THE PRINCE

Niccolò Machiavelli

Lucid Conversion
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A NOTE ON THE LUCID CONVERSION

This text is a Lucid conversion of Niccolò Machiavelli's *The Prince*, prepared from the Italian text. It is not a revision of any single existing English translation. The MetaLibri Italian edition edited by Sálvio M. Soares served as the primary working text and was compared with the Italian Wikisource transcription. The completed conversion was subsequently checked at materially significant passages against the critical Italian text established by Giorgio Inglese. Where textual differences affect meaning, argumentative structure, or interpretation, the preferred reading is identified in the accompanying notes.

This is not a new critical edition. Its textual purpose is more limited: to establish a sufficiently reliable Italian source for a structurally faithful conversion into present English. Bibliographical information for the Italian texts and other consulted resources appears in "Sources and Bibliography" at the end of Appendix B.

The word *conversion* is deliberate. A narrowly literal translation can preserve Machiavelli's surface grammar while obscuring the structure of his reasoning. A loose paraphrase can produce readable English by discarding qualifications, dependencies, ambiguities, or unsettling implications. The Lucid conversion seeks a position between these approaches: current, immediately intelligible English that preserves the complete argumentative structure of the source.

The word *Lucid* is used in the particular sense developed through the Hoffman–Joyce Continuum (DOI: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17517550). The Continuum describes controlled movement among three principal communicative conditions: the Lucid Pole, the Hybrid Current, and the Dream Pole. This conversion remains principally at the Lucid

Pole, where representation is stable, syntax is clear, and persons, actions, conditions, and consequences remain externally traceable.

The Hoffman–Joyce Continuum functions here as a compositional and diagnostic framework, not as an interpretive theory imposed upon Machiavelli. Its dimensions of Fit, Phase, and Dissolution help identify ways in which language may preserve, accelerate, compress, destabilize, or dissolve the reader's access to represented relations. In this conversion, the desired condition is high Fit between the Italian argument and its English articulation. Phase follows the movement of Machiavelli's reasoning rather than introducing an independent literary rhythm. Dissolution is not added for stylistic effect; ambiguity or instability is preserved only when it belongs to the source.

The Continuum is applied qualitatively rather than as a numerical or sentence-by-sentence scoring system. It establishes the target communicative condition and provides a vocabulary for examining departures from it. It does not determine what Machiavelli means, supply missing premises, settle deliberate ambiguities, or generate the later organizational interpretation.

The preservation constraints applied during conversion were also informed by the Lay Conversion Framework (LCF; DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19407981) and the Lay Conversion Specification (LCS; DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19407327). HJC establishes the desired communicative condition of the English articulation; LCF/LCS help govern the transformation by distinguishing changes in vocabulary, syntax, and sentence boundaries from changes that would remove claims, dependencies, scope conditions, ambiguity, epistemic posture, or sequence of evaluability. The present edition is not designated a lay conversion, and it does not claim exhaustive compliance with every LCS requirement. LCF/LCS are used here only as supporting preservation and audit constraints. Each chapter was processed in four stages. First, the Italian source text was established and material variants were identified. Second, the chapter was resolved into its substantive claims, conditions, contrasts, causal relations, examples, and conclusions. Third, those relations were expressed in contemporary English, dividing long sentences and clarifying referents where necessary without changing their logical dependence. Fourth, the resulting English was checked against the Italian for omitted claims, weakened qualifications, changed causal sequences, softened language, or interpretation inadvertently introduced as translation.

The controlling unit of fidelity was therefore not always the individual word or sentence. It was the distinction, relation, or dependency being established. An Italian sentence could be divided, its referent made explicit, or its clauses locally reordered when doing so allowed an English reader to recover more faithfully the structure available to a reader of Machiavelli's Italian. No substantive claim was intentionally added merely to make the reasoning appear more complete.

Certain Italian terms were retained when a single English equivalent would prematurely narrow them. These include *virtù*, *fortuna*, *stato*, *ordini*, *armi*, and *necessità*. Their meanings were determined contextually and explained in the accompanying notes. No

mechanically consistent English substitute was imposed where Machiavelli allowed a term to carry political, institutional, military, and personal meanings at once.

The conversion also preserves Machiavelli's rhetorical and moral severity. Words denoting destruction, cruelty, crime, coercion, betrayal, or subordination were not softened into administrative euphemisms. Historically situated religious or political language was retained when it belonged to Machiavelli's argument and identified in the notes when necessary. His compressed historical examples were rendered according to the function they perform in his text rather than silently rewritten according to later historical judgment.

Four layers are kept separate throughout this edition. The Lucid conversion presents what Machiavelli says. The textual and argumentative notes explain significant Italian terms, variants, historical references, translation decisions, and the explicit structure of Machiavelli's reasoning. The organizational notes reconstruct what that reasoning may reveal about political continuation, dependency, institutional retention, coercive capacity, and evaluability. The postchapter AC Weakening sections reduce selected organizational results to more general articulations.

The organizational reconstruction draws upon Admissibility Calculus (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.21982239) and Cohaerentia (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.18717795), collectively designated AC&C. AC&C terminology is not inserted into the conversion or attributed to Machiavelli. The organizational notes use the later AC&C framework to make explicit relations that Machiavelli himself repeatedly tracks without formalizing them in that vocabulary. They do not attribute AC&C's formal concepts or derivational apparatus to him; they do propose that his classifications, conditional comparisons, and analyses of dependency, necessity, continuation, and failure exhibit a related proto-organizational analytical technique.

Following each chapter, a postchapter section titled An AC Weakening asks how much historical and other particular articulation can be removed while preserving one or more organizational relations established by the chapter. Named persons, places, events, and local circumstances are progressively replaced by their functional relations, while the relevant conditions, dependencies, distinctions, and consequences are retained. The operation stops when further removal would alter the preserved result or leave it too indeterminate to perform the same analytical work.

Here, weakening does not mean softening Machiavelli's language or reducing the force of his claim. It means removing articulation that is not required for the selected organizational result. Each postchapter section presents an AC weakening, not a claim to have established the uniquely weakest possible formulation. These weakenings belong to the later organizational reconstruction; they are not part of the conversion and are not attributed to Machiavelli.

The conversion was produced through an AI-assisted collaborative process using OpenAI's ChatGPT under continuing human editorial direction. AI assistance was used

in examining Italian syntax, comparing textual readings, drafting and checking English formulations, and developing preliminary textual and organizational notes. The conversion standard, methodological constraints, interpretive boundaries, selection of final wording, and decision to publish remain matters of human authorship and editorial judgment.

AI-generated conclusions were not treated as textual evidence. Claims about Machiavelli remain answerable to the Italian source, and the conceptual claims made in the organizational notes remain answerable to their stated derivation. The purpose of disclosing the process is not to transfer interpretive authority to an automated system, but to make the collaboration inspectable: consequential source terms remain visible, material decisions are recorded, and later analysis is prevented from silently entering the translated text.

Readers seeking a direct encounter with Machiavelli's argument may proceed from the Dedication through Chapter XXVI, reading or passing over the postchapter AC Weakenings as desired. Appendices A and B provide the fuller textual, organizational, and methodological apparatus.

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NICCOLÒ MACHIAVELLI TO THE MAGNIFICENT LORENZO DE' MEDICI

Those who wish to gain favor with a prince usually approach him with one of two kinds of gift: something they themselves value most among their possessions, or something in which they see that he takes particular pleasure. Thus princes are often presented with horses, weapons, cloth of gold, precious stones, and similar ornaments considered worthy of their greatness.

Therefore, wishing to offer myself to Your Magnificence with some evidence of my service to you, I have found among my possessions nothing dearer to me, or more highly valued, than my knowledge of the actions of great men.

I acquired this knowledge through long experience of contemporary affairs and continuous study of ancient affairs. I have spent a long time carefully reflecting upon and examining both, and have now reduced what I learned to this small volume, which I send to Your Magnificence.

Although I judge this work unworthy to appear before you, I nevertheless trust that your humane generosity will lead you to accept it. I can give you no greater gift than the ability to understand, in a very short time, everything that I came to know and comprehend over so many years and through so many hardships and dangers.

I have not embellished this work or filled it with elaborate rhetorical periods, inflated and magnificent words, or any other verbal allure or external ornament with which many writers customarily describe and decorate their works. I intended no external feature to confer distinction upon it. Whatever makes it acceptable should arise only from the variety of its material and the gravity of its subject.

I do not want it to be regarded as presumption that a man of low and humble station dares to reason about princely governments and formulate rules for them.

Those who depict landscapes position themselves low on the plain in order to observe the nature of mountains and high places. To observe the nature of low places, they position themselves high upon the mountains.

In the same way, to know well the nature of peoples, one must be a prince; and to know well the nature of princes, one must be one of the people.

Accept, therefore, Your Magnificence, this small gift in the spirit in which I send it. If you carefully examine and read it, you will recognize within it my strongest desire: that you attain the greatness that *fortuna* and your other qualities promise you.

And if Your Magnificence, from the summit of your elevated position, should sometimes turn your eyes toward these low places, you will recognize how undeservedly I suffer under the great and continuing hostility of *fortuna*.

An AC Weakening

When the courtly address, particular gifts, and differences of rank are removed while the organizational relations are preserved:

A subordinate may seek a more favorable relation with a governing subject by converting accumulated experience and historical comparison into a compact contribution useful to that subject. The contribution derives its value from the relations it preserves, rather than from ornamental presentation or the status of its contributor. Because organizational access is position-relative, distinct positions disclose different aspects of the same organization.

Weaker still:

Organizational knowledge acquired from one position may be made available to another through a reduced articulation that preserves otherwise inaccessible relations.

CHAPTER I

THE KINDS OF PRINCIPALITIES AND THE WAYS THEY ARE ACQUIRED

Every state and every dominion that has exercised, or now exercises, rule over people is either a republic or a principality.

Every principality is either hereditary or new.

A principality is hereditary when its ruler's lineage has held princely authority there for a long time.

A new principality is of one of two kinds:

1. It is wholly new rather than an addition to a hereditary state already possessed by the acquiring prince, as Milan was for Francesco Sforza.

2. It is newly added as a component of the acquiring prince's hereditary state, as the Kingdom of Naples then was for the King of Spain.

For every dominion acquired in this way, three further distinctions apply:

1. Before its acquisition, its people were accustomed either to living under a prince or to living free.
2. It was acquired either with the military forces of others or with the acquiring prince's own forces.
3. It was acquired either through *fortuna* or through *virtù*.

An AC Weakening

When particular political forms and historical examples are removed while the classificatory relations are preserved:

An organization exercising rule is distinguishable by its governing form and by the continuity of that form. A newly acquired governing organization remains further distinguishable by whether it stands as a new organization or becomes a component of an already retained one; by the prior governing condition of those subjected to it; by whether the force enabling its acquisition was internally retained or externally supplied; and by whether acquisition depended principally upon exercised capacity or upon conditions not controlled by the acquirer.

Weaker still:

The present form of a governing organization does not exhaust its organizational character. Analytically relevant distinctions remain in its prior organization, its relation to an existing continuation, and the dependencies through which it was acquired.

CHAPTER II

HEREDITARY PRINCIPALITIES

I will leave aside the discussion of republics, because I have discussed them at length on another occasion.

I will turn only to principalities. Continuing to weave the threads laid out above, I will examine how these principalities can be governed and retained.

Hereditary states, whose people are accustomed to the bloodline of their prince, are much easier to retain than new states.

Only two things are required of the hereditary prince.

First, he must not depart from the established *ordine* of his ancestors.

Second, he must adapt his timing and conduct to circumstances as they arise.

If such a prince possesses ordinary practical competence, he will continue to hold his state unless an extraordinary and overwhelming force deprives him of it. Even if he is deprived of it, he will recover it whenever adversity befalls the occupier.

Italy provides the example of the Duke of Ferrara. He withstood the assaults of the Venetians in 1484 and of Pope Julius in 1510 for no reason other than that his rule in that dominion had long been established.

A hereditary prince has fewer causes and less necessity to injure those he rules. It therefore follows that he will be more loved.

Unless extraordinary vices cause his people to hate him, it is reasonable that his own people should be naturally well disposed toward him.

Under long-established and continuous rule, memories and causes of political innovation are extinguished.

Every political change leaves behind an attachment point—an *addentellato*—upon which another change can be built.

An AC Weakening

When hereditary lineage, particular rulers, and historical events are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A long-retained governing continuation is easier to preserve when those governed have become accustomed to its organizing order. Its successor ordinarily needs only to preserve that inherited order while adapting conduct to changing circumstances. Established continuity reduces the need to impose injurious changes and diminishes the retained causes of alternative rule, unless the ruler introduces an extraordinary incompatibility or an overwhelming external force intervenes. External displacement need not eliminate the recoverability of the prior continuation, while the disruption itself creates an attachment point from which further disruption can proceed.

Weaker still:

Long-retained organizational continuity reduces both the burdens of preservation and the availability of alternatives. Organizational change, once introduced, creates retained availability for further change.

CHAPTER III

MIXED PRINCIPALITIES

But the difficulties lie in a new principality. First, if it is not wholly new but has been joined to an existing principality as one of its members—so that the whole may be called, in a sense, mixed—its initial upheavals arise from a natural difficulty common to all new principalities.

People willingly change rulers because they believe they will improve their condition. This belief makes them take up arms against whoever governs them. But in this they deceive themselves, because experience later shows them that they have made things worse.

This outcome follows from another natural and ordinary necessity: whoever becomes a new prince must always injure his new subjects, both through the presence of armed forces and through the countless other injuries that a new acquisition brings with it.

Thus, in occupying a principality, you make enemies of everyone you have injured. At the same time, you cannot keep as friends those who placed you there, because you cannot satisfy them in the way they expected. Nor, because you are indebted to them, can you use strong remedies against them. For no matter how strong a ruler may be in military forces, he always needs the favor of the local population in order to enter a territory.

For these reasons Louis XII, King of France, took Milan immediately and lost it just as quickly. The first time, Ludovico Sforza's forces alone were enough to take it from him. The people who had opened the gates to Louis discovered that they had been deceived in their expectations and in the future benefits they had anticipated. They could not endure the burdens imposed by the new prince.

It is nevertheless true that when a rebellious territory is acquired for a second time, it is harder to lose. The ruler can seize the occasion provided by the rebellion and act with less restraint in securing himself: he can punish offenders, identify suspected opponents, and strengthen his weakest positions.

Thus, although the first time a disturbance raised on the frontier by Duke Ludovico was enough to make France lose Milan, the second time it required the whole world to be arrayed against France, and the French armies had to be destroyed and driven out of Italy. This followed from the causes given above. Nevertheless, Milan was taken from France both the first and the second time.

The general causes of the first loss have now been discussed. It remains to examine those of the second, and to say what remedies Louis had available—and what remedies any

ruler in his position might have used—to hold an acquisition more successfully than the King of France did.

I say, then, that states which are acquired and added to a ruler's established state are either in the same region and speak the same language, or they are not.

When they are, they are very easy to hold, especially if they are not accustomed to living in freedom. To possess them securely, it is enough to extinguish the bloodline of the prince who formerly ruled them. Provided that their existing conditions are otherwise maintained, and that there is no great difference in customs, the inhabitants will live quietly.

This can be seen in Burgundy, Brittany, Gascony, and Normandy, which have belonged to France for so long. Although there are some differences of language, their customs are similar, and they can easily accommodate one another.

Whoever acquires such territories and wishes to keep them must observe two precautions. First, the bloodline of their former prince must be extinguished. Second, neither their laws nor their taxes must be altered. In this way, the new territory and the ruler's established principality soon become one body.

But when states are acquired in a region unlike the ruler's own in language, customs, and political arrangements—its *ordini*—then the difficulties appear. To hold them requires great *fortuna* and great *industria*.

One of the greatest and most effective remedies would be for the person who acquires the territory to go and live there.

This would make possession more secure and more lasting, as the Turkish ruler has done in Greece. Even with all the other arrangements he has used to hold that territory, he could not possibly have kept it had he not gone to live there.

When you are present, you see disorders as they arise and can remedy them quickly. When you are absent, you hear of them only after they have grown large and can no longer be remedied.

Moreover, the territory is not stripped bare by your officials. The subjects are satisfied because they have immediate access to the prince. If they intend to behave loyally, they therefore have more reason to love him; if they intend otherwise, they have more reason to fear him.

Any foreign power wishing to attack that state will proceed more cautiously. So long as the prince lives there, he can lose it only with the greatest difficulty.

The other excellent remedy is to establish colonies in one or two places, serving almost as fetters that bind the territory. Otherwise, it will be necessary to maintain a large force of cavalry and infantry there.

Colonies cost the prince little. At no expense, or almost none, he can establish and maintain them. He injures only those whose fields and houses he takes in order to give them to the new settlers, and these people constitute only a very small part of the state.

Those he injures are left scattered and impoverished, and therefore can never harm him. Everyone else remains uninjured and should therefore stay quiet; at the same time, they are afraid to step out of line, lest what happened to those who were dispossessed should also happen to them.

I conclude that colonies cost little, are more loyal, and injure fewer people. Those who are injured cannot retaliate because they have been impoverished and dispersed.

For it must be noted that people must either be treated with favor or extinguished. They can avenge slight injuries, but they cannot avenge grave ones. An injury must therefore be inflicted in such a way that there is no reason to fear revenge.

But if, instead of colonies, you maintain armed forces in the territory, you will spend far more. The entire revenue of the state will be consumed in guarding it, so that the acquisition becomes a loss.

You will also injure far more people, because the whole territory suffers as your army is moved among its lodgings. Everyone feels this hardship, and everyone becomes your enemy. These enemies can harm you because, although beaten down, they remain in their own homes.

From every direction, then, this kind of military occupation is as useless as colonies are useful.

A ruler governing a region unlike his own must also make himself the leader and defender of its less powerful neighbors. He must work to weaken the more powerful rulers within it, and he must take care that no foreign power as strong as himself is allowed to enter.

Such a foreign power will always be brought in by people who are dissatisfied, whether through excessive ambition or through fear. Thus the Aetolians brought the Romans into Greece; and in every other territory the Romans entered, they were invited by some of its inhabitants.

The normal course of events is that, as soon as a powerful foreign ruler enters a region, all its lesser powers attach themselves to him. They are moved by the envy they bear toward the ruler who had previously been powerful over them.

The newcomer therefore has no difficulty winning these lesser powers. They all willingly rally to the state he has acquired. He need only take care that they do not acquire too much strength or authority.

With his own forces and their support, he can easily reduce the more powerful rulers and remain the sole arbiter of the region. Whoever fails to manage this relationship properly will quickly lose what he has acquired; and while he still holds it, he will face endless difficulties and troubles.

The Romans carefully observed all these principles in the territories they conquered. They established colonies, maintained the lesser powers without allowing their power to increase, reduced the greater powers, and did not allow powerful foreigners to establish influence there.

The province of Greece alone will suffice as an example. The Romans kept the Achaeans and Aetolians in alliance; they reduced the kingdom of Macedonia; and they drove out Antiochus.

No services performed by the Achaeans or Aetolians ever caused the Romans to permit them to enlarge their states. Philip's appeals never persuaded the Romans to become his friends without first reducing his power. Nor could the power of Antiochus make them consent to his holding any territory in that region.

For in these matters the Romans did what all wise princes should do. They considered not only present disorders but future ones, and they used every practical means to prevent them.

When dangers are foreseen from a distance, they can easily be remedied. But if you wait until they draw near, the medicine comes too late, because the disease has become incurable.

It happens here as physicians say it happens with a wasting fever: at the beginning the disease is easy to cure but difficult to recognize; with the passage of time, if it was neither recognized nor treated at the beginning, it becomes easy to recognize but difficult to cure.

So it is with political affairs. When the evils arising within a state are recognized from a distance—a capacity given only to a prudent ruler—they can be cured quickly. But when they have not been recognized and are allowed to grow until everyone can see them, there is no longer any remedy.

Because the Romans saw dangers from a distance, they always acted against them. They never allowed a danger to develop merely to avoid a war, because they knew that war is not eliminated by postponement: it is merely deferred to the advantage of others.

They therefore chose to wage war against Philip and Antiochus in Greece, so that they would not later have to fight them in Italy. At the time, the Romans could have avoided both wars, but they chose not to.

They were never pleased by the maxim constantly repeated by the wise men of our own time: "Enjoy the benefits of time." They preferred instead the benefits of their own *virtù* and prudence. For time sweeps everything forward, and can bring evil together with good, and good together with evil.

But let us return to France and examine whether it followed any of these principles. I shall speak of Louis rather than Charles, because Louis held possessions in Italy for longer, allowing his conduct to be seen more clearly. You will see that he did the opposite of everything that must be done to hold a state unlike one's own.

King Louis was brought into Italy by the ambition of the Venetians, who intended, through his arrival, to acquire half of Lombardy.

I do not wish to blame the king for entering Italy or for making this alliance. He wanted to establish an initial foothold in Italy, but he had no friends there. Indeed, because of King Charles's conduct, every door had been closed to him. He was therefore forced to accept whatever alliances he could obtain.

His plan would have succeeded if he had made no errors in his subsequent dealings.

Once Louis had acquired Lombardy, he immediately recovered the standing France had lost under Charles. Genoa yielded. The Florentines became his friends. The Marquis of Mantua, the Duke of Ferrara, Bentivoglio, the Lady of Forlì, the rulers of Faenza, Pesaro, Rimini, Camerino, and Piombino, and the Lucchese, Pisans, and Sienese—all came forward seeking his friendship.

The Venetians could then see the recklessness of their decision. In order to acquire two towns in Lombardy, they had made the King of France master of two-thirds of Italy.

Consider how little difficulty the king would have had in maintaining his position in Italy if he had followed the rules given above and had kept all these friends safe and protected.

They were numerous, weak, and fearful—some of the Church, others of the Venetians. They therefore had no choice but to remain with Louis. Through them he could easily have secured himself against the great powers that remained.

But no sooner had Louis entered Milan than he did the opposite. He helped Pope Alexander VI take possession of Romagna.

He failed to see that this decision weakened him. He deprived himself of his friends and of those who had thrown themselves into his arms, while making the Church powerful by

adding substantial temporal power to the spiritual authority that already gave it such influence.

Having made this first error, Louis was forced to continue along the same course. Eventually, in order to restrain Alexander's ambition and prevent him from becoming master of Tuscany, Louis was compelled to return to Italy.

It was not enough for him to have made the Church powerful and deprived himself of his friends. Because he desired the Kingdom of Naples, he divided it with the King of Spain.

Where Louis had previously been the sole arbiter of Italy, he introduced a partner. He thereby gave the ambitious people of Italy, and those dissatisfied with him, another power to whom they could appeal.

Where he could have left in Naples a king dependent upon him, he drove that king out and installed someone capable of driving Louis himself out.

The desire to acquire is certainly very natural and ordinary. Whenever people acquire what they have the capacity to acquire, they will be praised rather than blamed. But when they lack the capacity and nevertheless insist upon acquiring at any cost, there lies the error and the blame.

If France could have attacked Naples with its own forces, it should have done so. If it could not, it should not have divided the kingdom.

France's division of Lombardy with the Venetians deserved some excuse, because it gave France a foothold in Italy. But the division of Naples deserved blame, because it was not excused by any such necessity.

Louis had therefore committed five errors: he eliminated the lesser powers; increased the strength of a power already strong in Italy; introduced an exceedingly powerful foreign ruler; failed to live in Italy himself; and failed to establish colonies there.

These errors might still not have harmed him during his lifetime had he not committed a sixth: taking the Venetian state from the Venetians.

If Louis had not strengthened the Church or brought Spain into Italy, it would have been reasonable and necessary to reduce Venetian power. But once he had taken those earlier decisions, he should never have permitted Venice to be ruined.

So long as the Venetians remained powerful, they would have kept other powers away from Lombardy. Venice would not have permitted anyone to take Lombardy unless Venice itself became its master. Other powers would not have wished to take Lombardy from France merely to give it to Venice, and none would have had the courage to attack France and Venice together.

If someone should say that King Louis conceded Romagna to Alexander and the Kingdom of Naples to Spain in order to avoid war, I answer with the reasons already given: a disorder should never be allowed to develop merely to avoid a war. The war is not avoided; it is only postponed to your disadvantage.

If someone else should cite the promise Louis had given the pope—to assist him in that enterprise in return for the annulment of Louis's marriage and the cardinal's hat for the Archbishop of Rouen—I answer with what I shall say below concerning the promises of princes and how they should be observed.

King Louis therefore lost Lombardy because he observed none of the methods used by others who had conquered territories and intended to keep them. There is nothing miraculous about this. It is entirely reasonable and ordinary.

I discussed this matter at Nantes with the Cardinal of Rouen, while Duke Valentino—as Cesare Borgia, the son of Pope Alexander, was commonly called—was taking possession of Romagna.

When the cardinal told me that the Italians did not understand warfare, I replied that the French did not understand statecraft. If they had understood it, they would never have allowed the Church to grow so powerful.

Experience has shown that the power of the Church and of Spain in Italy was produced by France, and that France's ruin in Italy was produced by them.

From this we may draw a general rule which never, or only rarely, fails:

Whoever causes another to become powerful causes his own ruin. For that power was created by him either through practical skill or through force—and the person who has become powerful must suspect both the skill and the force that raised him.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, territories, and historical examples are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing organization newly attached to an existing continuation is initially unstable. Its acquisition commonly depends upon contributors expecting improvement, while its establishment imposes injuries and burdens that frustrate those expectations. The acquirer thereby produces enemies among those injured without remaining able to satisfy or freely suppress those whose contribution enabled entry. Reacquisition after rebellion may permit stronger consolidation because opposition has become identifiable and the ruler can act with fewer constraints.

The transformation required for retention varies with the difference between the acquiring and acquired organizations. Where their language, customs, and governing

arrangements are compatible, eliminating the former ruling continuation while preserving established laws and burdens can permit their incorporation into one body. Where their organizational arrangements differ, retention requires greater accessibility and control. Direct presence improves the early detection and correction of disorder, restricts intermediary abuse, gives the governed access to the ruler, and increases the cost of external intervention. Colonization creates embedded points of control by dispossessing a limited group and depriving it of retaliatory capacity; continuing military occupation distributes injury and expense throughout the acquired organization, producing numerous opponents who remain locally capable of retaliation.

An acquisition also alters the surrounding organization of power. Its preservation requires the acquirer to retain weaker contributing powers without allowing them to become independently dominant, reduce stronger competing powers, and prevent an equivalent external power from acquiring a local point of entry. Dissatisfied local organizations make such entry available. Emerging threats are therefore most remediable while their articulation is still limited; delay does not eliminate the conflict but allows the opposing continuation to acquire greater capacity.

Earlier choices alter the conditions under which later choices remain effective. A relation necessary for initial entry may become destructive if repeated after that entry has been secured. Weakening a former counterweight may become inadmissible after other rivals have been strengthened. Errors can consequently produce new dependencies that compel further errors. Acquisition beyond the acquirer's retained capacity, or the transfer of sufficient capacity to another organization, can transform an instrument or ally into an independent rival capable of terminating the continuation that enabled it.

Weaker still:

The retention of an acquired governing continuation depends upon keeping imposed change, distributed injury, informational delay, retaliatory capacity, and surrounding concentrations of power within the acquirer's capacities. An acquirer undermines its own continuation when it frustrates the contributors who enabled entry, generalizes opposition, permits disorders to grow beyond remedy, destroys necessary counterweights, or enables another organization to become independently more powerful.

CHAPTER IV

WHY THE KINGDOM OF DARIUS, CONQUERED BY ALEXANDER, DID NOT REBEL AGAINST ALEXANDER'S SUCCESSORS AFTER HIS DEATH

Considering the difficulties involved in holding a newly acquired state, someone might wonder how Alexander the Great became master of Asia within a few years and then died almost immediately after conquering it.

It would seem reasonable that the whole state should have rebelled. Nevertheless, Alexander's successors retained it, and they encountered no difficulty in holding it except that which arose among themselves from their own ambition.

I answer that the principalities known to history have been governed in two different ways.

In the first, one prince governs and everyone else is his servant. These servants assist him in governing the kingdom as ministers only through his favor and permission.

In the second, a prince governs together with hereditary barons, who hold their rank not through the ruler's favor but through the antiquity of their bloodlines. These barons have domains and subjects of their own. Their subjects recognize them as rulers and possess a deep-rooted attachment to them.

In states governed by one prince and his servants, the prince possesses greater authority. Throughout his territory, no one recognizes anyone but him as superior. If the people obey someone else, they do so only because that person is the prince's minister or official; they feel no particular personal loyalty toward him.

In our own time, examples of these two different forms of government are the Ottoman sultan and the King of France.

The entire Ottoman monarchy is governed by one ruler. Everyone else is his servant. The ruler divides his kingdom into *sanjaks*, sends different administrators to govern them, and replaces or transfers those administrators as he chooses.

The King of France, by contrast, stands among a long-established multitude of lords who are recognized and loved by their own subjects. These lords possess hereditary prerogatives that the king cannot take from them without placing himself in danger.

Anyone who considers these two kinds of state will find that the Ottoman state is difficult to conquer but, once conquered, very easy to hold.

The Ottoman kingdom is difficult to conquer because an invader cannot be invited in by autonomous princes within the kingdom. Nor can he expect a rebellion among the ruler's surrounding officials to make his undertaking easier.

This follows from the reasons already given. Because they are all dependent upon and bound to the ruler, they are more difficult to corrupt. Even if they were corrupted, little advantage could be expected from them, because they cannot bring the population with them.

Anyone who attacks the Ottoman ruler must therefore expect to find the entire state united. He must place greater hope in his own forces than in disorders arising among his enemy.

But once the Ottoman ruler has been defeated and broken in the field so completely that he cannot rebuild his armies, the victor has nothing further to fear except the ruling dynasty.

Once that bloodline has been extinguished, no one else remains who needs to be feared, because the ruler's officials possess no independent authority among the population. Just as the conqueror could place no hope in them before his victory, he has no reason to fear them afterward.

The opposite occurs in kingdoms governed like France.

You can enter such a kingdom easily by winning over one of its barons, because malcontents and people who desire political change can always be found. For the reasons already given, they can open the way into the state and make your victory easier.

But if you then wish to hold the kingdom, that victory brings endless difficulties—both with those who helped you and with those whom you have oppressed.

Nor is it enough to extinguish the ruling prince's bloodline. The hereditary lords remain, and they can make themselves leaders of new disturbances. Because you can neither satisfy all of them nor extinguish all of them, you will lose the state whenever an opportunity arises.

Now, if you consider the character of Darius's government, you will find that it resembled the Ottoman kingdom.

Alexander therefore had first to attack it as one united structure and defeat it in the field. After that victory, and after Darius's death, the state remained secure in Alexander's possession for the reasons already explained.

If Alexander's successors had remained united, they could have enjoyed the kingdom peacefully. No disturbances arose within it except those they themselves produced.

But states organized like France cannot be possessed with such tranquility.

This explains the frequent rebellions against the Romans in Spain, France, and Greece. Those territories contained numerous established principalities. As long as the memory of those principalities survived, the Romans remained uncertain of their possession.

But once the memory of those former rulers had been extinguished through the power and long duration of Roman rule, the Romans became secure possessors.

Later, when the Romans fought among themselves, each Roman leader could bring part of those provinces over to his side in proportion to the authority he had established there. Because the bloodlines of their former rulers had been extinguished, the inhabitants recognized no rulers other than Romans.

Considering all these things, no one should be surprised by the ease with which Alexander held the state of Asia, or by the difficulties others—such as Pyrrhus and many more—experienced in preserving what they had acquired.

This difference arose not from the greater or lesser *virtù* of the conqueror, but from the different structural character of what was conquered.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, inherited titles, and historical examples are removed while the organizational structure is preserved:

A governing organization may concentrate authority in a single ruling continuation whose subordinate officials possess no independently retained authority, or it may distribute authority among established local continuations whose members recognize them directly and remain attached to them.

Concentrated authority provides few internal points through which an external organization can enter. Because subordinate officials depend upon the central ruler and cannot independently mobilize the governed population, an acquirer must confront the governing organization as a united structure. Once its central continuation and succession have been eliminated, however, few independently recognized authorities remain from which resistance can be organized. The structure is therefore difficult to acquire but comparatively easy to retain.

Distributed authority produces the inverse condition. Independently recognized local powers provide dissatisfied members and external acquirers with multiple points of entry, making initial acquisition easier. Those same local continuations survive the defeat of the central ruler and retain the recognition, attachment, and mobilizing capacity required for subsequent resistance. Because the acquirer can neither satisfy nor eliminate every such continuation, initial victory does not produce secure possession.

Extended rule can gradually extinguish the remembered availability of displaced governing continuations. Once those alternatives and their lines of succession are no longer retained, the population recognizes only the replacement organization. Subsequent instability then arises primarily from divisions within that organization rather than from restoration of the organizations it displaced.

Weaker still:

The distribution of independently retained authority produces an inverse relation between acquisition and preservation. A governing organization with few internal entry points may be difficult to penetrate but easy to replace once its center is eliminated; an organization with many internal entry points may be easy to penetrate but difficult to consolidate because those points remain available for resistance.

CHAPTER V

HOW TO GOVERN CITIES OR PRINCIPALITIES THAT LIVED UNDER THEIR OWN LAWS BEFORE BEING CONQUERED

When newly acquired states have been accustomed to living under their own laws and in freedom, there are three ways to hold them.

The first is to destroy them.

The second is to go and live there personally.

The third is to allow them to continue living under their own laws, while extracting tribute and establishing within them a government controlled by a few citizens who will keep the state friendly to you.

Because that government was created by the conquering prince, it knows that it cannot survive without his friendship and power. It will therefore do everything necessary to preserve his rule.

If a city accustomed to living freely is to be preserved rather than destroyed, it can be held more easily through the agency of its own citizens than in any other way.

Consider the examples of the Spartans and the Romans.

The Spartans held Athens and Thebes by establishing governments controlled by a few citizens. Nevertheless, they lost both cities.

The Romans, in order to hold Capua, Carthage, and Numantia, destroyed them—and did not lose them.

The Romans later attempted to hold Greece in almost the same way the Spartans had: they allowed it to remain free and retain its own laws. This did not succeed. They were therefore compelled to destroy many cities in that region in order to hold it.

For in truth, there is no secure way to possess cities accustomed to freedom except to destroy them.

Whoever becomes master of a city accustomed to living freely and does not destroy it should expect to be destroyed by it.

Such a city can always take refuge, when it rebels, in the name of liberty and in its ancient political institutions—its *ordini*. Neither the passage of time nor benefits received will ever cause these to be forgotten.

Whatever the conqueror does, and whatever precautions he takes, unless the inhabitants are divided or dispersed, they will not forget that name or those institutions. At the first opportunity, they will immediately return to them.

This is what Pisa did after it had been held in servitude by the Florentines for many years.

But when cities or provinces have been accustomed to living under a prince, and that prince's bloodline has been extinguished, their situation is different.

On the one hand, they are accustomed to obeying. On the other, they no longer have their former prince. They cannot agree among themselves upon choosing a new prince, and they do not know how to live in freedom.

They are therefore slower to take up arms. A new prince can win them over and make himself secure against them more easily.

But in republics there is greater hatred and a greater desire for revenge. The memory of their former freedom does not—and cannot—allow them to rest.

The safest course, therefore, is either to extinguish them or to live there.

An AC Weakening

When named cities, conquerors, and historically particular forms are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A previously self-governing organization retains within its laws, institutions, practices, and shared political memory the means of reconstructing its former continuation. Conquest can suppress that continuation without making it organizationally unavailable. When the constraining power weakens, the retained name and institutions of freedom provide a common reference through which resistance can be coordinated and the prior organization resumed.

A dependent internal government may help an external ruler administer such an organization because its own continuation depends upon the ruler who created it. That dependency, however, does not necessarily eliminate the wider population's retained access to its former order. Benefits conferred by the new ruler and the mere passage of time are insufficient while the people, institutions, and coordinating distinctions required for restoration remain available.

Continuous direct presence can constrain this alternative continuation as attempts to recover it arise. Destruction or dispersion operates more radically by eliminating the people and relations through which the prior continuation could be reconstructed. Machiavelli therefore treats the destruction of the acquired organization—not merely the defeat of its present government—as the only fully secure means of making its independent continuation unavailable.

A population previously organized around a single hereditary ruler presents a different structure. Once that ruling continuation has been eliminated, the population retains the practice of obedience but lacks an agreed center through which the former government can be restored. If it has not retained the institutions and coordinative capacities of self-government, it also lacks an immediately available alternative continuation. The acquiring ruler can therefore substitute himself more readily.

Weaker still:

A suppressed organization remains recoverable while its members retain access to the distinctions, institutions, and coordinative capacities required to reconstruct it. External replacement remains insecure while that alternative continuation stays organizationally available.

CHAPTER VI

NEW PRINCIPALITIES ACQUIRED THROUGH ONE'S OWN ARMS AND *VIRTÙ*

No one should be surprised if, in speaking of principalities that are entirely new—new both in their prince and in their political state—I introduce examples drawn from the greatest founders.

People almost always travel along roads already beaten by others and proceed in their actions through imitation. Yet they cannot follow another person's path exactly, nor can they equal the *virtù* of the person they imitate.

A prudent person should therefore always enter upon paths traveled by great people and imitate those who have been most excellent. In this way, even if his own *virtù* does not equal theirs, it may at least carry some trace of them.

He should act like a prudent archer. When the place he intends to strike appears too distant, and he knows the effective range of his bow, he aims far above the intended target—not because he expects his arrow to reach that height, but because so elevated an aim enables him to reach his actual target.

I say, then, that in entirely new principalities governed by entirely new princes, the difficulty of maintaining them varies according to the greater or lesser *virtù* of the person who acquires them.

Because the transition from private citizen to prince presupposes either *virtù* or *fortuna*, it would seem that either one can mitigate many of the difficulties. Nevertheless, those who have relied less upon *fortuna* have generally proved more durable.

It also makes matters easier when the prince, having no other state, is forced to reside personally in the one he has acquired.

But to consider those who became princes through their own *virtù* rather than through *fortuna*, I say that the most excellent were Moses, Cyrus, Romulus, Theseus, and others like them.

Strictly speaking, Moses should not be included in this discussion, since he was only carrying out what God had commanded. Nevertheless, he deserves admiration for the grace that made him worthy of speaking with God.

But if we consider Cyrus and the others who acquired or founded kingdoms, we shall find them all admirable. If their particular actions and institutions are examined, they will not appear different from those of Moses, although Moses had so great a teacher.

Examining their actions and lives, we see that they received nothing from *fortuna* except the opportunity—the *occasione*—that supplied them with material into which they could introduce whatever form they judged appropriate.

Without that opportunity, the *virtù* of their spirit would have been extinguished. Without their *virtù*, the opportunity would have arrived in vain.

It was therefore necessary for Moses to find the people of Israel enslaved in Egypt and oppressed by the Egyptians, so that, wishing to escape servitude, they would be prepared to follow him.

For Romulus to become King of Rome and founder of that homeland, it was necessary that he be unable to remain in Alba and that he be abandoned at birth.

Cyrus needed to find the Persians dissatisfied with the rule of the Medes, and the Medes softened and enervated by a long peace.

Theseus could not have demonstrated his *virtù* had he not found the Athenians dispersed.

These opportunities made those men successful, while their exceptional *virtù* enabled them to recognize the opportunities. Through this conjunction, their homelands were ennobled and became exceedingly prosperous.

Those who become princes through paths of *virtù* like these acquire their principalities with difficulty but hold them with ease.

The difficulties they experience in acquiring their principalities arise partly from the new institutions and methods—the new *ordini e modi*—that they are compelled to introduce in order to establish their state and secure themselves.

It must be understood that nothing is more difficult to undertake, more uncertain of success, or more dangerous to manage than to place oneself at the head of the introduction of new institutions.

The innovator has as enemies everyone who benefited from the old institutions. He has only lukewarm defenders among those who might benefit from the new ones.

This lukewarmness arises partly from fear of the opponents, who have the existing laws on their side, and partly from people's disbelief. People do not genuinely trust something new until they have seen it confirmed by reliable experience.

Consequently, whenever the enemies of the new order have an opportunity to attack, they do so with partisan determination. Those who might benefit from the new order defend it only lukewarmly. The innovator and his supporters are therefore placed in danger together.

To examine this matter properly, we must distinguish between innovators who stand through their own power and those who depend upon others. That is, we must ask whether they must plead for cooperation in order to carry out their undertaking, or whether they possess the power to compel it.

In the first case, they always come to a bad end and accomplish nothing.

But when they depend upon themselves and possess the power to compel, they are only rarely endangered.

From this arises the fact that all armed prophets have conquered, while unarmed prophets have been ruined.

For besides everything already said, the disposition of peoples is changeable. It is easy to persuade them of something, but difficult to keep them fixed in that persuasion.

Affairs must therefore be arranged so that when people no longer believe willingly, they can be made to continue believing by force.

Moses, Cyrus, Theseus, and Romulus could not have secured prolonged observance of their constitutions had they been unarmed.

In our own time, this is what happened to Friar Girolamo Savonarola. He was ruined together with his new institutions as soon as the multitude began to cease believing in him. He possessed no means of holding firm those who had believed, or of making the unbelievers believe.

Founders of this kind therefore encounter great difficulties while carrying out their work. All their dangers lie along the way, and they must overcome them through *virtù*.

But once they have overcome those dangers and have begun to be held in reverence—having extinguished those of comparable standing who envied them—they remain powerful, secure, honored, and prosperous.

To these great examples I wish to add a lesser one. It nevertheless bears some proportion to them and may stand for all other similar examples: Hiero of Syracuse.

Hiero rose from private citizen to Prince of Syracuse. He received nothing from *fortuna* except the opportunity.

The Syracusans, being oppressed, chose him as their military commander. From that position, he merited being made their prince.

Even as a private citizen he possessed such *virtù* that a writer said of him that he lacked nothing necessary for ruling except a kingdom to rule.

Hiero disbanded the old military force and organized a new one. He abandoned the old alliances and formed new ones.

Once he possessed alliances and soldiers that were his own, he could build any structure upon that foundation.

He therefore endured great difficulty in acquiring his principality and little difficulty in maintaining it.

An AC Weakening

When named founders, states, and exemplary histories are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

Previously successful continuations provide paths that later agents can follow, but they cannot be reproduced exactly because the capacities of the agent and the conditions of the undertaking differ. An exemplary continuation can nevertheless orient action beyond what the agent would otherwise attain, just as an elevated aim can compensate for limited effective range.

An entirely new governing continuation requires the conjunction of opportunity and exercised capacity. Opportunity makes previously unavailable material and relations accessible; virtù recognizes that availability and organizes it into a new form. Opportunity without sufficient virtù remains unrealized, while virtù without an available opportunity lacks material through which it can become organizationally effective. Because opportunity is externally supplied while virtù belongs to the founder's retained capacity, organizations founded with less continuing dependence upon fortuna are generally more durable.

Institutional innovation initially produces an asymmetry of commitment. Those who benefit from the established order possess definite interests, existing laws, and an already organized basis for resistance. Those who might benefit from the proposed order possess only an anticipated benefit that has not yet been confirmed by experience. The old order therefore has determined defenders, while the new order has conditional and weakly committed contributors.

A founder who depends upon those uncertain contributors or upon powers retained by the existing order cannot reliably complete the transformation. Persuasion may initiate a new continuation, but changing belief cannot preserve it indefinitely. Machiavelli therefore treats independently retained coercive capacity as the means by which observance is continued after voluntary belief declines. Once the new institutions have been confirmed through experience, comparable rival centers have been eliminated, and the founder possesses forces and alliances that depend upon the new organization rather than the old one, the continuation becomes comparatively easy to preserve.

Weaker still:

A novel organizational continuation becomes durable when an available opportunity is converted, through internally retained capacity, into institutions, enforcement, and dependencies that no longer rely upon the prior organization or upon the continuing voluntary commitment of its initial contributors.

CHAPTER VII

NEW PRINCIPALITIES ACQUIRED THROUGH THE FORCES OF OTHERS AND THROUGH *FORTUNA*

Those who rise from private citizens to princes solely through *fortuna* do so with little effort, but they maintain themselves only with great effort.

They encounter no difficulties along the way because they fly to their destination. All their difficulties arise after they have been placed there.

Such rulers are those who receive a state either through money or through the favor of the person granting it. This happened to many men in the Greek cities of Ionia and the Hellespont, where Darius made them princes so that they would govern those cities for his security and glory.

The same was true of those Roman emperors who rose from private station to imperial power by corrupting the soldiers.

Such rulers depend entirely upon the will and *fortuna* of the person who made them great—two exceedingly changeable and unstable things.

They neither know how nor possess the power to maintain their position.

They do not know how because, unless a person possesses exceptional intelligence and *virtù*, it is unreasonable to expect someone who has always lived as a private citizen to know how to command.

They do not possess the power because they have no armed forces that can be loyal and faithful to them.

Moreover, states that arise suddenly resemble all other natural things that are born and grow quickly. They cannot develop roots and supporting connections strong enough to prevent the first adverse weather from destroying them.

The exception occurs when those who have suddenly become princes possess such *virtù* that they immediately know how to prepare themselves to preserve what *fortuna* has placed in their laps. They must construct afterward the foundations that other rulers constructed before becoming princes.

From our own time I wish to provide two examples of these different ways of becoming a prince—one through *virtù* and the other through *fortuna*: Francesco Sforza and Cesare Borgia.

Through appropriate means and his own great *virtù*, Francesco Sforza rose from private citizen to Duke of Milan. What he acquired through a thousand hardships, he maintained with little effort.

Cesare Borgia, commonly called Duke Valentino, acquired his state through the *fortuna* of his father, Pope Alexander VI, and lost it when that *fortuna* disappeared.

This happened despite the fact that Borgia used every effort and did everything a prudent and capable ruler should do in order to establish roots within states granted to him by the arms and *fortuna* of others.

For, as I said above, someone who does not construct his foundations beforehand may still construct them afterward if he possesses great *virtù*—although this causes hardship for the architect and places the building in danger.

If we consider all the duke's actions, we shall see that he constructed substantial foundations for his future power.

I do not consider it superfluous to examine them, because I know of no better instruction for a new prince than the example of Borgia's actions. If his arrangements ultimately failed to benefit him, this was not because of any defect in them, but because of an extraordinary and extreme hostility of *fortuna*.

When Alexander VI sought to make his son powerful, he faced many immediate and future difficulties.

First, he saw no way to make Borgia ruler of any state unless it was a possession of the Church. Yet he knew that the Duke of Milan and the Venetians would not permit him to take such a state, because Faenza and Rimini were already under Venetian protection.

Furthermore, the military forces of Italy—and especially those forces he might have employed—were controlled by people who had reason to fear an increase in papal power. He could not trust them because they were all in the hands of the Orsini, the Colonna, and their followers.

It was therefore necessary to disrupt the existing political arrangements and throw the Italian states into disorder so that Alexander could securely seize part of them.

This proved easy because he found that the Venetians, moved by other considerations, had decided to bring the French back into Italy.

Alexander not only refrained from opposing this but facilitated it by annulling King Louis's former marriage.

The king therefore entered Italy with Venetian assistance and Alexander's consent. No sooner had Louis reached Milan than the pope obtained troops from him for the campaign in Romagna. The king agreed to the campaign because of the authority and standing he possessed.

Having acquired Romagna and defeated the Colonna faction, the duke wished both to retain Romagna and to advance farther. Two things obstructed him.

The first was his own military forces, which did not appear faithful to him.

The second was the will of France.

Borgia feared that the Orsini forces he had employed would fail him—that they would not only prevent further acquisitions but take away what he had already acquired. He feared that the King of France might do the same.

He received evidence of the Orsini's unreliability when, after conquering Faenza, he attacked Bologna and saw them proceed halfheartedly in the assault.

He discovered the king's intentions after taking the Duchy of Urbino, when he moved against Tuscany and the king forced him to abandon the undertaking.

The duke therefore decided that he would no longer depend upon the *fortuna* or arms of others.

His first action was to weaken the Orsini and Colonna factions in Rome. He won over all the noblemen who supported those families, making them his own gentlemen and granting them generous stipends.

He honored them according to their abilities by giving them military commands and governmental offices. Within a few months, their attachment to their former factions had been extinguished and redirected entirely toward the duke.

After dispersing the Colonna family, Borgia waited for an opportunity to eliminate the Orsini. The opportunity came, and he used it even better than it presented itself.

The Orsini realized too late that the increasing power of the duke and the Church meant their ruin. They therefore convened a council at Magione, in the territory of Perugia.

From that council arose the rebellion of Urbino, disturbances in Romagna, and countless dangers for the duke. He overcame them all with French assistance.

Once his standing had been restored, Borgia no longer trusted France or any other external force. Not wishing to put his security to the test by relying upon them, he turned to deception.

He concealed his intentions so effectively that the Orsini, through the mediation of Paolo Orsini, reconciled themselves with him.

The duke omitted no form of courtesy that might reassure Paolo, giving him robes, money, and horses. The Orsini's credulity eventually brought them into Borgia's hands at Senigallia.

Having eliminated their leaders and won their followers over to himself, the duke had constructed strong foundations for his power.

He possessed all of Romagna together with the Duchy of Urbino, and he had won over their populations because they had begun to experience improved conditions under his government.

Because this part of his conduct deserves to be known and imitated by others, I do not wish to pass over it.

After taking Romagna, the duke found that it had been governed by ineffectual rulers. They had plundered their subjects rather than governed them, and they had produced causes of division rather than unity.

As a result, the entire region was filled with robbery, conflict, and every other kind of lawlessness.

Borgia judged that, if he wished to make Romagna peaceful and obedient to sovereign authority, it was necessary to give it effective government.

He therefore placed Messer Remirro de Orco in command—a cruel and decisive man to whom he granted complete authority.

In a short time, Remirro made the province peaceful and united, earning great authority.

The duke then judged that such excessive power was no longer appropriate, because he feared it would become hated. He established a civil tribunal at the center of the province under an exceptionally capable president, and each city was given its own advocate before the tribunal.

Borgia recognized that the earlier severities had produced some hatred against him. To purge that resentment from the minds of the people and win them completely, he wished to show that any cruelty committed had not originated with him but with the minister's harsh nature.

Seizing an opportunity to make this clear, one morning he had Remirro's body displayed in two pieces in the public square at Cesena, with a wooden block and bloody knife beside it.

The ferocity of that spectacle left the people simultaneously satisfied and stunned.

But let us return to where we began.

The duke had now become powerful and had partly secured himself against immediate dangers. He had armed himself according to his own design and had largely eliminated the neighboring military forces capable of harming him.

If he wished to continue his acquisitions, his remaining constraint was France. He knew that the king, who had recognized his mistake too late, would no longer tolerate Borgia's expansion.

The duke therefore began seeking new alliances and distancing himself from France when the French advanced toward the Kingdom of Naples against the Spaniards besieging Gaeta.

His intention was to free himself from dependence upon them. He would soon have succeeded had Alexander remained alive.

These were Borgia's arrangements concerning immediate circumstances.

Regarding the future, however, he had to fear that the next pope would be hostile to him and would attempt to take away what Alexander had given him.

He planned to protect himself against this danger in four ways.

First, he would extinguish the bloodlines of all the rulers he had dispossessed, thereby depriving a future pope of people who could provide a pretext or opportunity for attacking him.

Second, he would win over all the Roman nobility so that, through them, he could hold the pope in check.

Third, he would bring as much of the College of Cardinals as possible under his influence.

Fourth, before Alexander died, he would acquire enough power and territory to resist an initial attack through his own strength.

By the time Alexander died, Borgia had completed three of these four measures and had nearly completed the fourth.

He killed as many members of the dispossessed ruling families as he could reach, and very few escaped. He had won over the Roman nobility, and he possessed a very large faction within the College of Cardinals.

Regarding further territorial acquisition, he planned to become master of Tuscany. He already possessed Perugia and Piombino and had assumed the protection of Pisa.

As soon as he no longer had to defer to France—and that moment was approaching because the Spaniards had already expelled the French from Naples, leaving both France and Spain compelled to purchase his friendship—he would have moved upon Pisa.

After that, Lucca and Siena would immediately have yielded, partly from hostility toward Florence and partly from fear. The Florentines would have had no remedy.

Had this plan succeeded—and it was close to succeeding in the very year Alexander died—Borgia would have acquired so much strength and standing that he could have sustained himself independently.

He would no longer have depended upon the *fortuna* or forces of others, but solely upon his own power and *virtù*.

But Alexander died only five years after Borgia had first drawn his sword.

He left the duke with only Romagna securely consolidated. All Borgia's other states remained suspended and unstable. He stood between two exceedingly powerful hostile armies and was himself deathly ill.

Yet the duke possessed such fierceness and such *virtù*, understood so well how people must be won over or destroyed, and had laid such strong foundations in so short a time that—had those armies not been pressing upon him, or had he been healthy—he would have withstood every difficulty.

That his foundations were strong could be seen from the fact that Romagna waited for him for more than a month.

In Rome, although half-dead, he remained secure. Although the Baglioni, Vitelli, and Orsini entered Rome, they gained no following against him.

Even if Borgia could not make his preferred candidate pope, he could at least prevent anyone he opposed from becoming pope.

Had he been healthy when Alexander died, everything would have been easy for him.

During the days in which Julius II was elected, the duke told me that he had considered everything that might happen upon his father's death and had found a remedy for everything.

The one possibility he had never anticipated was that, when his father was dying, he himself would also be near death.

Having considered all the duke's actions, I cannot reproach him. On the contrary, as I have done here, I believe he should be presented as a model for everyone who has risen to power through *fortuna* and the arms of others.

Possessing a great spirit and elevated intentions, he could not have conducted himself differently. Only the shortness of Alexander's life and Borgia's own illness obstructed his plans.

Anyone who considers it necessary in a new principality to secure himself against enemies, acquire friends, conquer by force or deception, make himself loved and feared by the people, followed and respected by the soldiers, eliminate those who are able or likely to injure him, transform old institutions through new methods, be severe yet gracious, magnanimous and liberal, abolish a disloyal military force and create a new one, and maintain relations with kings and princes so that they must help him willingly and attack him only with caution—such a person can find no more immediate example than the actions of Cesare Borgia.

He can be criticized only for his part in the election of Julius II, in which he made a bad choice.

As already stated, Borgia could not make anyone he wished pope, but he possessed the power to prevent someone he opposed from becoming pope.

He should never have consented to the election of any cardinal whom he had injured, or who would have reason to fear him after becoming pope.

For people injure others either from fear or from hatred.

Among the cardinals Borgia had injured were San Pietro in Vincoli, Colonna, San Giorgio, and Ascanio.

All the other cardinals, if elected pope, would have had reason to fear him except the Cardinal of Rouen and the Spanish cardinals. The Spaniards were connected and obligated to him; Rouen possessed independent power because he was supported by the Kingdom of France.

The duke should therefore have secured the election of a Spaniard above all. If he could not do that, he should have consented to the election of Rouen, but never San Pietro in Vincoli.

Anyone who believes that new benefits cause powerful men to forget old injuries deceives himself.

The duke therefore erred in this election, and that error caused his final ruin.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, territories, and particular historical acts are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing position conferred through external favor, purchased support, or borrowed force may be acquired before its recipient possesses the knowledge, capacities, and supporting relations required to preserve it. The ease of acquisition is therefore reversed after accession: every difficulty avoided beforehand reappears as a requirement of

retention. Because the continuation remains dependent upon the changing will, capacity, and circumstances of those who produced it, it lacks roots capable of surviving the withdrawal of its enabling conditions.

Exceptional virtù may permit the recipient to construct these foundations afterward, but the conversion must occur before external support disappears. The ruler must progressively replace borrowed forces with internally controlled forces, redirect contributors away from their former attachments, eliminate independently dangerous centers, establish alliances that depend upon the new continuation, and obtain support from the governed by producing an order they experience as preferable to the one displaced. Each operation converts externally supplied availability into internally retained capacity.

A temporary agent granted concentrated coercive authority can rapidly suppress disorder, but may accumulate both independent power and public hatred. Replacing that agent with accessible civil institutions can preserve the imposed order while removing the dependency and redirecting responsibility for its violence. In Machiavelli's example, the public destruction of the coercive agent completes this transfer through calculated brutality: the ruler retains the result of the cruelty while attempting to separate himself from its authorship.

The conversion must address future as well as immediate dependencies. A ruler whose authority originated with a patron must anticipate the patron's disappearance, eliminate displaced continuations that a successor could reactivate, acquire influence over the selection of that successor, and accumulate sufficient independent capacity to withstand the transition. Even extensive preparation remains bounded, however. An unanticipated conjunction of failures can temporarily make the ruler's accumulated capacities inaccessible at the precise moment they are required.

Past injuries also remain organizationally consequential. New benefits do not necessarily extinguish the fear or hatred produced by earlier injury. When a ruler cannot determine a future selection but retains the power to exclude hostile alternatives, failure to exercise that negative capacity allows an already identifiable threat to become governing. A continuation may therefore fail not because every foundation was absent, but because one retained dependency was permitted to select the condition under which all the others became unavailable.

Weaker still:

An externally conferred governing continuation becomes durable only insofar as borrowed authority, force, support, and opportunity are converted into internally retained capacities before the external conditions that supplied them disappear. Its vulnerability is determined not by the ease of its acquisition, but by the dependencies that remain capable of terminating it.

CHAPTER VIII

THOSE WHO ATTAIN A PRINCIPALITY THROUGH WICKED DEEDS

There are two additional ways in which a private citizen may become a prince, neither of which can be attributed entirely to *fortuna* or to *virtù*.

I do not think these should be omitted, although one of them could be discussed more fully in a treatment of republics.

The first occurs when someone ascends to a principality by a wicked and criminal path.

The second occurs when a private citizen becomes prince of his homeland through the favor of his fellow citizens.

In discussing the first way, I shall present two examples—one ancient and one modern—without otherwise entering into the merits of the matter. I judge these examples sufficient for anyone who might find himself compelled to imitate them.

Agathocles the Sicilian rose from not merely private but low and contemptible origins to become King of Syracuse.

Born the son of a potter, he led a wicked life at every stage of his advancement.

Nevertheless, he accompanied his wickedness with such *virtù* of mind and body that, after entering military service, he rose through its ranks to become the chief magistrate and military commander of Syracuse.

Once established in that position, he decided to become prince. He intended to take by violence, and to hold without obligation to anyone, the power that had originally been granted to him by public agreement.

After communicating his plan to Hamilcar the Carthaginian, who was campaigning with his armies in Sicily, Agathocles assembled the people and Senate of Syracuse one morning, as though he intended to deliberate upon matters concerning the republic.

At a predetermined signal, he ordered his soldiers to kill all the senators and the wealthiest members of the population.

Once they were dead, he seized and held the principality of the city without encountering any civil opposition.

Although the Carthaginians defeated him twice and eventually besieged Syracuse, he was able not only to defend his city but also to leave part of his army protecting it while he attacked Africa with the remainder.

Within a short time, he freed Syracuse from the siege and reduced the Carthaginians to extreme necessity.

They were compelled to reach an agreement with him: they would remain content with possession of Africa and leave Sicily to Agathocles.

Anyone who considers this man's actions and capabilities will see little or nothing that can be attributed to *fortuna*.

As already stated, Agathocles attained the principality not through anyone's favor but through the ranks of military service, which he had earned through a thousand hardships and dangers. He then maintained it through many courageous and dangerous decisions.

Yet killing one's fellow citizens, betraying one's friends, and living without faith, mercy, or religious restraint cannot be called *virtù*.

Such methods may acquire political power, but they cannot acquire glory.

If we consider Agathocles's *virtù* in entering and escaping dangers, and the greatness of spirit with which he endured and overcame adversity, there is no evident reason why he should be judged inferior to any of the most excellent military commanders.

Nevertheless, his savage cruelty, his inhumanity, and his countless crimes do not permit him to be celebrated among the most excellent people.

What he accomplished therefore cannot be attributed either to *fortuna* or, in the fullest sense, to *virtù*, since he achieved it without the proper claim to either.

In our own time, during the reign of Alexander VI, there was Oliverotto da Fermo.

Having been left fatherless when very young, Oliverotto was raised by his maternal uncle, Giovanni Fogliani. In his early youth, he was sent to serve as a soldier under Paolo Vitelli so that, thoroughly instructed in military discipline, he might attain an eminent military rank.

After Paolo's death, Oliverotto served under Paolo's brother, Vitellozzo. Because he was intelligent and vigorous in both body and spirit, he very quickly became one of the foremost men in Vitellozzo's army.

But because remaining in the service of others seemed servile to him, he decided to seize Fermo. He had the assistance of certain citizens of Fermo who preferred the servitude of their homeland to its liberty, as well as the support of the Vitelli family.

Oliverotto wrote to Giovanni Fogliani that, having been away from home for many years, he wished to return to see his uncle and his city and to attend to his inheritance.

He said that he had labored for no purpose except to acquire honor. So that his fellow citizens might see that he had not spent his time in vain, he wished to arrive honorably, accompanied by one hundred mounted friends and servants.

He asked Giovanni to arrange for the people of Fermo to receive him with honor. Such a reception, he explained, would honor not only Oliverotto but Giovanni himself, whose ward he had been.

Giovanni neglected none of the duties owed to his nephew. He arranged for Oliverotto to be received honorably by the people of Fermo and lodged him in his own house.

After several days, during which Oliverotto secretly prepared everything required for his intended crime, he held an elaborate banquet. He invited Giovanni Fogliani and all the leading men of Fermo.

When the meal and the customary entertainments had ended, Oliverotto deliberately began a serious discussion concerning the greatness of Pope Alexander, his son Cesare, and their undertakings.

After Giovanni and the others had responded, Oliverotto suddenly rose. He said that such matters should be discussed in a more private place and withdrew into another room.

Giovanni and all the other leading citizens followed him.

No sooner had they taken their seats than soldiers emerged from hiding places within the room and killed Giovanni and all the others.

After the murders, Oliverotto mounted his horse and rode through the city. He surrounded the supreme magistracy inside the government palace.

Out of fear, the magistrates were forced to obey him and establish a new government, of which Oliverotto made himself prince.

Having killed everyone who, through dissatisfaction, might have harmed him, he strengthened his position through new civil and military institutions.

Within the single year that he held the principality, he became not only secure within Fermo but formidable to all his neighbors.

Removing him would have been as difficult as removing Agathocles had Oliverotto not allowed Cesare Borgia to deceive him.

At Senigallia, as described above, Borgia captured the Orsini and Vitelli leaders. Oliverotto was captured with them.

One year after committing his act of parricide, Oliverotto was strangled together with Vitellozzo, who had been his teacher in both his *virtù* and his wickedness.

Someone might wonder how Agathocles and others like him could, after countless betrayals and cruelties, live securely for so long in their own countries, defend themselves against external enemies, and avoid conspiracies by their own citizens.

Many others who employed cruelty were unable to preserve their states even in peaceful times, much less during the uncertainties of war.

I believe the difference arises from whether cruelty is used well or badly.

Cruelties may be called well used—if it is permissible to speak well of evil—when they are committed all at once from the necessity of securing oneself, are not afterward continued, and are converted as far as possible into benefits for the subjects.

Cruelties are badly used when, although few at the beginning, they increase with the passage of time instead of disappearing.

Those who follow the first method may, before God and humanity, find some means of preserving their state, as Agathocles did.

Those who follow the second cannot possibly maintain themselves.

It should therefore be noted that, when seizing a state, the occupier should calculate all the cruelties he considers necessary and commit them at a single stroke.

He should do this so that he does not have to return to them every day. By not renewing them, he can reassure people and win them over by providing benefits.

Anyone who acts differently, whether from timidity or bad advice, must always keep the knife in his hand.

He can never base himself securely upon his subjects, because continual and freshly renewed injuries prevent them from ever feeling secure in relation to him.

Injuries should therefore be inflicted all at once, so that, being experienced for a shorter time, they cause less continuing resentment.

Benefits should be granted little by little, so that they may be experienced and appreciated more fully.

Above all, a prince must live with his subjects in such a way that no event, whether favorable or adverse, forces him to alter his conduct toward them.

When adverse circumstances bring necessity, it is too late to begin inflicting injuries.

Any benefits you then provide will not help you, because they will be judged compulsory. No one will feel gratitude toward you for them.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, cities, and particular acts of betrayal are removed while the organizational and evaluative distinctions are preserved:

The capacities required to acquire and preserve a governing continuation are not identical to the qualities required for that continuation to receive honor or glory. An actor may possess courage, intelligence, endurance, and effective coercive capacity while using betrayal, murder, and cruelty to obtain rule. Those capacities can make the acquisition functionally successful without making either its means or its author morally admirable. Successful continuation therefore does not entail evaluative legitimacy.

An actor may exploit established relations of trust to assemble and eliminate those capable of coordinating resistance. By destroying the people and institutions through which opposition could continue, the actor can transform conditionally granted authority into a governing continuation no longer answerable to those who originally conferred it. New civil and military institutions can then stabilize the resulting control. Internal consolidation, however, does not eliminate vulnerabilities arising from external relations or from the actor's own susceptibility to deception.

Machiavelli's distinction between cruelty "well used" and "badly used" concerns the temporal organization of coercion, not its moral justification. Violence that the acquirer judges necessary is treated as functionally less destabilizing when it is concentrated into the founding transition, terminated, and followed by a progressively experienced improvement in ordinary conditions. Continuing or increasing injury repeatedly renews insecurity, prevents stable expectations from forming, and makes the governed unable to treat their relation to the ruler as settled.

Benefits and injuries consequently operate differently across time. Concentrated injury is intended to become increasingly remote in the experience of those who remain, whereas gradually provided benefits remain repeatedly available for recognition. If injuries are postponed until adversity makes them necessary, they reveal the ruler's vulnerability and reactivate insecurity. Benefits offered under the same necessity appear compelled rather than freely conferred and therefore generate little gratitude or attachment.

A ruler must therefore establish sufficient capacity and a sufficiently stable relation with the governed before adversity occurs. If changing circumstances force repeated reversals between reassurance and violence, the governing continuation remains dependent upon the very disturbances it is attempting to control.

Weaker still:

Functional capacity to acquire and preserve a governing continuation is separable from its moral admissibility. In Machiavelli's analysis, a coercively founded continuation becomes more stable when founding violence is bounded and followed by predictable order, while recurring violence continually restores the insecurity and opposition that threaten it.

CHAPTER IX

THE CIVIL PRINCIPALITY

Let us now turn to the other way in which a citizen becomes prince of his homeland—not through wickedness or some other intolerable violence, but through the favor of his fellow citizens.

This may be called a civil principality.

Attaining it requires neither complete *virtù* nor complete *fortuna*, but rather a fortunate astuteness.

I say that a person rises to this kind of principality through either the favor of the people or the favor of the great.

For in every city there are two different political dispositions—two *umori*.

They arise because the people desire neither to be commanded nor oppressed by the great, while the great desire to command and oppress the people.

From these two opposing appetites, one of three outcomes arises within a city: principality, liberty, or lawless license.

A principality is created either by the people or by the great, according to which side obtains the opportunity.

When the great see that they cannot resist the people, they begin directing their collective standing toward one of their own number and make him prince. Under the protection of his position, they hope to satisfy their appetite to dominate.

Likewise, when the people see that they cannot resist the great, they direct their support toward one person and make him prince so that his authority will defend them.

A person who reaches the principality with the assistance of the great maintains himself with greater difficulty than someone who becomes prince with the assistance of the people.

The first finds himself surrounded by many who believe themselves his equals. Consequently, he can neither command nor manage them as he wishes.

But the person who reaches the principality through popular support finds himself standing alone. Around him are either no people, or very few, who are not prepared to obey.

Moreover, the great cannot be satisfied honorably and without injuring others, but the people can.

The objective of the people is more honorable than that of the great: the great wish to oppress, while the people wish only not to be oppressed.

It must also be added that a prince can never make himself secure against a hostile population because the people are too numerous. He can make himself secure against hostile members of the great because they are few.

The worst a prince can expect from a hostile population is that it will abandon him.

From hostile members of the great, however, he must fear not only abandonment but active opposition.

Because the great possess more foresight and astuteness, they always act in time to save themselves. They seek positions under whoever they expect will emerge victorious.

The prince must also live continually with the same population. But he can govern without the same members of the great.

He can make and unmake great men every day, granting or removing their standing whenever he chooses.

To clarify this matter, I say that the great must be considered principally in two ways: either they conduct themselves so that they bind their fortunes entirely to yours, or they do not.

Those who bind themselves to you and are not rapacious should be honored and loved.

Those who do not bind themselves to you must be divided into two further kinds.

Some refrain from commitment because of timidity and a natural lack of courage. You should make use of these people, especially those capable of giving sound advice.

In prosperous times, they bring you honor. In adversity, you have no reason to fear them.

But when members of the great deliberately avoid binding themselves to you because of ambition, it is a sign that they think more about themselves than about you.

The prince must guard against such people and treat them as declared enemies, because in adversity they will always assist in his ruin.

Someone who becomes prince through the favor of the people should therefore preserve their friendship.

This will be easy because the people ask only not to be oppressed.

But someone who becomes prince against the people through the favor of the great must, before doing anything else, attempt to win over the people.

This will be easy if he takes them under his protection.

When people receive good from someone from whom they expected harm, they become more strongly obligated to their benefactor. The people may therefore become more favorably disposed toward such a prince than if he had attained the principality through their original support.

The prince can win them over in many ways. Because these methods vary according to circumstances, no fixed rule can be given, and I shall therefore leave them aside.

I shall conclude only that a prince must have the people as his friends. Otherwise, he has no remedy in adversity.

Nabis, Prince of Sparta, withstood a siege conducted by all Greece and by an exceptionally victorious Roman army. Against them, he defended both his homeland and his state.

When danger arrived, he needed only to secure himself against a few internal opponents.

Had the people been his enemies, that would not have been enough.

No one should oppose my conclusion by repeating the worn-out proverb that whoever builds upon the people builds upon mud.

That proverb is true when a private citizen makes the people his foundation and persuades himself that they will rescue him if he is oppressed by enemies or magistrates.

In that situation, he will often find himself deceived, as happened in Rome to the Gracchi and in Florence to Messer Giorgio Scali.

But the situation is different when a prince builds upon the people—provided that he can command, possesses courage, does not become dismayed in adversity, has made the necessary preparations, and keeps the entire citizen body resolute through his own spirit and political institutions.

Such a prince will not find himself deceived by the people. He will discover that he has constructed sound foundations.

These principalities normally become endangered when they attempt to rise from a civil order to an absolute one.

Such princes govern either personally or through magistrates.

In the latter case, their states are weaker and more dangerous because they depend entirely upon the will of the citizens appointed to the magistracies.

Especially in adverse times, those magistrates can very easily take the state away from the prince, either by actively opposing him or simply by refusing to obey.

When danger has already arrived, it is too late for the prince to seize direct authority.

Citizens and subjects who are accustomed to receiving commands from the magistrates will not, during such a crisis, begin obeying commands issued personally by the prince.

In uncertain times, he will always suffer from a shortage of people whom he can trust.

Such a prince cannot base his expectations upon what he observes in peaceful times, when citizens have need of the state.

Then everyone comes running. Everyone makes promises. Everyone wishes to die for him—when death remains far away.

But in adverse times, when the state has need of its citizens, few are found.

This test is all the more dangerous because it can be made only once.

A wise prince must therefore devise a way by which his citizens, at all times and under every kind of circumstance, will have need of him and of his state.

They will then always remain faithful to him.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, cities, and particular factions are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing continuation may arise within an existing civil organization when one of two opposed groups concentrates its support upon an individual whom it expects to secure an objective it cannot secure alone. The resulting ruler therefore begins as the instrument of a contributing organization: either a numerous population seeking freedom from domination or a smaller powerful group seeking the capacity to dominate.

The source of elevation determines the ruler's subsequent dependencies. Powerful sponsors regard themselves as the ruler's equals, possess independent capacities, and expect benefits that require injury to others. Their objective cannot be satisfied without reproducing the conflict from which the principality arose. A population seeking only not to be oppressed presents a less expansive and more jointly satisfiable condition. Its members are too numerous to eliminate or replace, but their principal power against the ruler is collective withdrawal. Powerful sponsors are fewer and replaceable, yet they can actively organize opposition, redirect their allegiance, and assist a competing continuation.

Contributors must therefore be distinguished by both capacity and commitment. Those whose continuation is bound to the ruler's may become reliable participants. Those who remain uncommitted through limited courage can be useful without becoming serious rivals. Those who deliberately preserve their independence because of ambition retain themselves as alternative governing centers and will make that alternative available when adversity weakens the ruler.

Popular favor becomes a sound foundation only when the ruler can convert diffuse support into an organized continuation through command, courage, preparation, and institutions. Sympathy alone cannot preserve a private individual who lacks governing capacity. A ruler initially elevated by powerful sponsors may nevertheless establish a stronger popular dependency by protecting the population from the domination it expected from him.

Nominal authority is also distinct from operational access to command. A ruler who governs through magistrates depends upon their continuing obedience. If the population has become accustomed to receiving commands from those intermediaries, the ruler cannot wait until crisis to redirect obedience toward himself. Established command pathways remain operative during adversity, while newly asserted ones may not yet be organizationally available.

Support observed during peaceful conditions is therefore an unreliable measure of support under danger. Low-cost promises do not establish that contributors will accept high-cost continuation, and the decisive test may occur only once. Durability requires dependencies established beforehand through which the citizens' own continuations remain joined to that of the ruler and the civil order.

Weaker still:

The stability of a civil governing continuation depends not merely upon how much support it possesses, but upon the objectives, capacities, replaceability, command positions, and retained alternatives of those providing it. Apparent support becomes durable only when it is organized into dependencies that remain operative under adversity.

CHAPTER X

HOW THE STRENGTH OF PRINCIPALITIES SHOULD BE MEASURED

In examining the characteristics of these principalities, another consideration must be introduced.

We must ask whether a prince possesses sufficient resources to stand by himself when necessary, or whether he always requires the defense of others.

To clarify this distinction, I judge that princes can stand by themselves when, through an abundance of people or money, they can assemble an adequate army and fight a battle against anyone who attacks them.

I judge that princes always require the assistance of others when they cannot meet their enemies in the field but are compelled to take refuge behind their walls and defend them.

The first situation has already been discussed, and we shall say whatever else is necessary about it later.

In the second situation, nothing can be said except that such princes should fortify and provision their principal cities and disregard the loss of the surrounding countryside.

Anyone who has thoroughly fortified his city and has governed his subjects in the manner described above—and to be described below—will always be attacked with great caution.

People are naturally reluctant to undertake enterprises that visibly present great difficulty. No attack can appear easy against someone who possesses a strong city and is not hated by his people.

The cities of Germany are exceedingly free. They possess little surrounding territory and obey the emperor when it suits them.

They fear neither the emperor nor any other powerful ruler in their vicinity because they are fortified so effectively that everyone expects conquering them to be tedious and difficult.

They all possess suitable walls and defensive ditches. They have sufficient artillery and maintain enough food, drink, and fuel in public storehouses to last for one year.

In addition, so that the working population can be fed without exhausting the public treasury, they maintain sufficient materials and resources to provide a year's employment in the trades that are the strength and life of the city—the trades by which the population supports itself.

They also hold military training in high regard and possess many institutions for maintaining it.

A prince, therefore, who possesses a strong city and does not make himself hated is not an attractive target for attack.

If someone nevertheless attacks him, the attacker will depart in disgrace. The circumstances of the world vary so greatly that it is nearly impossible for anyone to keep an army encamped idly before a city for an entire year.

Someone might object that if the people possess property outside the walls and see it being burned, they will lose patience. A long siege and concern for their own interests will cause them to forget their prince.

I answer that a powerful and courageous prince will always overcome these difficulties.

At one moment, he will give his subjects hope that their suffering will not last long. At another, he will make them fear the enemy's cruelty. He will also act skillfully to secure himself against those who appear dangerously bold.

Moreover, the enemy will normally burn and devastate the countryside immediately upon arriving, while the defenders' spirits are still heated and they remain eager to resist.

The prince should therefore fear this less than might be supposed.

After several days, when people's emotions have cooled, the damage has already been done. The injuries have already been suffered, and no remedy remains.

At that point, the people become even more closely united with their prince. They believe that he has acquired an obligation toward them because their homes were burned and their property destroyed in his defense.

It is human nature to become bound to others through benefits one has given as well as through benefits one has received.

Considering everything carefully, a prudent prince should therefore have little difficulty keeping the spirits of his citizens firm, both at the beginning of a siege and as it continues, provided that they do not lack the means either to live or to defend themselves.

An AC Weakening

When particular cities, military technologies, and siege conditions are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

The strength of a governing organization is measured by whether it possesses internally retained capacities sufficient to preserve itself under attack or must depend upon capacities supplied by another organization. Independent strength may take the form of sufficient resources for direct confrontation, but inability to confront an opponent in the field does not by itself establish organizational weakness.

When the entire governed domain cannot be defended, the organization may contract around a preservable core. Fortification protects its essential relations; stored necessities maintain biological continuation; retained productive activity preserves economic and social function; and established training and institutions maintain defensive capacity. Peripheral territory may be relinquished without terminating the governing continuation if the protected center retains what its members require both to live and to resist.

Defensive strength is relational rather than absolute. A protected organization need not make attack impossible; it need only make the attacker's required continuation more difficult or prolonged than the attacker can reliably sustain. Visible difficulty can prevent attack before conflict begins, while sufficient endurance can allow changing external circumstances to terminate an attack already undertaken.

Material preparation remains insufficient if the population withdraws its support. The ruler must avoid becoming hated and must preserve collective resolution by managing expectations of duration, maintaining recognition of the external threat, and constraining internal actions that could disrupt defense. Once losses have become irreversible, those who suffered them may become more closely bound to the defended continuation because their sacrifices constitute contributions for which they expect reciprocal obligation. Participants can therefore become attached through benefits they have given as well as through benefits they have received.

Weaker still:

Organizational strength consists in the capacity to preserve a sufficient continuation through internally retained material, productive, defensive, institutional, and relational resources until the opposing continuation can no longer sustain its constraint.

CHAPTER XI

ECCLESIASTICAL PRINCIPALITIES

It remains now only to discuss ecclesiastical principalities.

In these, all the difficulties arise before possession is obtained.

They are acquired through either *virtù* or *fortuna*, but they can be maintained without either.

This is because they are sustained by institutions long established in religion. These institutions are so powerful and possess such qualities that they keep their princes in power regardless of how those princes conduct themselves or live.

These rulers alone possess states that they do not defend and subjects whom they do not govern.

Yet their states, although left undefended, are not taken from them. Their subjects, although not governed, show no concern. They neither think of separating themselves from their rulers nor are able to do so.

These principalities alone, therefore, are secure and prosperous.

But because they are governed by higher causes beyond the reach of the human mind, I shall leave them undiscussed.

Since they are exalted and maintained by God, it would be the work of a presumptuous and reckless person to reason about them.

Nevertheless, someone may ask how the Church has attained such greatness in temporal power.

Before Alexander VI, the Italian powers—and not only those properly called powers, but every baron and ruler, however minor—held the Church's temporal power in little esteem.

Now a King of France trembles before it. The Church has been able to drive him out of Italy and ruin the Venetians.

Although these events are well known, I do not think it superfluous to recall how they occurred.

Before Charles VIII, King of France, entered Italy, the peninsula was under the power of the pope, the Venetians, the King of Naples, the Duke of Milan, and the Florentines.

These powers had two principal concerns.

The first was that no foreign ruler should enter Italy with armed forces.

The second was that none of the Italian powers should acquire additional territory.

The two powers watched most carefully were the pope and the Venetians.

Restraining the Venetians required the union of all the others, as occurred in the defense of Ferrara.

To keep the pope weak, the other powers employed the Roman barons.

These barons were divided into two factions, the Orsini and the Colonna. There was always some cause of conflict between them.

By remaining armed immediately before the pope's eyes, they kept the papacy weak and infirm.

Although a courageous pope would sometimes arise, as Sixtus IV did, neither *fortuna* nor political skill could free him from these difficulties.

The shortness of papal reigns was the cause.

A pope lived, on average, approximately ten years. Within that time, he could barely reduce one of the two factions.

If, for example, one pope had nearly extinguished the Colonna, another pope hostile to the Orsini would arise and restore the Colonna. Yet he would not have sufficient time to extinguish the Orsini.

This caused the pope's temporal power to be held in little esteem throughout Italy.

Then Alexander VI arose.

More than any previous pope, he demonstrated how much a pope could accomplish through money and armed force.

Using Duke Valentino as his instrument and the French invasion as his opportunity, Alexander accomplished everything I described above when discussing the duke's actions.

Although Alexander's intention was not to make the Church powerful but to make his son powerful, everything he accomplished ultimately increased the Church's power.

After Alexander's death and the destruction of the duke, the Church inherited the results of their labors.

Pope Julius II came afterward and found the Church already powerful.

It possessed all of Romagna. The power of the Roman barons had been broken, and Alexander's blows had neutralized their factions.

Julius also found open to him a method of accumulating money that had never been used so extensively before Alexander.

Julius not only continued these practices but expanded them.

He planned to acquire Bologna, destroy Venetian power, and drive the French out of Italy.

All these undertakings succeeded.

He deserves even greater praise because he did everything to increase the power of the Church rather than that of any private individual.

He also kept the Orsini and Colonna factions within the reduced limits in which he had found them.

Although each faction still contained leaders capable of producing new disturbances, two things kept them restrained.

The first was the greatness of the Church, which intimidated them.

The second was that neither faction possessed cardinals capable of advancing its interests.

These factions will never remain quiet whenever they possess cardinals. Cardinals nourish the factions both within Rome and outside it, and the barons are then compelled to defend them.

Thus the ambitions of the prelates produce conflict and disorder among the barons.

His Holiness Pope Leo X has therefore inherited an exceedingly powerful papacy.

It may be hoped that, if his predecessors made it great through arms, he will make it still greater and more venerable through his goodness and his countless other *virtù*.

An AC Weakening

When religious titles, named officeholders, factions, and historical events are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing continuation may be sustained by institutions so deeply established that its preservation depends less upon the capacities or conduct of its current ruler than upon the authority, expectations, and relations already retained by the organization. The officeholder occupies a continuation whose foundations he did not construct and need not continually reproduce. Institutional recognition can therefore preserve the ruler even when he contributes little direct defense or governance.

Such an organization may nevertheless remain weak in its relations with surrounding powers and internal factions. When individual tenures are too short to complete structural changes, and successors restore the rivals weakened by their predecessors, each ruler's achievements remain local and reversible. The institution cannot develop cumulatively because the result of one continuation is not reliably retained as the starting condition of the next.

This changes when an officeholder produces territorial, financial, coercive, or institutional capacities that become attached to the office rather than remaining dependent upon his personal continuation. The intended beneficiary of those actions need not be the organization that ultimately retains them. Capacities created to advance a private objective may survive the failure of that objective and become available to the containing institution.

A successor can then inherit those promoted results, reuse the methods that produced them, and develop them further without repeating the original work of acquisition. What required exceptional opportunity, force, or skill from one officeholder becomes an established organizational resource for the next. The institution thereby acquires a developmental continuity that exceeds the lives, intentions, and capacities of its individual rulers.

Internal factions remain capable of renewed continuation when they retain representatives within the central institution who can connect factional ambition to external supporters. Removing or restricting those access points, while increasing the authority of the containing organization, reduces the factions' ability to reconstruct themselves as competing centers of power.

Weaker still:

An institution becomes independently durable when capacities produced by transient occupants are retained by the office and made reusable across succession. Once such promotion occurs, institutional continuation no longer depends upon reproducing the virtù, fortuna, or intentions through which those capacities were originally acquired.

CHAPTER XII

THE DIFFERENT KINDS OF MILITARY FORCES, AND MERCENARY SOLDIERS

Having discussed individually all the kinds of principalities that I proposed to examine at the beginning, having considered to some extent the causes of their good or bad condition, and having shown the methods by which many people have attempted to acquire and maintain them, it remains for me to discuss generally the means of offense and defense available to each.

We have already said that a prince must possess sound foundations. Otherwise, he will necessarily come to ruin.

The principal foundations of every state—whether new, old, or mixed—are good laws and good arms.

Because good laws cannot exist where there are no good arms, and where good arms exist good laws must follow, I shall leave aside the discussion of laws and speak about arms.

I say, then, that the arms with which a prince defends his state are either his own, mercenary, auxiliary, or mixed.

Mercenary and auxiliary forces are useless and dangerous.

Anyone whose state rests upon mercenary arms will never remain stable or secure.

Mercenary forces are divided, ambitious, undisciplined, and unfaithful. They are courageous among their friends and cowardly before their enemies.

They possess neither fear of God nor fidelity toward other people.

Your ruin is postponed only for as long as an attack is postponed.

In peace, you are plundered by the mercenaries. In war, you are plundered by your enemies.

The reason is that mercenaries possess no attachment and no motive that keeps them in the field except a small wage, and that wage is not enough to make them willing to die for you.

They are perfectly willing to be your soldiers while you are not at war. But when war arrives, they either flee or desert.

I should require little effort to persuade anyone of this, because Italy's present ruin has no other cause than its having rested upon mercenary arms for many years.

These forces once made some advances on behalf of particular rulers, and when fighting one another they appeared courageous.

But when a foreign invader arrived, they revealed what they truly were.

Thus Charles, King of France, was permitted to take Italy with nothing more than a piece of chalk.

Those who said that our sins were the cause spoke the truth. But the sins were not those they imagined. They were the sins I have just described.

Because they were the sins of princes, the princes themselves have suffered the punishment.

I wish to demonstrate more fully the disastrous character of mercenary arms.

Mercenary commanders are either exceptionally capable or they are not.

If a commander is capable, you cannot trust him. He will always aspire to his own greatness, either by oppressing you, his employer, or by oppressing others beyond what you intended.

But if the commander does not possess *virtù*, he will ordinarily ruin you through incompetence.

Someone may respond that anyone who commands armed forces will behave in this way, whether or not he is a mercenary.

I answer that military power must be exercised either by a prince or by a republic.

A prince must go personally and perform the office of commander himself.

A republic must send its own citizens. When it sends someone who does not prove capable, it must replace him. When he does prove capable, it must restrain him through laws so that he does not exceed his proper limits.

Experience shows that princes commanding in person and republics armed with their own citizens make the greatest advances. Mercenary forces produce nothing but harm.

A republic armed with its own forces also falls under the control of one of its citizens with much greater difficulty than a republic armed with foreign forces.

Rome and Sparta remained armed and free for many centuries.

The Swiss are exceedingly well armed and exceedingly free.

Among ancient examples of mercenary forces are the Carthaginians. After the First Punic War, they were nearly overpowered by their own mercenary soldiers, even though Carthaginian citizens commanded those forces.

After the death of Epaminondas, the Thebans made Philip of Macedon commander of their soldiers. After achieving victory, he deprived them of their liberty.

After Duke Filippo died, the Milanese hired Francesco Sforza to fight the Venetians. Having defeated the Venetians at Caravaggio, Sforza joined with them to oppress his Milanese employers.

Sforza's father, while serving Queen Joanna of Naples, suddenly left her without armed forces. To avoid losing her kingdom, she was compelled to place herself in the hands of the King of Aragon.

It may be objected that the Venetians and Florentines formerly expanded their territories with mercenary forces, and that their commanders defended them rather than making themselves princes.

I answer that in this matter the Florentines were favored by *fortuna*.

Of the capable commanders whom they had reason to fear, some did not win, some faced opposing commanders who restrained them, and others directed their ambition elsewhere.

The commander who did not win was John Hawkwood. Because he did not win, his fidelity was never tested.

But everyone must admit that, had he won decisively, Florence would have been at his mercy.

Sforza was always opposed by the followers of Braccio, so the two forces kept one another in check.

Francesco Sforza directed his ambition toward Lombardy. Braccio directed his against the Church and the Kingdom of Naples.

But let us turn to something that occurred more recently.

The Florentines made Paolo Vitelli their commander. He was an exceptionally prudent man who had acquired a very great reputation after beginning in private station.

Had he conquered Pisa, no one could deny that the Florentines would have been forced to remain aligned with him.

If he had entered the service of their enemies, they would have possessed no remedy against him. If they retained him, they would have been compelled to obey him.

If we consider the progress of the Venetians, we see that they acted securely and gloriously while they conducted their wars with their own people.

This was before they began territorial campaigns on the Italian mainland. In their earlier wars, Venetian nobles and an armed population acted with great *virtù*.

But when they began fighting on land, they abandoned this practice and adopted the military customs of Italy.

At the beginning of their territorial expansion, they possessed little land power and great prestige, so they did not have much reason to fear their commanders.

But as they expanded under Carmagnola, they received a demonstration of their error.

They had seen that he was an exceptionally capable commander when, under his leadership, they defeated the Duke of Milan.

Yet they also recognized that he had become uncommitted and hesitant in continuing the war. They judged that they could no longer win under him because he no longer wished them to win.

They could not dismiss him without losing what they had acquired. To secure themselves against him, they were therefore compelled to kill him.

The Venetians later employed Bartolomeo da Bergamo, Roberto da San Severino, the Count of Pitigliano, and similar commanders.

With these men, they had to fear losses rather than expect gains.

This occurred at Vailà, where in a single battle they lost what they had acquired through eight hundred years of great effort.

From mercenary arms arise only slow, delayed, and feeble acquisitions—but sudden and astonishing losses.

Because these examples have brought me to Italy, which has been governed by mercenary forces for many years, I wish to examine their history from farther back.

By understanding their origin and development, they may be more effectively corrected.

You should understand that, when imperial power began in recent times to be driven out of Italy and the pope acquired greater temporal standing, Italy divided into numerous states.

Many of the larger cities took up arms against their nobles, who had formerly oppressed them with the emperor's support. The Church supported these cities in order to increase its own temporal standing.

In many other cities, individual citizens became princes.

Italy therefore passed largely into the hands of the Church and several republics.

Because the priests and republican citizens who governed these states possessed no knowledge of warfare, they began hiring foreigners as soldiers.

The first person to give prestige to this kind of military force was Alberigo da Conio, a man of Romagna.

Among those who descended from his military discipline were Braccio and Sforza, who in their time became arbiters of Italy.

After them came all the other mercenary commanders who have governed the military forces of Italy down to our own time.

The final result of their *virtù* has been that Italy was overrun by Charles, plundered by Louis, violated by Ferdinand, and insulted by the Swiss.

The method these commanders adopted was first to deprive infantry of prestige so that they could increase their own.

They did this because they possessed no states and depended entirely upon their military profession.

A small number of infantry gave them no standing, while they could not afford to maintain a large number.

They therefore concentrated upon cavalry. With a manageable number of mounted soldiers, they could be supported and honored.

Affairs reached the point that an army of twenty thousand soldiers contained fewer than two thousand infantry.

The commanders also employed every method they could devise to remove effort and danger from themselves and their soldiers.

They did not kill one another in their skirmishes but took prisoners and released them without ransom.

They did not attack cities at night, and the defenders of cities did not attack their camps at night.

They constructed neither defensive stockades nor ditches around their camps.

They did not campaign during winter.

All these practices were permitted by their military institutions and were devised, as I have said, to avoid hardship and danger.

In this way, they brought Italy to enslavement and disgrace.

An AC Weakening

When named states, commanders, and particular military practices are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing organization requires both an ordering structure and an effective capacity to preserve that order. If the capacity required for defense and enforcement is unavailable to the organization itself, its laws and governing decisions remain dependent upon whoever controls that capacity.

When a continuation-critical function is delegated to an external organization whose survival and objectives are not bound to those of its employer, compensation may secure participation under low-cost conditions without securing performance when the cost becomes extreme. Apparent service during peace therefore does not establish fidelity during war. The delegated force may remain available only while the function for which it was retained is not actually required.

The employer then faces a structural dilemma. An incapable external commander cannot preserve the organization; a highly capable commander acquires sufficient independent capacity to redirect the delegated force toward his own continuation. He may exceed the intended objective, impose new dependencies upon his employer, transfer his service to a rival, or appropriate the organization he was hired to defend. The employer is threatened by incompetence at one extreme and autonomous competence at the other.

Internally retained force reduces this divergence because those exercising it participate in the continuation being defended. That identity is not sufficient by itself: a governing organization must also preserve authority over its commanders. A ruler may exercise command directly; a republic may select its own citizens, replace incapable commanders, and constrain successful ones through retained laws. Internal capacity becomes protective only when its exercise remains answerable to the containing organization.

Success under favorable circumstances does not refute the underlying dependency. An external commander's fidelity may remain untested because he fails to achieve decisive power, is constrained by an equivalent rival, or directs his ambition elsewhere. Such

arrangements can accumulate slow and limited gains while retaining the possibility of sudden catastrophic loss.

Over time, the external provider may also reorganize the delegated function around its own preservation. It selects methods that increase its standing and income while reducing its expense, effort, and exposure to danger. The resulting practices may continue to resemble the required function while progressively losing the capacity to perform it under genuine threat. An entire containing organization can consequently become adapted to the continuation of its providers rather than to its own defense.

Weaker still:

An organization cannot securely continue when a capacity necessary for its preservation is controlled by another organization whose incentives, command structure, and survival are not dependent upon that continuation.

CHAPTER XIII

AUXILIARY, MIXED, AND ONE'S OWN FORCES

Auxiliary forces—the other useless kind—are employed when you call upon a powerful ruler to come with his own troops to assist and defend you. Pope Julius II did this recently. After seeing how badly his mercenaries performed in the campaign against Ferrara, he turned to auxiliaries and made an agreement with Ferdinand, king of Spain, under which Ferdinand was to assist him with his men and armies.

These forces may be useful and effective in themselves, but they are always harmful to the person who calls them in: if they lose, you are ruined; if they win, you become their prisoner.

Although ancient histories are full of such examples, I do not wish to leave this recent example of Pope Julius II. His decision could not have been more reckless: in order to acquire Ferrara, he placed himself entirely in the hands of a foreign ruler.

His good *fortuna*, however, produced a third outcome, preventing him from suffering the consequences of his bad choice. His auxiliaries were defeated at Ravenna; then the Swiss arose and, contrary to everyone's expectations—his own as well as others'—drove away the victors. Thus Julius remained the prisoner neither of his enemies, because they fled, nor of his auxiliaries, because the victory was achieved by forces other than theirs.

The Florentines, being completely disarmed, brought ten thousand French troops against Pisa in order to conquer it. By this decision they exposed themselves to greater danger than at any other time in all their troubles.

The emperor of Constantinople, wishing to resist his neighbors, brought ten thousand Turks into Greece. When the war ended, the Turks refused to leave. This marked the beginning of Greece's enslavement to the infidels.

Anyone, therefore, who wishes to make victory impossible should employ auxiliary forces, for they are much more dangerous than mercenaries. With auxiliaries, ruin arrives already organized: they form a single body, entirely directed toward obedience to someone else.

Mercenaries, by contrast, require more time and a better opportunity to injure you after they have won. They do not form a single body, and they have been recruited and paid by you. A third party whom you appoint to command them cannot immediately acquire enough authority over them to harm you.

In short, with mercenaries the greater danger lies in their *ignavia*—their cowardly ineffectiveness; with auxiliaries, the danger lies in their *virtù*.

A wise prince, therefore, has always avoided both kinds and turned instead to his own forces. He would rather lose with his own men than win with those of another, judging that a victory acquired through foreign forces is not a true victory.

I shall never hesitate to cite Cesare Borgia and his actions. The duke entered the Romagna with auxiliary forces, bringing an entirely French army with him, and with those forces he captured Imola and Forlì.

But when these forces no longer appeared safe to him, he turned to mercenaries, judging them less dangerous, and hired the Orsini and Vitelli. When, in practice, he found them uncertain, treacherous, and dangerous, he destroyed them and turned to forces of his own.

The difference among these kinds of forces can easily be seen by comparing the duke's reputation when he had only the French, when he employed the Orsini and Vitelli, and when he was finally left with his own soldiers and depended upon himself alone. His reputation increased at every stage. He was never fully respected until everyone saw that he was the complete master of his own military power.

I had not intended to depart from recent Italian examples. Nevertheless, I do not wish to omit Hiero of Syracuse, one of the men I mentioned earlier.

As I have said, Hiero was made commander of the Syracusan armies. He immediately recognized that their mercenary troops were useless, because their commanders were made of the same material as our Italian commanders. Since it appeared to him that he

could neither keep them nor safely dismiss them, he had them all cut to pieces. From then onward, he made war with his own forces and not with those of others.

I also wish to recall an image from the Old Testament that illustrates this point.

When David offered to go and fight Goliath, the Philistine challenger, Saul armed David in his own armor in order to give him courage. But once David had put it on, he rejected it, saying that he could not make proper use of himself while wearing it. He therefore chose to meet the enemy with his own sling and knife.

In short, another man's arms will either fall from your shoulders, weigh you down, or bind you too tightly.

Charles VII, father of King Louis XI, freed France from the English through his *fortuna* and *virtù*. Recognizing the necessity of possessing forces of his own, he established within his kingdom a standing organization of men-at-arms and infantry.

Later, his son King Louis abolished the infantry organization and began hiring Swiss troops. This error, continued by his successors, has become—as events now demonstrate—the source of the dangers facing that kingdom.

By giving prestige to the Swiss, Louis diminished the worth of all his own forces. He abolished his infantry and made his native men-at-arms dependent upon foreign troops. Having become accustomed to fighting beside the Swiss, the French men-at-arms came to believe that they could not win without them.

The result is that the French are inadequate when fighting against the Swiss and, without the Swiss, prove ineffective against anyone else.

The armies of France have therefore been mixed: partly mercenary and partly their own. Such mixed forces are much better than purely auxiliary or purely mercenary forces, but they remain greatly inferior to forces entirely one's own.

The example already given is enough. The kingdom of France would be unbeatable if Charles's system had been preserved or expanded.

But human shortsightedness begins a policy which, because it tastes good at first, fails to recognize the poison hidden underneath—just as I said earlier about wasting fevers.

Therefore, a ruler who cannot recognize the evils developing within his principality while they are still being born is not truly wise; and this ability is granted to very few.

If we consider the beginning of the Roman Empire's ruin, we shall find that it began simply with the hiring of the Goths. From that moment, the strength of the Roman Empire began to be enervated, and all the *virtù* taken away from the Romans was transferred to the Goths.

I conclude, therefore, that no principality is secure unless it possesses forces of its own. Without them, it is entirely dependent upon *fortuna*, because it lacks the *virtù* that can defend it steadfastly in adversity.

It has always been the opinion and judgment of wise men that nothing is so weak or unstable as the reputation of a power that is not founded upon its own strength.

One's own forces are those composed of one's subjects, citizens, or men raised and formed under one's own authority. All other forces are either mercenary or auxiliary.

How one should organize forces of one's own will be easy to discover by examining the *ordini*—the systems and institutions—of the four men I named earlier, and by considering how Philip, the father of Alexander the Great, as well as many republics and princes, armed and organized themselves. I refer the reader entirely to those examples.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, armies, and historical examples are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A capacity does not belong to an organization merely because it is temporarily exercised on that organization's behalf. It remains external when its members, command relations, cohesion, and ultimate allegiance are retained by another governing continuation.

A cohesive external force creates a closed failure structure for the organization requesting it. If the force loses, the requesting organization lacks sufficient capacity to resist its opponent. If the force wins, it remains an organized and effective power answerable to someone else, against which the requesting organization also lacks sufficient capacity. Defeat leaves the original threat in control; victory introduces the provider as a new controlling threat. The provider's competence therefore increases rather than decreases the requesting organization's dependency.

Fragmented external providers are dangerous principally because they may fail to perform or may gradually acquire independent power. An already unified auxiliary organization arrives with command, discipline, and allegiance intact. Its capacity to subordinate the recipient does not have to be constructed after victory; the organization of that subordination is already present. Once such a dependency has been admitted, the recipient may be unable either to retain it safely or to dismiss it safely.

Internally retained capacity differs because its development, command, and continued availability remain within the organization whose continuation it preserves. A victory achieved through external capacity is therefore not fully the recipient's victory if the resulting condition leaves the recipient unable to continue independently. Successful performance must preserve both the immediate objective and the organization's authority over the means by which that objective was achieved.

Repeated reliance upon external capacity also changes the developmental structure of the recipient. Internal practices are discontinued, native contributors lose standing and experience, and remaining internal forces become accustomed to functioning only in combination with the external provider. Capacity is thereby weakened within the recipient while being exercised, refined, and increased within the provider. What initially appears to supplement internal strength can progressively transfer virtù from the organization being assisted to the organization assisting it.

This deterioration may initially produce favorable results and become visible only when independent performance is required. Mixed capacity can delay the failure because some internal organization remains, but it cannot restore capacities that are no longer being independently exercised and developed. Recognizing the dependency while it is forming is therefore part of the capacity required to prevent it.

Weaker still:

Organizational capacity resides where it is formed, commanded, retained, and recursively developed—not necessarily where its effects are temporarily directed. An organization that repeatedly substitutes externally controlled capacity for its own transfers both competence and continuational independence to the provider.

CHAPTER XIV

WHAT A PRINCE MUST DO CONCERNING MILITARY AFFAIRS

A prince, therefore, must have no other objective, no other concern, and must adopt nothing else as his profession except war, together with its organization and discipline. This is the only profession proper to one who commands.

It possesses such *virtù* that it not only maintains those who were born princes, but often enables men of private station to rise to that rank.

Conversely, when princes have devoted more thought to comforts than to arms, they have lost their states.

The foremost cause that makes you lose a state is neglecting this profession. The cause that enables you to acquire one is being expert in it.

Francesco Sforza, because he was armed, rose from private citizen to Duke of Milan. His sons, because they avoided the hardships of arms, fell from dukes to private citizens.

Among the other harms that being unarmed brings you, it makes you contemptible. This is one of the disgraces against which a prince must guard, as will be discussed below.

There is no proportion at all between an armed man and an unarmed one.

It is unreasonable to expect someone armed to obey willingly someone unarmed, or for an unarmed ruler to feel secure among armed subordinates. The armed man feels contempt; the unarmed ruler feels suspicion. Under those conditions, they cannot work well together.

Therefore, a prince who does not understand military affairs, in addition to the other disadvantages already mentioned, cannot be respected by his soldiers or trust them.

A prince must therefore never take his mind away from the practice of war. In peace he must exercise it more than in war.

He can do this in two ways: through action and through thought.

As for action, besides keeping his forces properly organized and trained, he must be constantly engaged in hunting.

Hunting partly accustoms his body to hardship and partly teaches him the nature of terrain: how mountains rise, how valleys open, how plains lie, and the character of rivers and marshes. He must devote the greatest care to this knowledge.

It is useful in two ways.

First, he learns to know his own country and can better understand its defenses.

Second, through knowledge and experience of that terrain, he can readily understand any new terrain he must reconnoiter. The hills, valleys, plains, rivers, and marshes found in Tuscany, for example, bear a certain similarity to those in other provinces. Knowledge of the terrain in one province therefore makes it easier to understand the terrain of others.

A prince who lacks this expertise lacks the first qualification a commander must possess. It teaches him how to locate the enemy, select encampments, lead armies, arrange battles, and besiege fortified places to his advantage.

One of the praises writers give Philopoemen, prince of the Achaeans, is that during times of peace he thought of nothing except the ways of war.

When he was in the countryside with friends, he would often stop and reason with them:

“If the enemy were on that hill and we were here with our army, which of us would have the advantage? How could we advance to meet them while preserving our formation? If we wished to retreat, how should we do it? If they retreated, how should we pursue them?”

As they continued walking, he presented every contingency that could arise for an army. He listened to his companions' views, stated his own, and supported it with reasons.

As a result of these continual exercises of thought, no contingency could arise while he was leading armies for which he did not have a remedy.

As for exercising the mind, a prince must read histories. In them he must consider the actions of excellent men, see how they conducted themselves in wars, and examine the causes of their victories and defeats, so that he can avoid the causes of defeat and imitate the causes of victory.

Above all, he must act as some excellent man before him has acted: he must choose for imitation a predecessor who was praised and glorified, and always keep that man's deeds and actions before him.

Thus Alexander the Great is said to have imitated Achilles; Caesar, Alexander; and Scipio, Cyrus.

Anyone who reads the life of Cyrus written by Xenophon can then recognize in Scipio's life how much glory this imitation brought him, and how closely—in chastity, affability, humaneness, and generosity—Scipio conformed himself to what Xenophon wrote of Cyrus.

A wise prince must follow methods like these.

He must never remain idle in peaceful times. Through *industria*, he must make those times a resource upon which he can draw in adversity, so that when *fortuna* changes, it finds him prepared to resist it.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, military exercises, terrains, and exemplary histories are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing organization cannot securely command a continuation-critical capacity that its ruler neither possesses nor understands. When effective force resides in armed subordinates while the ruler lacks both competence and corresponding capacity, formal hierarchy becomes disproportionate to operational power. The subordinates have reason for contempt, the ruler has reason for suspicion, and neither reliable command nor mutual trust can be maintained.

Competence in an existential function must therefore be developed continuously rather than sought only when the function becomes urgently necessary. Practical exercise builds tolerance for its demands and gives the ruler direct access to the material relations within which action must occur. Detailed knowledge of one environment also supplies relational patterns through which unfamiliar environments can be examined. Local

experience becomes transferable when its structure, rather than merely its particulars, is retained.

Scenario reasoning extends practical preparation by articulating possible conditions before any one of them becomes actual. By varying positions, advantages, movements, failures, and responses, the ruler constructs alternative continuations and tests their consequences while correction remains inexpensive. Discussion with others exposes those alternatives to comparison and requires proposed actions to be supported by reasons. When adversity arrives, remedies already articulated through prior examination are more readily available than responses that must be invented under immediate constraint.

Historical study further enlarges this retained experience. The actions of earlier agents make otherwise inaccessible successes and failures available for comparison. Examining their causes permits the ruler to imitate relations that produced success while avoiding those that produced failure. Exemplary figures also provide an elevated organizational model toward which conduct can be repeatedly oriented.

Peace is therefore not an absence of the required function but the condition under which its capacities can be developed with the greatest freedom. Time not consumed by immediate danger can be converted into training, environmental knowledge, tested alternatives, historical comparison, and prepared remedies. When circumstances change, the ruler can then draw upon capacities accumulated before their use became necessary.

Weaker still:

Continuational resilience is produced before adversity by converting available time, practical experience, simulated alternatives, and retained historical results into capacities and remedies that remain accessible when conditions change.

CHAPTER XV

THE QUALITIES FOR WHICH PEOPLE, ESPECIALLY PRINCES, ARE PRAISED OR CONDEMNED

It remains now to examine what conduct and methods of government a prince should use toward his subjects or his friends.

I know that many have written about this. I fear that, by writing about it as well, I may be considered presumptuous—especially because, in discussing this subject, I depart from the methods followed by others.

But because my intention is to write something useful to whoever understands it, I have judged it more appropriate to follow the *verità effettuale* of the matter—its truth in actual operation—rather than its imagined form.

Many have imagined republics and principalities that have never been seen or known to exist in reality.

The distance between how people live and how they ought to live is so great that whoever abandons what is done for what ought to be done learns how to bring about his ruin rather than his preservation.

For a man who wishes to make a profession of being good in every respect must come to ruin among so many who are not good.

Therefore, a prince who wishes to preserve himself must learn how to be capable of not being good, and must use or refrain from using that capacity according to *necessità*.

Leaving aside, then, imagined accounts of a prince and discussing those that are true, I say that all people, whenever they are spoken about—and especially princes, because they occupy higher positions—are characterized by some of the following qualities, which bring them either blame or praise.

One is considered generous, another miserly. I use *misero*, a Tuscan term, because in our language *avaro* also describes someone who seeks to acquire through plunder, whereas we call *misero* someone who is excessively reluctant to use what is his own.

One is considered a giver, another rapacious;

one cruel, another merciful;

one a breaker of faith, another faithful;

one effeminate and fainthearted, another fierce and courageous;

one humane, another arrogant;

one lascivious, another chaste;

one sincere, another cunning;

one unyielding, another accommodating;

one serious, another frivolous;

one religious, another unbelieving;

and so on.

I know that everyone will acknowledge that it would be most praiseworthy for a prince to possess all the qualities listed above that are considered good.

But because the conditions of human life do not permit all of them to be possessed or completely practiced, a prince must be prudent enough to know how to avoid the disgrace attached to those vices that would cost him his state.

He should also guard against those that would not cost him his state, if possible. But when that is impossible, he may give way to them with fewer reservations.

Furthermore, he should not be troubled by incurring the disgrace attached to vices without which he could preserve the state only with difficulty.

For when everything is carefully considered, one will find some quality that appears to be a virtue but, if followed, would bring about his ruin; and another that appears to be a vice but, if followed, produces his security and well-being.

An AC Weakening

When particular virtues, vices, and conventional descriptions of rulers are removed while the evaluative structure is preserved:

Guidance intended to preserve an actual continuation must be answerable to the relations and conduct that are operationally present, not to an imagined organization whose participants behave as they ought. A strategy that depends upon conditions unavailable in the organization cannot remain effective merely because it would be admirable under different conditions.

Public praise and condemnation classify conduct according to socially retained categories. Those classifications do not by themselves establish the consequences of that conduct. A quality identified as virtuous may expose its practitioner to agents who do not reciprocate it, while a quality identified as vicious may supply a capacity required for preservation under the existing conditions.

Because a finite agent cannot fully realize every praised quality under every circumstance, prudence requires distinguishing among their consequences. The ruler must first avoid conduct that would terminate the governing continuation, should avoid other discrediting conduct when possible, and must retain the capacity to depart from conventionally praised conduct when necessità makes that departure functionally necessary.

Retaining the capacity not to act well is not identical to exercising it continually. The required capacity lies in conditional selection: recognizing when ordinarily praised

conduct remains compatible with preservation, when it becomes destructive, and when ordinarily condemned conduct supplies a necessary remedy.

Functional preservation, reputational approval, and moral admissibility therefore remain distinct evaluations. Demonstrating that conduct preserves a ruler or state does not establish that the conduct is ethically justified; it establishes only its relation to the continuation Machiavelli has selected for analysis.

Weaker still:

The received classification of an action does not determine its contribution to a specified continuation. Its functional admissibility depends upon the actual conditions, dependencies, and consequences under which it is performed.

CHAPTER XVI

GENEROSITY AND PARSIMONY

Beginning, then, with the first of the qualities listed above, I say that it would be good to be considered generous.

Nevertheless, generosity practiced in such a way that you acquire that reputation harms you. For if it is practiced virtuously and as it ought to be practiced, it will not be recognized, and the disgrace attached to its opposite will not fall away from you.

Therefore, to preserve among people the name of generosity, a prince must omit no display of sumptuousness. A prince of this kind will always consume all his resources in such works. In the end, if he wishes to preserve the name of generosity, he will be compelled to burden the people extraordinarily, become aggressively extractive in raising revenue, and do everything possible to obtain money.

This will begin to make him hated by his subjects and, once poor, little esteemed by anyone. In this way, through his generosity, he will have injured the many and rewarded the few; he will feel the first hardship and be endangered by the first peril.

If he recognizes this and tries to draw back, he immediately incurs the disgraceful name of being miserly.

A prince, therefore, cannot practice the virtue of generosity in a publicly recognized way without harming himself. If he is prudent, he should not care about being called miserly.

Over time he will be considered increasingly generous, when people see that, because of his parsimony, his revenues are sufficient; that he can defend himself against anyone who makes war on him; and that he can undertake campaigns without burdening the people.

In this way, he comes to practice generosity toward all those from whom he takes nothing—and they are countless—and miserliness toward all those to whom he gives nothing—and they are few.

In our own times, we have seen great things accomplished only by those who were considered miserly. The others have been destroyed.

Pope Julius II used his reputation for generosity to attain the papacy. Afterward he gave no thought to preserving it, so that he could make war.

The present King of France has waged many wars without imposing an extraordinary tax upon his subjects, solely because his long-standing parsimony supplied the additional expenses.

The present King of Spain, had he been considered generous, would neither have undertaken nor won so many campaigns.

A prince should therefore care little about incurring the name of miserly if this enables him not to rob his subjects, to defend himself, to avoid becoming poor and contemptible, and to avoid being forced to become rapacious. For this is one of those vices that enables him to rule.

Someone may object: “Caesar attained imperial power through generosity, and many others, because they were generous and were considered so, have risen to the highest ranks.”

I answer: either you are already an established prince, or you are on the way to acquiring a principality.

In the first case, this generosity is harmful. In the second, it is certainly necessary to be considered generous.

Caesar was one of those who sought to attain the principality of Rome. But if, after attaining it, he had survived and had not moderated his expenditures, he would have destroyed that empire.

Someone may reply that many princes who were considered extremely generous accomplished great things with their armies.

I answer that a prince spends either what belongs to himself and his subjects or what belongs to others.

In the first case, he must be parsimonious. In the second, he should omit no part of generosity.

A prince who campaigns with armies and lives on booty, plunder, and imposed contributions is handling what belongs to others. This generosity is necessary to him; otherwise, his soldiers would not follow him.

A prince can give more lavishly from what belongs neither to himself nor to his subjects, as Cyrus, Caesar, and Alexander did. Spending what belongs to others does not diminish your reputation; it increases it. Only spending what belongs to you harms you.

Nothing consumes itself as completely as generosity. While you practice it, you destroy your capacity to continue practicing it.

You become either poor and contemptible or, in order to escape poverty, rapacious and hated.

Among all the conditions against which a prince must guard are being contemptible and being hated. Generosity leads to both.

It is therefore wiser to accept the name of miserly, which produces disgrace without hatred, than, in seeking the name of generous, to be forced to incur the name of rapacious, which produces disgrace accompanied by hatred.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, particular expenditures, and conventional reputations are removed while the resource dependencies are preserved:

A positively regarded quality may require visible and repeated performances in order to remain socially recognized. If each performance consumes the resources required for its repetition, maintaining the reputation progressively destroys the capacity upon which the practice depends.

Once internal resources are exhausted, the ruler must either discontinue the performance and immediately lose the desired reputation or obtain additional resources through increased extraction. The benefits displayed to a limited group are then financed by burdens imposed upon a larger population. Apparent generosity toward the few becomes distributed injury to the many, producing both hatred through extraction and contempt through depletion.

A negatively regarded restraint may produce the inverse result. By preserving internally retained resources, the ruler remains capable of defense and extraordinary action without imposing new burdens upon the population. What appears locally as refusal to give can therefore operate more generally as non-extraction. Over time, the consequences of restraint may alter the reputation initially attached to it.

The same conduct also changes function across organizational conditions. Visible generosity may contribute to acquiring a position because it attracts initial support, yet

undermine preservation after the position has been obtained. Its effect also depends upon whose resources are being distributed. Giving away resources retained by the ruler and his subjects diminishes their continuation; distributing resources taken from outsiders rewards followers without immediately diminishing the ruler's internal foundation.

The latter generosity is not costless. It preserves the contributing military organization by transferring its cost to another population. Conduct can therefore appear beneficial within the ruler's local continuation while remaining destructive relative to the larger organization upon which that benefit is imposed.

Weaker still:

A practice is not organizationally sustainable when each performance reduces the retained capacity required to perform it again. When reputation demands its continuation, depletion forces compensatory extraction and can transform an apparent benefit into broadly distributed harm.

CHAPTER XVII

CRUELTY AND MERCY, AND WHETHER IT IS BETTER TO BE LOVED THAN FEARED, OR RATHER FEARED THAN LOVED

Moving next to the other qualities mentioned above, I say that every prince should desire to be regarded as merciful and not cruel. Nevertheless, he must take care not to misuse this mercy.

Cesare Borgia was regarded as cruel. Yet his cruelty had put the Romagna back in order, united it, and brought it to peace and loyalty.

If this is considered carefully, one can see that he was much more merciful than the Florentine people, who, to escape the name of cruel, allowed Pistoia to be destroyed.

A prince, therefore, should not be troubled by the disgrace of being called cruel when this enables him to keep his subjects united and loyal. With very few exemplary punishments, he will be more merciful than those who, through excessive mercy, allow disorders to continue, from which killings and robberies arise. These disorders ordinarily injure an entire community, whereas executions ordered by the prince injure a particular individual.

Of all princes, it is impossible for a new prince to escape the name of cruel, because new states are full of dangers. Virgil places these words in the mouth of Dido:

“Harsh circumstances and the newness of my reign compel me
to take such measures and guard my borders far and wide.”

Nevertheless, a prince should be deliberate in believing and acting. He should not frighten himself, and he should proceed in a measured way, with prudence and humanity, so that excessive confidence does not make him incautious and excessive distrust does not make him intolerable.

From this arises a dispute: whether it is better to be loved than feared, or the reverse.

The answer is that a prince should wish to be both. But because it is difficult to join the two together, it is much safer to be feared than loved when one of them must be lacking.

For this may generally be said of people: they are ungrateful and fickle, pretenders and dissemblers; they flee danger and crave gain.

As long as you benefit them, they are wholly yours. They offer you their blood, property, lives, and children—as I said above—when the need is far away. But when it approaches, they turn against you.

A prince who has based himself entirely upon their promises, finding himself without other preparations, is ruined. Friendships acquired at a price, rather than through greatness and nobility of spirit, may be bought, but they are not possessed; when the time comes, they cannot be spent.

People are less reluctant to injure someone who makes himself loved than someone who makes himself feared. Love is maintained by a bond of obligation which, because people are bad, is broken whenever their own advantage gives them an opportunity. Fear is maintained by dread of punishment, which never fails you.

Nevertheless, the prince must make himself feared in such a way that, if he does not acquire love, he avoids hatred. Being feared without being hated can very well exist together.

He will always achieve this if he refrains from the property of his citizens and subjects and from their women.

If he must nevertheless proceed against someone’s life, he should do so only when there is proper justification and evident cause. Above all, however, he must refrain from the property of others, because people forget the death of a father sooner than the loss of an inheritance.

Moreover, reasons for taking property never fail. Anyone who begins to live by plunder always finds a reason to seize what belongs to others. By contrast, reasons for taking life are rarer and run out sooner.

But when the prince is with his armies and commands a multitude of soldiers, it is then entirely necessary not to care about the name of cruel. Without that name, an army has never been kept united or ready for any operation.

Among Hannibal's remarkable actions is this: although he had an enormous army composed of innumerable peoples and led it to wage war in foreign lands, no dissension ever arose either among them or against their commander, in bad fortune or in good.

This could have arisen from nothing other than his inhuman cruelty, which, together with his many forms of *virtù*, always made him revered and terrifying in the eyes of his soldiers. Without that cruelty, his other forms of *virtù* would not have been sufficient to produce this effect.

Writers who reflect too little upon the matter admire this achievement on the one hand and condemn its principal cause on the other.

That his other forms of *virtù* would not have been sufficient can be seen in Scipio, one of the most exceptional men not only of his own time but in all recorded history. His armies in Spain mutinied against him.

This arose from nothing other than his excessive mercy, which had given his soldiers more latitude than was consistent with military discipline. Fabius Maximus reproached him for this in the Senate and called him a corrupter of Roman military discipline.

After the Locrians had been destroyed by one of Scipio's lieutenants, Scipio neither avenged them nor corrected the lieutenant's abusive conduct. All of this arose from his lenient nature.

So much so that, when someone wished to excuse him in the Senate, he said that there were many men who knew better how not to make errors than how to correct them.

In time, this nature would have damaged Scipio's fame and glory had he persisted in it while holding command. But because he lived under the government of the Senate, this harmful quality was not only concealed; it brought him glory.

I conclude, then, returning to being feared and loved: because people love according to their own choosing and fear according to the prince's choosing, a wise prince must base himself upon what is his own, not upon what belongs to others. He must only take care to avoid hatred, as has been said.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, military examples, and conventional moral labels are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing practice cannot be evaluated solely by the reputation attached to it. Restraint that permits disorder to continue may distribute injury throughout an entire population, while limited and directed punishment may constrain the relations producing that disorder. Machiavelli therefore distinguishes the apparent mercy of the ruler's conduct from the total injuries propagated through the organization. Functional containment does not make cruelty morally good, but the avoidance of a cruel reputation does not by itself make the resulting continuation merciful.

The exercise of coercion must remain bounded by evaluable conditions. Excessive confidence leaves threats unrecognized; excessive distrust makes the ruler intolerable and can produce the opposition he fears. Preservation therefore requires deliberate judgment, sufficient evidence, proportional action, and retention of humanity rather than either indiscriminate confidence or indiscriminate punishment.

Love and fear establish different dependencies. Love remains conditional upon the continuing voluntary attachment of those who provide it. Low-cost promises made while danger is distant do not establish that the same contributors will accept high costs when danger becomes immediate. Support purchased through benefits may produce present expressions of loyalty without producing commitment that remains available during adversity.

Fear supported by credible punishment is more directly controlled by the ruler, but it remains stabilizing only while it does not become hatred. Hatred supplies the governed with a shared motive for terminating the ruler's continuation. Coercion must therefore remain predictable and bounded, particularly against repeated intrusion into relations people regard as their own. Systematic seizure of property is especially destabilizing because it preserves both an enduring grievance and a renewable incentive for the ruler to continue predation.

The degree of discipline required also varies with the organization governed. A heterogeneous force operating under extreme danger may require constraints different from those appropriate to an ordinary civil population. The consequences of a ruler's disposition further depend upon institutional containment: a larger governing organization may restrain, correct, or absorb the failures produced by an individual commander, allowing a personally unsuitable quality to acquire a favorable reputation without exposing the whole continuation to its consequences.

Weaker still:

A continuation dependent upon voluntary attachment outside the ruler's control is less reliable under adversity than one supported by internally retained enforcement. Enforcement remains stabilizing, however, only while it constrains defection without generating hatred sufficient to organize an opposing continuation.

CHAPTER XVIII

HOW PRINCES SHOULD KEEP FAITH

Everyone understands how praiseworthy it is for a prince to keep faith, to live with integrity, and not with cunning. Nevertheless, experience in our own times shows that the princes who have accomplished great things have held faith of little account and have known how to manipulate people's minds through cunning. In the end, they have overcome those who based themselves upon loyalty.

You must therefore know that there are two kinds of fighting: one with laws and the other with force.

The first belongs to human beings; the second belongs to beasts. But because the first is often insufficient, it becomes necessary to resort to the second. A prince must therefore know how to use both the beast and the human being.

The ancient writers taught this lesson to princes indirectly. They tell how Achilles and many other ancient princes were given to Chiron the centaur to be raised and kept under his discipline.

To have a teacher who was half beast and half human means nothing other than that a prince must know how to use both natures. One without the other cannot endure.

Since a prince is therefore compelled to know how to use the beast, he should take from among the beasts the fox and the lion. The lion cannot defend itself against traps, and the fox cannot defend itself against wolves.

One must therefore be a fox to recognize the traps and a lion to frighten the wolves. Those who rely only upon the lion do not understand the matter.

A prudent ruler therefore cannot—and should not—keep faith when keeping it would work against him and when the reasons that caused him to make the promise have ceased to exist.

If people were all good, this precept would not be sound. But because they are bad and would not keep faith with you, you too need not keep faith with them.

Nor will a prince ever lack plausible reasons with which to give his failure to keep faith the appearance of legitimacy.

One could give innumerable modern examples of this and show how many peace agreements and promises have been rendered null and void by the faithlessness of princes. The prince who has known best how to use the fox has fared best.

But he must know how to disguise this nature well and must be a great pretender and dissembler. People are so simple and so governed by immediate necessities that anyone who deceives will always find someone who lets himself be deceived.

I do not wish to leave one recent example unmentioned.

Alexander VI never did anything, and never thought of anything, except deceiving people; and he always found someone upon whom he could practice it.

No man ever made assertions more forcefully, confirmed them with greater oaths, or kept them less. Nevertheless, his deceptions always succeeded exactly as he wished, because he understood this aspect of the world well.

A prince, therefore, does not need actually to possess all the qualities described above, but he very much needs to appear to possess them.

Indeed, I will dare to say this: possessing them and invariably practicing them is harmful, while appearing to possess them is useful.

A prince should appear merciful, faithful, humane, upright, and religious—and should indeed be so. But he must keep his mind prepared in such a way that, when it becomes necessary not to be so, he can and knows how to change to the opposite.

It must be understood that a prince, and especially a new prince, cannot consistently observe all the practices for which people are considered good. To preserve the state, he is often compelled to act against faith, against charity, against humanity, and against religion.

He must therefore have a mind prepared to turn as the winds and variations of *fortuna* command him. As I said above, he should not depart from the good when he is able to remain within it, but he must know how to enter into evil when necessity compels him.

A prince must therefore take great care that nothing ever comes from his mouth which is not filled with the five qualities described above. To anyone who sees and hears him, he should appear entirely merciful, entirely faithful, entirely upright, entirely humane, and entirely religious.

There is no quality more necessary to appear to possess than this last one.

People generally judge more with their eyes than with their hands, because everyone is able to see, while only a few are able to experience directly.

Everyone sees what you appear to be; few experience what you actually are. Those few do not dare oppose the opinion of the many, because that opinion is protected by the majesty of the state.

In the actions of all people, and especially of princes, where there is no higher judgment to which one can appeal, people look to the outcome.

A prince should therefore make it his aim to prevail and preserve the state. His means will always be judged honorable and praised by everyone, because the multitude is always won over by appearances and by the outcome of events.

The world consists almost entirely of the multitude, and the few have no room to act when the many have something upon which to rely.

A certain prince of the present time, whom it is better not to name, never preaches anything except peace and faith, yet he is utterly hostile to both. Had he observed either one, it would more than once have cost him either his reputation or his state.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, animal metaphors, and particular deceptions are removed while the organizational and representational dependencies are preserved:

A governing continuation may rely upon two different capacities: coordination through shared laws and commitments, and compulsion through force. Neither capacity answers every threat. Rule-governed conduct cannot constrain actors who abandon the shared rules, while force without sufficient perception cannot recognize deception or avoid traps. Durable power therefore requires both the capacity to recognize concealed relations and the capacity to respond when ordinary coordination fails.

A promise establishes an expected future continuation between participants. Machiavelli treats that continuation as conditional upon the circumstances and reciprocal conduct that produced it. When those conditions disappear, the ruler may abandon the promised continuation. Deception enters when the ruler retains the public articulation of fidelity while privately reserving the power to determine whether its conditions still apply. Plausible justification then preserves the appearance of the commitment after its operative relation has been terminated.

The ruler can consequently separate represented character from actual conduct. Publicly accessible qualities remain stable—mercy, fidelity, humanity, integrity, and religion—while privately exercised conduct changes with circumstance. The ruler's functional flexibility is purchased by preventing those subject to his actions from obtaining reliable access to the decision rule governing that change.

This separation is sustainable because access to conduct is asymmetrically distributed. The multitude ordinarily encounters the ruler through public language, visible ceremony, selected actions, and apparent outcomes. Only a few possess direct access to contrary conduct, and those few may lack the authority or safety required to alter the judgment of the many. The power of the state can therefore protect the public representation against evidence available to less powerful observers.

Where no higher adjudicating organization can evaluate the ruler's means, successful preservation of the state becomes publicly available as evidence that those means were justified. Outcome, appearance, and institutional authority reinforce one another: success validates the representation, the representation organizes popular approval, and popular approval isolates those capable of contradicting it.

Weaker still:

A dominant organization can preserve a public identity inconsistent with its conduct when access to that conduct is unequal, authoritative representation is under its control, and those possessing contrary evidence lack the capacity to alter shared evaluation. Deception thereby converts informational asymmetry into political continuity at the cost of shared evaluability.

CHAPTER XIX

HOW A PRINCE SHOULD AVOID BEING DESPISED AND HATED

Because I have discussed the most important of the qualities mentioned above, I will consider the others briefly under this general rule: as has already been said in part, a prince should think about avoiding whatever makes him hated or despised.

Whenever he avoids these things, he will have fulfilled his part and will find no danger in the disgrace attached to his other qualities.

What makes him hated above all, as I have said, is being rapacious and seizing the property and women of his subjects. He must refrain from these things.

Whenever the people as a whole are deprived of neither their property nor their honor, they live contentedly. The prince then has to contend only with the ambition of a few, which can be restrained easily and in many ways.

What makes him contemptible is being regarded as inconstant, frivolous, effeminate, fainthearted, and irresolute. A prince should guard against these qualities as against a reef.

He should endeavor to make greatness, courage, gravity, and strength recognizable in his actions.

In the private affairs of his subjects, he should insist that his judgment be irrevocable. He should maintain such an opinion of himself that no one thinks either of deceiving or manipulating him.

A prince who creates this opinion of himself commands great respect. It is difficult to conspire against or attack a ruler who commands respect, provided he is understood to be capable and revered by his own people.

A prince must therefore have two fears: one internal, concerning his subjects, and the other external, concerning foreign powers.

Against the external danger, he defends himself with good arms and good friends. If he has good arms, he will always have good friends.

Internal affairs will ordinarily remain stable when external affairs remain stable, unless they have already been disturbed by a conspiracy.

Even when foreign powers move against him, if his state is properly organized, if he has lived as I have described, and if he does not lose heart, he will withstand every assault—as I said Nabis the Spartan did.

But regarding his subjects, when foreign affairs are quiet, he must fear that they may conspire secretly.

The prince protects himself against this danger to a great degree by avoiding being hated or despised and by keeping the people satisfied with him. As was explained at length above, achieving this is necessary.

One of the most powerful remedies a prince has against conspiracies is not being hated by the people as a whole. Anyone who conspires always believes that by killing the prince he will satisfy the people. But when he believes that killing the prince would offend them, he does not acquire the courage to undertake it, because the difficulties facing conspirators are innumerable.

Experience shows that there have been many conspiracies, but few have ended successfully.

A conspirator cannot act alone, and he cannot seek companions except among those he believes to be discontented. But the moment you reveal your intention to a discontented man, you give him a means of becoming contented: by exposing you, he can expect every advantage.

Seeing a certain reward on that side, and on yours a doubtful gain filled with danger, he must be either an extraordinarily loyal friend or an utterly obstinate enemy of the prince if he is to keep faith with you.

To reduce the matter to its essentials, on the conspirator’s side there is nothing but fear, anxiety, and suspicion of punishment to terrify him.

On the prince's side are the majesty of the principality, the laws, his friends, and the defenses of the state. When popular goodwill is added to all these things, it is nearly impossible for anyone to be rash enough to conspire.

Ordinarily, a conspirator must be afraid before committing the crime. In this case, he must also be afraid afterward, because once the act has been committed, the people will be his enemy and he can hope for no refuge.

One could give innumerable examples of this, but I will be satisfied with one from the time of our fathers.

Annibale Bentivoglio, grandfather of the present Annibale and prince of Bologna, was killed by the Canneschi, who conspired against him. No descendant remained except Messer Giovanni, who was still an infant.

Immediately after the murder, the people rose and killed all the Canneschi.

This arose from the popular goodwill enjoyed by the house of Bentivoglio in Bologna at that time.

That goodwill was so great that, after Annibale's death, no Bentivoglio remained in Bologna who could govern the state. But the Bolognese received information that a man of Bentivoglio birth was living in Florence and had until then been considered the son of a blacksmith.

They went to Florence for him and gave him the government of their city. He governed it until Messer Giovanni reached an age suitable for governing.

I conclude, therefore, that a prince should have little concern about conspiracies when the people are well disposed toward him. But when the people are hostile and hate him, he must fear everything and everyone.

Well-ordered states and wise princes have therefore taken the greatest care not to drive the powerful into desperation, while satisfying the people and keeping them content. This is one of the most important matters confronting a prince.

Among the kingdoms that are well ordered and governed in our own time is France. It possesses innumerable good institutions upon which the freedom of action and security of the king depend. Foremost among these is Parliament and its authority.

The person who organized that kingdom recognized the ambition and insolence of the powerful and judged that a bridle was necessary to restrain them.

On the other side, he recognized the hatred that the people as a whole bore toward the powerful—a hatred founded upon fear—and wished to make the people secure against them.

He did not want this conflict to become the king's particular responsibility, because that would expose the king to blame from the powerful when he favored the people and from the people when he favored the powerful.

He therefore established a third judge who, without burdening the king, could discipline the powerful and support the lesser people.

No arrangement could have been better or more prudent, or a greater source of security for the king and the kingdom.

From this, another notable rule can be drawn: princes should have burdensome measures administered by others, but should grant favors themselves.

I conclude again that a prince should esteem the powerful but must not make himself hated by the people.

Considering the lives and deaths of certain Roman emperors, it might appear to many that they provide examples contrary to my opinion. Some emperors lived admirably and displayed great *virtù* of spirit, yet nevertheless lost the empire or were killed by their own followers, who conspired against them.

To answer these objections, I will examine the qualities of several emperors and show that the causes of their ruin were not different from those I have already presented. I will also call attention to matters worth considering by anyone who reads the history of those times.

It will be sufficient to take all the emperors who succeeded to the empire from Marcus Aurelius, the philosopher, through Maximinus.

They were Marcus Aurelius; his son Commodus; Pertinax; Julianus; Severus; Severus's son Antoninus Caracalla; Macrinus; Heliogabalus; Alexander Severus; and Maximinus.

First it should be noted that, whereas other princes must contend only with the ambition of the powerful and the unruliness of the people, the Roman emperors faced a third difficulty: they had to endure the cruelty and greed of the soldiers.

This was so difficult that it caused the ruin of many emperors, because it was difficult to satisfy both the soldiers and the people.

The people loved peace and therefore loved moderate princes. The soldiers loved a prince of military spirit who was insolent, cruel, and rapacious.

They wanted him to exercise these qualities against the people so that they could receive double pay and give free expression to their own greed and cruelty.

Consequently, emperors who possessed neither by nature nor by skill a reputation great enough to keep both groups within bounds always came to ruin.

Most of them—especially those who came to the principality as new men—recognized the difficulty created by these two opposing dispositions and turned toward satisfying the soldiers, caring little about injuring the people.

This choice was necessary for them. Because princes cannot avoid being hated by someone, they must first endeavor not to be hated by the population as a whole.

When they cannot achieve this, they must use every means available to avoid the hatred of whichever collective body is more powerful.

Therefore, emperors who, because their rule was new, needed extraordinary support attached themselves to the soldiers rather than to the people. Whether this proved useful depended upon whether the emperor knew how to maintain his standing with the soldiers.

For the reasons given above, Marcus Aurelius, Pertinax, and Alexander Severus—although all lived moderately, loved justice, opposed cruelty, and were humane and benevolent—came to bad ends, with the exception of Marcus.

Marcus alone lived and died with the highest honor because he succeeded to the empire by hereditary right. He did not owe it either to the soldiers or to the people.

Furthermore, because he possessed many qualities that made him revered, he kept both groups within their proper bounds throughout his life and was never either hated or despised.

Pertinax, however, was made emperor against the wishes of the soldiers. Having grown accustomed to living without discipline under Commodus, they could not tolerate the honest life to which Pertinax wished to return them.

He therefore created hatred against himself. Contempt was then added to this hatred because he was old, and he came to ruin at the very beginning of his administration.

Here it must be noted that hatred is acquired through good actions as well as bad ones.

Therefore, as I said above, a prince who wishes to preserve the state is often compelled not to be good.

When the collective body you judge necessary for your preservation—whether the people, the soldiers, or the powerful—is corrupt, you must follow its disposition and satisfy it. Under those conditions, good actions become your enemies.

But let us come to Alexander Severus.

His goodness was so great that, among the other praises attributed to him, it was said that during the fourteen years he held the empire, no one was ever put to death by him without judgment.

Nevertheless, he was regarded as effeminate and as a man who allowed himself to be governed by his mother. For this he came to be despised. The army conspired against him and killed him.

Considering, by contrast, the qualities of Commodus, Severus, Caracalla, and Maximinus, you will find them extremely cruel and rapacious.

To satisfy the soldiers, they spared the people no kind of injury that could be inflicted upon them. All except Severus came to bad ends.

Severus possessed so much *virtù* that, by keeping the soldiers friendly, he was able to reign successfully even though the people were heavily burdened by him.

His qualities made him appear so remarkable to both the soldiers and the people that the people remained astonished and stunned, while the soldiers remained respectful and satisfied.

Because his actions were remarkable for a new prince, I wish to show briefly how well he knew how to employ the roles of the fox and the lion—the two natures that, as I said above, a prince must imitate.

Recognizing the cowardice of Emperor Julianus, Severus persuaded the army he commanded in Slavonia that it would be right to march upon Rome and avenge the death of Pertinax, who had been killed by the Praetorian Guard.

Under this pretext, without revealing that he aspired to the empire, he moved his army against Rome. He arrived in Italy before news of his departure had become known.

When he reached Rome, the Senate, acting from fear, elected him emperor, and Julianus was killed.

After this beginning, Severus faced two difficulties if he wished to make himself master of the entire state.

One was in Asia, where Niger, commander of the Asian armies, had himself proclaimed emperor. The other was in the west, where Albinus also aspired to the empire.

Because Severus judged it dangerous to reveal himself as an enemy of both men, he decided to attack Niger and deceive Albinus.

He wrote to Albinus that, having been elected emperor by the Senate, he wished to share that dignity with him. He sent Albinus the title of Caesar and, by a decree of the Senate, named him his colleague.

Albinus accepted these things as true.

But after Severus had defeated and killed Niger and pacified the East, he returned to Rome and complained in the Senate that Albinus, showing little gratitude for the benefits he had received, had treacherously attempted to kill him. Severus therefore claimed that he was compelled to punish Albinus's ingratitude.

He then went to find him in France and took from him both his state and his life.

Anyone who examines Severus's actions closely will find him an extremely fierce lion and an extremely cunning fox.

He will see Severus feared and revered by everyone, yet not hated by the armies. He will not be surprised that this new man was able to hold so great an empire, because Severus's immense reputation always defended him against the hatred that the people might otherwise have conceived because of his plundering.

Caracalla, his son, also possessed remarkable qualities that made him admirable in the eyes of the people and pleasing to the soldiers.

He was a military man, highly capable of enduring every hardship, and contemptuous of delicate food and every other luxury. These qualities made him loved by all the armies.

Nevertheless, his ferocity and cruelty were so great and so unheard of—for after innumerable individual killings he killed a large part of the population of Rome and the whole population of Alexandria—that he became hated throughout the world.

He also began to be feared by those closest to him. Consequently, he was killed by a centurion in the midst of his army.

Here it should be noted that deaths of this kind, carried out by the decision of a resolute and obstinate individual, cannot be avoided by princes. Anyone who does not care about dying can attack them.

Nevertheless, a prince should fear such attacks less because they are extremely rare.

He should only take care not to inflict a grave injury upon anyone he employs or keeps close to him in the service of his principality.

Caracalla had failed to take this precaution. He had disgracefully killed the brother of the centurion, threatened the centurion every day, and nevertheless continued to employ him as one of his bodyguards.

This was a reckless decision and one that was bound to ruin him, as it did.

But let us come to Commodus.

He could have held the empire with great ease because he had inherited it as the son of Marcus Aurelius. He needed only to follow in his father's footsteps, and he would have satisfied both the people and the soldiers.

But because he possessed a cruel and bestial nature, he turned toward indulging the armies and permitting them to live without discipline so that he could practice his rapacity against the people.

On the other hand, he did not preserve his dignity. He frequently descended into the theaters to fight with gladiators and performed other degrading actions unworthy of imperial majesty.

He therefore became contemptible in the eyes of the soldiers. Hated on one side and despised on the other, he was conspired against and killed.

It remains to describe the qualities of Maximinus.

He was an extremely warlike man. After the armies became disgusted with the softness of Alexander Severus, whom I discussed above, they killed Alexander and elected Maximinus to the empire.

He did not possess it for long, because two things made him hated and despised.

The first was his extremely low birth, since he had once tended sheep in Thrace. This was widely known and caused everyone to look upon him with great disdain.

The second was that, at the beginning of his principality, he delayed going to Rome and taking possession of the imperial seat. Meanwhile, he acquired a reputation for extreme cruelty because his prefects committed many cruel acts in Rome and throughout the empire.

The entire world was therefore moved, on one side, by indignation at the lowliness of his birth and, on the other, by hatred arising from fear of his ferocity.

First Africa rebelled. Then the Senate, the entire population of Rome, and all Italy conspired against him.

His own army joined them. While besieging Aquileia, it encountered difficulty taking the city. The soldiers became disgusted with his cruelty and, seeing that he had so many enemies, feared him less. They killed him.

I do not wish to discuss Heliogabalus, Macrinus, or Julianus. Because they were entirely contemptible, they were quickly extinguished.

I will instead come to the conclusion of this discussion.

The princes of our own time face less difficulty in having to satisfy their soldiers extraordinarily. Although they must give the soldiers some consideration, the matter is quickly resolved because none of these princes maintains permanently assembled armies that have become deeply embedded in the governments and administrations of provinces, as the armies of the Roman Empire had been.

Therefore, if it was then necessary to satisfy the soldiers more than the people, it was because the soldiers possessed more power than the people.

Now it is more necessary for all princes—except the Turk and the Sultan—to satisfy the people rather than the soldiers, because the people possess more power.

I except the Turk because he always keeps around him twelve thousand infantry and fifteen thousand cavalry, upon whom the security and strength of his kingdom depend. He must set aside every other consideration regarding the people and keep these soldiers friendly.

The kingdom of the Sultan is similar. Because it rests entirely in the hands of the soldiers, he too must keep them friendly without regard for the people.

You should note that the Sultan's state differs from all other principalities. It resembles the Christian papacy, which cannot be called either a hereditary principality or a new principality.

The sons of the former prince do not remain as heirs and rulers. Instead, the new ruler is elected to that position by those who possess the authority to do so.

Because this arrangement is long established, the state cannot be called a new principality. It contains none of the difficulties found in new principalities.

Although the prince is new, the institutions of the state are old and are organized to receive him as though he were their hereditary ruler.

But let us return to our subject.

Anyone who considers the preceding discussion will see that either hatred or contempt caused the ruin of the emperors named above.

He will also understand why, although some of them proceeded in one way and others in the opposite way, one ruler following either path sometimes came to a successful end while the others came to disastrous ends.

Because Pertinax and Alexander Severus were new princes, it was useless and harmful for them to imitate Marcus Aurelius, who ruled by hereditary right.

Likewise, it was ruinous for Caracalla, Commodus, and Maximinus to imitate Severus, because they did not possess sufficient *virtù* to follow in his footsteps.

Therefore, a new prince in a new principality cannot imitate the actions of Marcus Aurelius, nor is it necessary for him to follow all those of Severus.

Rather, he should take from Severus those qualities necessary to found his state and from Marcus those qualities appropriate and glorious for preserving a state that is already established and secure.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, political offices, and historical conspiracies are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

A governing continuation becomes vulnerable when potential opponents possess both a motive to terminate it and an expectation that termination can succeed. Hatred supplies the motive; contempt lowers the expected difficulty. Broadly distributed injury to property, honor, or personal security can create shared hatred, while inconsistency, irresolution, frivolity, and visible incapacity make resistance appear practicable. Recognizable competence and decisiveness therefore operate as deterrents only while they do not themselves produce generalized hatred.

Internal conspiracy is a coordinative undertaking. A conspirator must disclose his intention to others, but each disclosure gives the recipient a safer and more immediate benefit: he can betray the conspiracy to the ruler. Popular support increases this asymmetry. If the population favors the existing continuation, conspirators must fear not only failure before the act but isolation and retaliation afterward. Popular goodwill thus functions as a distributed defensive capacity that deprives an attempted replacement of expected recognition and refuge.

A ruler must nevertheless evaluate several contributing organizations whose objectives may conflict. Preservation cannot be secured by treating "the people," "the powerful," and "the armed forces" as equivalent sources of support. Their importance depends upon their numbers, independent capacities, institutional positions, and ability to terminate the ruler's continuation. When one organized body controls the continuation-critical capacity, the ruler may become locally dependent upon satisfying it even when its demands injure the containing population. Functional preservation under that dependency does not make those demands ethically admissible.

Institutional design can reduce the ruler's direct exposure to conflicts among these bodies. An independently recognized adjudicating organization can constrain powerful actors, protect less powerful participants, and absorb blame generated by burdensome decisions. The ruler thereby remains associated with benefits while the institution administers necessary restraints. This arrangement stabilizes the ruler partly by separating the governing function from the personal attribution of its adverse consequences.

No institutional arrangement removes every threat. An individual willing to die may act without needing a survivable continuation after the ruler's death. Such attacks are difficult to prevent, but the ruler increases their availability by gravely injuring someone who retains trusted physical or organizational access to him.

The consequences of personal conduct also depend upon the structure in which it occurs. A disposition sustainable for an inherited ruler may destroy a new ruler who lacks the same retained recognition. Conduct effective for an exceptionally capable founder may destroy an imitator who lacks the capacities that made it effective. Conversely, an old institution can receive a new officeholder through an established succession structure and supply continuity that the individual does not personally possess.

Historical imitation must therefore preserve relevant organizational conditions rather than reproduce visible conduct. A successor should select from an example only those relations appropriate to founding an insecure continuation or preserving one already established.

Weaker still:

A governing continuation is secure to the extent that widely distributed actors lack a shared motive to terminate it and concentrated powerful actors lack an expected opportunity to replace it. Hatred organizes the motive; contempt makes success appear available; institutions, popular support, and recognizable capacity raise the cost of coordinating an alternative.

CHAPTER XX

WHETHER FORTRESSES AND MANY OTHER MEASURES PRINCES TAKE EVERY DAY ARE USEFUL OR NOT

Some princes, in order to hold their states securely, have disarmed their subjects. Others have kept their subject cities divided into factions. Some have deliberately fostered opposition to themselves. Others have sought to win over those who were regarded with suspicion at the beginning of their rule. Some have built fortresses; others have demolished and destroyed them.

No definite judgment can be given about all these measures without examining the particular circumstances of the state in which such a decision must be made. Nevertheless, I will discuss them as broadly as the subject itself permits.

A new prince has never disarmed his subjects. On the contrary, when he has found them unarmed, he has always armed them. For when they are armed, their arms become yours. Those whom you suspected become loyal; those already loyal remain so; and your subjects become your supporters.

Because you cannot arm all your subjects, you can favor those whom you do arm and then deal more securely with the rest. The difference they see in their treatment makes the armed men indebted to you. The others excuse you, recognizing that those who face greater danger and assume greater obligation must also receive greater consideration.

But when you disarm your subjects, you immediately offend them. You show that you distrust them—whether because you regard them as cowardly or because you doubt their loyalty. Either judgment breeds hatred against you. And because you cannot remain unarmed yourself, you must turn to mercenary troops, whose character has already been explained. Even if they were good, they could never be numerous or strong enough to defend you against both powerful enemies and suspicious subjects.

Therefore, as I have said, a new prince in an entirely new principality has always organized his own armed forces. History is full of such examples.

But when a prince acquires a new state that is added like a member to his old one, he must disarm that newly acquired territory, except for those who supported him in its conquest. Even these supporters, as time and opportunities allow, must be made soft and effeminate. He must arrange matters so that all the arms of his state are concentrated in his own soldiers—those who live near him in his original state.

Our ancestors, and those who were considered wise, used to say that Pistoia had to be held through factions and Pisa through fortresses. For this reason, they fostered divisions in some of their subject cities so that they could possess them more easily.

When Italy existed in a certain balance of power, this may have been well advised. But I do not believe that it can be given as a rule today. I do not believe that deliberately created divisions ever do any good. On the contrary, when an enemy approaches, a divided city will necessarily be lost at once. The weaker faction will always attach itself to the foreign power, while the stronger faction will be unable to resist by itself.

The Venetians, moved, I believe, by the reasoning just described, fostered the Guelf and Ghibelline factions in their subject cities. Although they never allowed these factions to come to bloodshed, they kept their disagreements alive so that the citizens, occupied with their internal divisions, would not unite against Venice. But this policy did not serve them well. After the Venetians were defeated at Vailà, one of the factions immediately took courage and deprived them of the whole territory.

Methods of this kind therefore reveal a prince's weakness. Such divisions will never be permitted in a vigorous principality. They are useful only in time of peace, when they make subjects easier to manage. When war comes, the falsity of the policy is exposed.

Princes undoubtedly become great when they overcome the difficulties and opposition raised against them. Thus *fortuna*—especially when it wishes to make a new prince great, since a new prince has a greater need to acquire reputation than a hereditary one—causes enemies to arise and launches attacks against him. This gives him the opportunity to overcome them and to climb higher by the very ladder his enemies have brought him.

For this reason, many judge that a wise prince, when he has the opportunity, should cunningly foster some hostility against himself, so that by crushing it he may increase his own greatness.

Princes, especially new ones, have often found greater loyalty and usefulness in those who were considered suspicious at the beginning of their rule than in those who were trusted from the start. Pandolfo Petrucci, prince of Siena, governed his state more through men who had once been regarded with suspicion than through the others.

No broad rule can be given here, because the matter varies according to the people involved. I will say only this: former enemies who cannot maintain their position without support can usually be won over by the prince with the greatest ease. They are compelled to serve him all the more faithfully because they recognize how necessary it is to erase, through their actions, the unfavorable opinion previously held of them. The prince therefore gains more useful service from them than from those who, serving with too great a sense of security, neglect his affairs.

Because the subject requires it, I also wish to remind princes who have newly acquired a state through support from within that state to consider carefully what caused their supporters to favor them. If the cause was not a natural attachment to the new prince, but merely dissatisfaction with the former government, it will be extremely difficult to keep these supporters as friends. It will be impossible to satisfy them.

Anyone who carefully considers the reasons for this, using examples drawn from both ancient and modern affairs, will see that it is much easier for the prince to win as friends those who were content with the former government—and who were therefore originally his enemies—than those who became his friends and helped him seize the state because they were dissatisfied with it.

It has been customary for princes, in order to hold their states more securely, to build fortresses. These serve as a bridle and curb upon those who might plan to act against them, while also providing the prince with a secure refuge from a sudden assault. I approve of this practice because it has been used since antiquity.

Nevertheless, in our own time Messer Niccolò Vitelli demolished two fortresses in Città di Castello in order to retain that state. Guidobaldo, Duke of Urbino, after returning to the

dominion from which Cesare Borgia had expelled him, razed every fortress in that province to its foundations. He judged that without them he would be less likely to lose his state again. The Bentivogli, when they returned to Bologna, followed the same course.

Fortresses, therefore, are useful or useless according to the circumstances. If they help you in one respect, they injure you in another. The matter may be reasoned through in this way:

A prince who is more afraid of his own people than of foreigners should build fortresses. But a prince who is more afraid of foreigners than of his own people should do without them. The castle of Milan, built by Francesco Sforza, has caused—and will continue to cause—more trouble for the House of Sforza than any other disorder in that state.

The best fortress of all is not to be hated by the people. Even if you possess fortresses, they will not save you when the people hate you. Once a people has taken up arms, foreigners willing to assist them will never be lacking.

In our own time, fortresses do not appear to have helped any prince except the Countess of Forlì, after her husband, Count Girolamo, was killed. Her fortress enabled her to escape the first popular uprising, wait for aid from Milan, and recover her state. At that time, circumstances were such that no foreign power could come to the people's aid.

But later, when Cesare Borgia attacked her and her hostile people joined forces with the foreign invader, her fortresses were of little use. Both then and before, she would have been safer if she had not been hated by the people than she was through possessing fortresses.

Having considered all these things, I will praise both the prince who builds fortresses and the prince who does not. But I will condemn anyone who, trusting in fortresses, considers the hatred of the people unimportant.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, cities, factions, and particular defensive structures are removed while the conditional dependencies are preserved:

No defensive or political measure is useful independently of the organization in which it operates. Arming, disarming, dividing, reconciling, provoking, fortifying, and dismantling can each preserve one continuation while endangering another. Their consequences depend upon the ruler's position, the population's prior organization, the principal source of danger, and the relations the measure creates or removes.

Arming previously excluded participants can incorporate their capacity into a new governing continuation. Selection for increased danger and obligation creates reciprocal indebtedness, while the grant of arms communicates trust and converts suspected

subjects into recognized contributors. Disarmament communicates distrust, produces resentment, and forces the ruler to obtain protective capacity elsewhere. In an annexed organization that retains a possible independent continuation, however, the same armed capacity may remain available for separation. The ruler may then attempt to concentrate force within his original organization. The opposite prescriptions arise because the arms participate in different possible continuations.

Deliberately dividing a governed population can make it easier to manage under peaceful conditions by preventing coordinated opposition. The same division destroys collective defensive capacity under external threat. The weaker faction gains an incentive to attach itself to an invading organization, while the stronger faction cannot defend the whole alone. A local increase in the ruler's control therefore produces a larger decrease in the containing organization's resilience.

Opposition can become a developmental opportunity when overcoming it makes the ruler's capacities publicly recognizable and increases his standing. Deliberately producing opposition attempts to manufacture such an opportunity, but makes the ruler's desired continuation dependent upon his ability to contain the threat he has created.

Initial loyalty is not necessarily more durable than initial suspicion. A former opponent whose present continuation depends upon the ruler may have a strong incentive to demonstrate fidelity, while an established supporter who considers his standing secure may contribute negligently. Conversely, support originally produced by dissatisfaction with a former government remains conditional upon expectations of improvement. Once the new ruler cannot satisfy those expectations, the contribution that enabled acquisition becomes unavailable.

A physical fortress similarly changes function with the direction of danger. It can provide delay and refuge against a sudden internal attack, yet it may contribute little against a foreign opponent supported by a hostile population. When popular hatred supplies an invader with local entry, information, and assistance, material fortification cannot restore the missing social relation. A ruler may therefore be safer without a fortress that encourages reliance upon containment than with one that permits popular hostility to remain uncorrected.

Weaker still:

No political measure is organizationally useful in itself. Its admissibility depends upon which continuation it strengthens, which alternative continuations it leaves available, the direction of the anticipated threat, and whether immediate control is purchased by reducing longer-term collective resilience.

CHAPTER XXI

WHAT A PRINCE SHOULD DO TO BE HELD IN ESTEEM

Nothing causes a prince to be esteemed so highly as great undertakings and striking examples set through his own conduct.

In our own time, we have Ferdinand of Aragon, the present king of Spain. He may almost be called a new prince, because from being a weak king he has become, through fame and glory, the foremost king in Christendom. If you consider his actions, you will find them all great, and some extraordinary.

At the beginning of his reign, he attacked Granada, and that undertaking became the foundation of his state. At first, he conducted the war at his leisure and without fear of interference. He kept the minds of the Castilian barons occupied with it. While they were thinking about the war, they did not think about political change; and meanwhile, without their noticing, he acquired reputation and authority over them.

With money from the Church and the people, he was able to maintain armies. Through that long war, he laid a foundation for his military establishment, which later brought him honor.

Beyond this, so that he could undertake still greater enterprises, he continually made use of religion. He turned to an act of pious cruelty, expelling the Marranos from his kingdom and dispossessing them. No example could be more wretched or more extraordinary.

Under this same cloak, he attacked Africa, undertook his campaign in Italy, and most recently attacked France. Thus he has always performed and devised great things, keeping the minds of his subjects suspended in expectation and filled with admiration, continually occupied with the outcomes.

His actions have followed one from another in such a way that, between one undertaking and the next, he has never given people enough time to organize sustained action against him.

It also helps a prince greatly to set striking examples in the government of his own state, like those told of Messer Bernabò of Milan. When someone does something extraordinary in civil life, whether good or bad, the prince should seize the occasion to reward or punish that person in a manner that will be widely discussed.

Above all, a prince should endeavor in every action to acquire the reputation of being a great and exceptional man.

A prince is also esteemed when he is a true friend and a true enemy—that is, when he openly declares himself, without reservation, in favor of one side against another. This course will always be more useful than remaining neutral.

Suppose two powerful neighboring states come to blows. Either they are such that you will have reason to fear whichever one wins, or they are not.

In either case, it will always be more useful for you to declare yourself and fight wholeheartedly.

In the first case, if you do not declare yourself, you will always become the victor's prey, to the pleasure and satisfaction of the defeated party. You will have neither a claim upon anyone nor anyone with reason to defend or shelter you. The victor does not want doubtful friends who refused assistance in adversity; and the defeated party will not receive you, because you were unwilling to take up arms and share his *fortuna*.

Antiochus entered Greece after being invited by the Aetolians to drive out the Romans. He sent ambassadors to the Achaeans, who were friends of Rome, encouraging them to remain outside the conflict. The Romans, from the other side, urged them to take up arms on Rome's behalf.

The question was debated in the council of the Achaeans. There, Antiochus's representative urged them to remain neutral. The Roman representative replied:

"As for what these men say—that you should not intervene in the war—nothing could be more contrary to your interests. Without favor and without dignity, you will become the victor's prize."

It will always happen that the party that is not your friend will ask you to remain neutral, while the party that is your friend will ask you to declare yourself with arms. Irresolute princes, hoping to escape immediate dangers, most often follow the neutral course—and most often come to ruin.

But when a prince declares himself vigorously for one side, and the ruler with whom he has allied himself wins, then even if that ruler is powerful and you remain at his discretion, he is under an obligation to you, and a bond of attachment has been formed between you. Men are never so dishonorable that they would oppress you through so conspicuous an act of ingratitude.

Moreover, victories are never so complete that the victor can disregard every consideration, especially justice.

If the ruler with whom you have allied yourself loses, he will receive you; and as long as he is able, he will help you. You become the companion of a *fortuna* that may rise again.

Now consider the second case, in which the opposing powers are such that you have no reason to fear whichever one wins. Here, it is even more prudent to choose a side. With the assistance of one, you bring about the ruin of the other—the very power that your ally, had he been wise, ought to have preserved. Once your ally wins, he remains at your discretion; and with your assistance, it is impossible that he should fail to win.

Here it must be noted that a prince should never join with someone more powerful than himself to attack another, unless necessity compels him. For if the stronger ally wins, you become his prisoner; and princes should avoid, as far as possible, being placed at another's mercy.

The Venetians allied themselves with France against the Duke of Milan, although they could have avoided that alliance. Their ruin resulted from it.

But when such an alliance cannot be avoided—as happened to the Florentines when the pope and Spain marched their armies to attack Lombardy—the prince should then join one side for the reasons already given.

No state should ever believe that it can choose a completely safe course. It should assume that every available course is uncertain. It lies in the order of things that whenever we try to avoid one danger, we encounter another.

Prudence consists in knowing how to recognize the character of the different dangers and in accepting the least bad as good.

A prince should also show himself to be a supporter of *virtù* and should honor those who excel in every art and profession.

He should encourage his citizens to pursue their occupations securely and peacefully—in commerce, agriculture, and every other human activity. One person should not be afraid to improve his property for fear that it will be taken from him; another should not be afraid to open a business for fear of extraordinary levies.

Instead, the prince should provide rewards for those who undertake such activities and for anyone who, in any way, seeks to enlarge or strengthen his city or state.

At suitable times of the year, he should also keep the people occupied with festivals and public spectacles. Because every city is divided into guilds, civic bodies, or tribes, he should show regard for these associations. He should sometimes meet with them and offer examples of his humanity and munificence.

Nevertheless, he must always preserve the majesty of his rank, for this must never be absent from anything he does.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, wars, alliances, and public ceremonies are removed while the organizational and representational dependencies are preserved:

Political esteem is a retained public expectation concerning a ruler's capacity, judgment, and probable conduct. It is produced when consequential actions make those qualities widely recognizable. A striking reward or punishment extends beyond its immediate recipient by providing a public example from which others infer how comparable conduct will be treated.

Large undertakings can simultaneously achieve an external objective and reorganize the ruler's internal relations. They can occupy powerful contributors, develop military and administrative capacity, redirect resources, and increase the ruler's authority while attention remains fixed upon the undertaking. A continuous succession of extraordinary actions can also prevent subjects from obtaining the interval required to examine their condition and coordinate sustained opposition.

Publicly accepted moral or religious representation can make an undertaking socially admissible even when its actual operation is dispossession, expulsion, or cruelty. The ruler can thereby acquire esteem through the representational form of an action while its burdens are imposed upon a population excluded from the approving evaluation. Extraordinary reputation and ethical admissibility therefore remain separable.

Open alignment in a conflict creates relations unavailable to a neutral participant. Commitment supplies an ally with a reason to recognize reciprocal obligation after victory and gives a defeated ally reason to provide refuge and future assistance. Neutrality may avoid immediate exposure but leave the neutral organization without attachment to either resulting continuation, making it available as the victor's next acquisition.

Alignment nevertheless becomes dangerous when the ally possesses sufficient independent capacity to subordinate its contributor after their common opponent is removed. The value of commitment therefore depends upon the resulting distribution of power. Alliance with a stronger organization may become necessary, but it should not be mistaken for a continuation free of dependency.

No available course is completely safe. Avoiding one danger alters the relations through which another becomes available. Prudence therefore does not discover an unconditionally good continuation; it compares differently structured dangers and selects the one whose expected injuries and dependencies remain least destructive.

Esteem can also be developed through the capacities of the governed organization. Predictable security against confiscation and extraordinary extraction allows citizens to invest in activities whose results they expect to retain. Recognition and reward promote useful achievement, while participation in civic associations and shared occasions maintains relational access between ruler and population. The ruler may enter these

relations without dissolving the distinction upon which the authority of his office depends.

Weaker still:

A ruler acquires esteem by making capacity, commitment, and predictable judgment publicly recognizable through consequential action. Prudence consists not in finding a continuation without danger, but in selecting and publicly sustaining one whose resulting dependencies remain manageable.

CHAPTER XXII

CONCERNING THE MINISTERS PRINCES KEEP CLOSE TO THEM

The choice of ministers is no small matter for a prince. Whether they are good depends upon the prince's own judgment.

The first inference people draw about a ruler's intelligence comes from observing the people he keeps around him. When they are capable and loyal, the ruler may always be considered wise, because he has known how to recognize their ability and how to keep them loyal.

But when they are otherwise, an unfavorable judgment may always be made about him, because his first error was made in choosing them.

No one who knew Messer Antonio da Venafro as the minister of Pandolfo Petrucci, prince of Siena, failed to judge Pandolfo a man of the highest ability for having chosen Antonio as his minister.

There are three kinds of minds.

The first understands matters by itself.

The second discerns what someone else understands.

The third understands neither by itself nor through others.

The first is supremely excellent; the second is excellent; the third is useless.

It necessarily follows, therefore, that if Pandolfo did not possess the first kind of mind, he possessed the second. For whenever someone has sufficient judgment to recognize the good and the bad in what another person says or does, then even if he cannot originate

ideas for himself, he can recognize the bad and good actions of his minister. He praises the good and corrects the bad.

Such a minister cannot hope to deceive him and therefore remains good.

But how can a prince recognize the character of a minister? There is one method that never fails.

When you see a minister thinking more about himself than about you, and seeking his own advantage within every action, such a man will never be a good minister, and you will never be able to trust him.

A person who holds another man's state in his hands must never think of himself, but always of the prince. He must never bring before the prince anything that does not pertain to the prince's interests.

On the other hand, if the prince wishes to keep the minister good, he must also concern himself with the minister. He must honor him, make him wealthy, bind him through obligation, and share honors and responsibilities with him.

The minister must see that he cannot maintain his position without the prince. His many honors should leave him with no desire for further honors; his abundant wealth should leave him with no desire for further wealth; and his many responsibilities should make him fear political change.

When princes and ministers are related to one another in this way, they can trust each other. When they are related otherwise, the outcome will always be harmful to one or the other.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, ministers, and personal rewards are removed while the organizational and evaluative dependencies are preserved:

A ruler's selection of close contributors provides publicly accessible evidence of capacities that cannot otherwise be directly observed. Capable and faithful ministers indicate that the ruler can recognize competence and preserve its alignment; incapable or disloyal ministers reveal a prior failure of judgment in their selection or retention.

A ruler need not personally originate every useful understanding. Governing intelligence can be organizationally distributed if the ruler possesses sufficient evaluative capacity to distinguish sound advice from error, recognize beneficial and harmful conduct, reward the first, and correct the second. The capacity to understand another person's understanding can therefore make otherwise unavailable intelligence usable by the governing organization.

Delegation becomes dangerous when the ruler cannot evaluate either the minister's work or the dependencies directing it. A minister who controls continuation-critical functions while using them primarily to increase his own independent standing becomes an alternative center of organization. His apparent service may then operate as a means of redirecting the governing structure toward his own continuation.

Trust cannot rest solely upon an assumed personal quality. The ruler must organize the minister's incentives so that honor, resources, authority, and responsibility remain joined to the ruler's continuation. The minister should expect less advantage from defection than from continued participation and should understand that political change would endanger the position already acquired. The ruler, in return, must recognize and sustain the minister's contribution.

Reciprocal trust becomes possible when each participant can evaluate the other's conduct and when neither can improve his own continuation by making the shared governing relation fail.

Weaker still:

Delegated intelligence remains organizationally useful only when its results are evaluable by the organization receiving them and the contributor's continuation remains aligned with the continuation that delegation is intended to preserve.

CHAPTER XXIII

HOW FLATTERERS SHOULD BE AVOIDED

I do not wish to omit an important subject: an error against which princes defend themselves only with difficulty, unless they are exceedingly prudent or have chosen their advisers well.

This error concerns flatterers, with whom courts are filled.

People take so much pleasure in their own affairs and opinions, and deceive themselves so thoroughly about them, that they defend themselves against this plague only with difficulty. Yet in trying to defend themselves, they also risk becoming despised.

The only way to protect yourself against flattery is to make people understand that they will not offend you by telling you the truth. But when everyone is free to tell you the truth, you lose their reverence.

A prudent prince must therefore follow a third course.

He should select wise men within his state and give only those men the freedom to tell him the truth—and only concerning the matters about which he asks them, not whatever else they choose.

But he must ask them about everything and listen to their opinions. He must then deliberate by himself and decide in his own way.

He should conduct himself toward these advisers, both collectively and individually, so that each one understands that the more freely he speaks, the more acceptable he will be to the prince.

Outside this selected group, the prince should refuse to listen to anyone. Once he has decided upon a course, he should follow it and remain unyielding in his decision.

Anyone who acts otherwise is either brought to ruin by flatterers or changes his course repeatedly because opinions vary. From this continual alteration, he becomes poorly esteemed.

I wish to offer a modern example.

Father Luca, one of the men of Maximilian, the present emperor, said of His Majesty that he sought advice from no one and yet never did anything according to his own intentions. This resulted from following a course exactly opposite to the one just described.

The emperor is a secretive man. He communicates his plans to no one and seeks no one's opinion about them. But when he begins putting those plans into effect, they become known and visible. The people around him then begin to oppose them; and because he is easily swayed, he abandons them.

From this it follows that what he does one day, he destroys the next. No one ever understands what he wants or intends to do, and no one can rely upon his decisions.

A prince, therefore, should always take counsel—but when he wishes, not when others wish.

Indeed, he should discourage everyone from offering advice about anything unless he has asked for it. But he himself should ask questions broadly and frequently. Then, concerning the matters he has raised, he should listen patiently to the truth.

If he learns that anyone has withheld the truth from him because of some private consideration, he should become angry.

Many people believe that a prince who has a reputation for prudence owes that reputation not to his own nature, but to the good advisers around him. They are undoubtedly mistaken.

There is a general rule that never fails: a prince who is not wise in himself cannot be well advised, unless by chance he entrusts himself entirely to one exceptionally prudent man who governs him in everything.

In that case, he might be well governed—but only for a short time, because the man governing him would soon take his state from him.

But when an unwise prince consults more than one adviser, he will never receive unified counsel, nor will he know how to unify their different recommendations himself. Each adviser will think about his own private interest, and the prince will know neither how to recognize this nor how to correct it.

Advisers cannot be expected to behave otherwise, because people will always prove bad unless some necessity makes them good.

It must therefore be concluded that good counsel, from wherever it comes, must arise from the prince's own prudence. The prince's prudence does not arise from good counsel.

An AC Weakening

When courts, personal flatterers, and named rulers are removed while the informational and coordinative dependencies are preserved:

A decision-making organization cannot correct errors when its members expect truthful contradiction to be punished. Information that conflicts with the governing agent's preferred understanding then becomes unavailable, while affirming representations are repeatedly selected and reinforced. The agent's susceptibility to flattery is therefore partly an organizational failure in the conditions governing access to difference.

Unrestricted contradiction creates an opposite danger. If every participant can introduce unsolicited differences at any time, deliberation remains perpetually open, authority becomes indeterminate, and decisions change with each new influence. The organization requires a bounded interface through which relevant disagreement can enter without dissolving the distinction between advising and deciding.

The governing agent must therefore select capable advisers, establish questions for common consideration, and make candid answers safe and valued within that scope. Advisers should retain sufficient independence to articulate differences, while the decision-maker must compare their contributions, identify private interests, and integrate or reject their recommendations. Strategic withholding of relevant information must remain consequential if candor is to stay organizationally available.

After deliberation, the governing agent must produce closure. Advice remains input to the decision rather than an independent power to reopen it continually. A selected continuation must remain stable long enough to become actionable; repeated reversal makes the agent's intentions inaccessible and prevents other participants from coordinating their own conduct around the decision.

An agent incapable of evaluating counsel cannot be repaired merely by increasing the quality or quantity of advisers. Complete dependence upon one capable adviser transfers effective governance to that adviser. Dependence upon several advisers produces unresolved differences that the agent cannot compare or unify, while each adviser retains an opportunity to redirect the decision toward a private continuation. Good counsel becomes organizationally effective only through the recipient's capacity to elicit, evaluate, select, and close upon it.

Weaker still:

An organization remains corrigible only when it preserves protected access to relevant contradiction while retaining the capacity to delimit inquiry, compare differing contributions, select a continuation, and close deliberation. Without contradiction, error becomes self-reinforcing; without closure, difference becomes oscillation.

CHAPTER XXIV

WHY THE PRINCES OF ITALY HAVE LOST THEIR STATES

The instructions given above, if prudently followed, make a new prince appear long-established. They immediately render him more secure and more firmly rooted in his state than if he had been established there for a long time.

A new prince is watched much more closely in his actions than a hereditary prince. When his actions are recognized as displaying *virtù*, they win people over and bind them to him much more strongly than ancient bloodlines do.

People are much more affected by present conditions than by the past. When they find good in the present, they enjoy it and seek nothing further. Indeed, they will undertake every defense on the prince's behalf, provided he does not undermine himself in other respects.

Such a prince will therefore receive double glory: he founded a new principality, and then adorned and strengthened it with good laws, good arms, good friends, and good examples.

Conversely, a man who was born a prince and then lost his state through insufficient judgment will bear double shame.

If we consider those rulers who have lost their states in Italy during our own time—such as the king of Naples, the duke of Milan, and others—we will first find in them a common defect concerning their military forces, for the reasons discussed earlier.

We will then find that they either had the people as enemies or, when they had the people as friends, failed to secure themselves against the great.

Without defects of this kind, states possessing enough sinew to maintain an army in the field are not lost.

Philip of Macedon—not the father of Alexander, but the Philip who was defeated by Titus Quinctius—possessed only a small state compared with the power of the Romans and the Greeks who attacked him.

Nevertheless, because he was experienced in war, knew how to maintain the people's support, and knew how to secure himself against the great, he sustained the war against them for many years. Although he finally lost control of several cities, he nevertheless retained his kingdom.

Therefore, our Italian princes who had occupied their principalities for many years and then lost them should not blame *fortuna*. They should blame their own negligence and inertia.

During peaceful times, they never considered that conditions could change. This is a common human failing: people do not reckon with the storm while the sea is calm.

Then, when adverse times arrived, these princes thought about fleeing rather than defending themselves. They hoped that the people, wearied by the arrogance of the conquerors, would call them back.

When every other course is unavailable, this one may be good. But it is exceedingly bad to abandon every other remedy in reliance upon it.

No one should ever choose to fall merely because he expects to find someone who will catch him.

That either does not happen or, if it does, it does not restore you securely. Such a defense is weak because it does not depend upon you.

Only those defenses that depend upon you yourself and upon your own *virtù* are good, certain, and enduring.

An AC Weakening

When named rulers, territories, and historical defeats are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

The durability of a governing continuation is not determined solely by its age. A newly established ruler can rapidly acquire the recognition ordinarily supplied by inherited continuity when present conduct makes competence publicly accessible and produces conditions the governed wish to preserve. Because a new ruler's actions receive heightened attention, demonstrated capacity may bind contributors more strongly than an inherited claim whose present operation supplies no comparable benefit.

A new continuation becomes functionally established when it develops reliable laws, internally controlled force, supportive relations, and exemplary conduct. An inherited continuation can lose the same stability when it consumes those retained advantages without reproducing their foundations. Organizational inheritance supplies an initial condition, not a guarantee of continued availability.

External adversity does not by itself explain political loss. A materially sufficient organization remains vulnerable when its protective capacity is externally controlled, when the population has been made hostile, or when independently powerful contributors have not been constrained. Conversely, a smaller organization may remain continuable against a larger opponent when it retains military competence, popular support, internal order, and the capacity to absorb partial losses without terminating its governing core.

Preparation must occur before adverse conditions make it necessary. Peace that is treated as a permanent condition leaves no developed continuation for war. When disruption arrives, flight combined with hope of later restoration transfers the ruler's future entirely to the conduct of the conqueror and the changing preferences of the population. Even if restoration occurs, it does not produce security because the capacity that returned the ruler remains external to him.

A remedy is durable only insofar as the capacities required to enact it remain available to the organization seeking preservation. Expectation that another organization will eventually reverse one's failure is not a substitute for a defense capable of preventing that failure.

Weaker still:

Organizational durability arises from capacities retained under changing conditions, not from the age or inherited status of the continuation. External adversity often reveals rather than creates failure: the terminal dependency was established when the organization neglected to prepare capacities of its own.

CHAPTER XXV

HOW MUCH POWER FORTUNA HAS IN HUMAN AFFAIRS, AND HOW IT SHOULD BE RESISTED

I am well aware that many people have held, and still hold, the opinion that the affairs of the world are governed by *fortuna* and by God in such a way that human prudence cannot correct them and has no remedy against them.

From this, they might conclude that it is not worth laboring greatly over human affairs, but that one should allow oneself to be governed by chance.

This opinion has gained greater credibility in our own time because of the great instability of events that have been seen, and continue to be seen every day, beyond all human prediction.

When I have sometimes thought about this, I have partly inclined toward their opinion.

Nevertheless, so that our free will is not extinguished, I judge that it may be true that *fortuna* is the arbiter of half our actions—but that she leaves the government of the other half, or nearly so, to us.

I compare *fortuna* to one of those destructive rivers that, when enraged, flood the plains, tear down trees and buildings, carry away earth from one place, and deposit it in another.

Everyone flees before them. Everyone yields to their force, unable to resist them at that moment.

Yet although rivers behave in this way, people can still make provisions during peaceful conditions. They can construct embankments and barriers so that, when the waters rise again, they will either flow through a channel or their force will be less unrestrained and destructive.

The same is true of *fortuna*. She demonstrates her power wherever no organized *virtù* has been prepared to resist her. She directs her assaults wherever she knows that no embankments or barriers have been constructed to contain her.

If you consider Italy, which has been the center of these upheavals and has given them their movement, you will see a country without embankments and without any barrier.

If Italy had been protected by appropriate *virtù*, as Germany, Spain, and France have been, then this flood would either not have produced the enormous changes it has produced, or it would not have reached Italy at all.

Let this be sufficient concerning resistance to *fortuna* in general.

Turning now to particular cases, we see one prince prospering today and falling into ruin tomorrow, although his nature and qualities have not changed.

I believe this arises first from the causes discussed at length earlier: a prince who relies entirely upon *fortuna* falls when she changes.

I also believe that the person whose mode of proceeding agrees with the character of the times will be successful, while the person whose conduct conflicts with the times will be unsuccessful.

We see people proceeding differently toward the ends they place before themselves—glory and riches. One proceeds cautiously, another impetuously; one through force, another through skill; one through patience, another through its opposite.

Each may reach the same end through these different methods.

We also see two cautious people, one of whom achieves his purpose while the other does not. Similarly, we see two people prosper equally through different approaches, one being cautious and the other impetuous.

This results from nothing other than the character of the times, which either conforms or fails to conform to their ways of proceeding.

From this follows what I have said: two people acting differently may produce the same result, while two acting in the same way may find that one reaches his objective and the other does not.

Variations in success also depend upon this relationship.

Suppose someone governs himself cautiously and patiently, and the times and circumstances turn in such a way that his method is effective. He prospers.

But if the times and circumstances change, he falls into ruin because he does not change his way of proceeding.

No person can be found who is prudent enough to adapt himself fully to this. One reason is that a person cannot easily deviate from what his nature inclines him toward. Another is that someone who has always prospered by following one path cannot persuade himself to abandon it.

Consequently, when the time comes for a cautious person to act impetuously, he does not know how to do so, and therefore he is ruined.

If he could change his nature as the times and circumstances changed, his *fortuna* would not change.

Pope Julius II proceeded impetuously in everything he did. He found the times and circumstances so well aligned with his manner of proceeding that he always achieved a successful outcome.

Consider his first campaign against Bologna, while Messer Giovanni Bentivoglio was still alive. The Venetians were displeased with it, as was the king of Spain, and Julius was still discussing the undertaking with France.

Nevertheless, with his fierceness and impetuosity, he personally set out on the expedition.

This move kept Spain and the Venetians suspended and motionless: the Venetians through fear, and Spain through its desire to recover the entire kingdom of Naples.

From the other side, Julius drew the king of France after him. The king saw that Julius had already moved and wanted the pope as an ally in order to weaken the Venetians. He therefore judged that he could not refuse Julius his troops without openly insulting him.

Through this impetuous movement, Julius accomplished what no other pope, with all ordinary human prudence, could have accomplished.

Had he waited to leave Rome until firm agreements had been reached and everything had been arranged—as any other pope would have done—he would never have succeeded. The king of France would have found a thousand excuses, and the others would have raised a thousand fears.

I will leave aside Julius's other actions. They were all similar, and they all succeeded.

The brevity of his life did not allow him to experience the opposite result. If times had arrived in which it was necessary to proceed cautiously, his ruin would have followed. He would never have departed from the methods toward which his nature inclined him.

I conclude, therefore, that because *fortuna* changes while people remain obstinate in their accustomed methods, they are successful while the two agree and unsuccessful as soon as they diverge.

I nevertheless judge that it is better to be impetuous than cautious. For *fortuna* is a woman, and if one wishes to keep her under, it is necessary to beat and strike her.

We see that she allows herself to be conquered more readily by those who act impetuously than by those who proceed coldly.

Therefore, because she is a woman, she favors the young. They are less cautious, fiercer, and command her with greater audacity.

An AC Weakening

When personified fortuna, named rulers, and historical circumstances are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

Some changes affecting a continuation arise beyond the prediction or control of the agent attempting to preserve it. The existence of such variation does not make preparation useless. Capacities constructed during stable conditions can redirect, constrain, or reduce the propagation of disturbances that cannot be prevented at the moment they occur. Organized virtù does not eliminate fortuna; it changes the consequences through which fortuna becomes organizationally effective.

No mode of conduct produces success independently of its conditions. Caution, impetuosity, force, skill, patience, and their opposites become effective only through their fit with the relations currently operating. Different methods can reach the same objective under different conditions, while identical methods can produce opposite outcomes when their surrounding conditions differ.

Past success can reduce future adaptability. An agent repeatedly rewarded for one mode of conduct acquires both a dispositional habit and evidential confidence in that mode. When conditions change, the previously successful method remains most readily available even after its fit has disappeared. The agent's retained history then prevents selection of the alternative continuation required by the changed circumstances.

Observed success does not establish that the successful method is generally superior. A method may appear consistently effective because the conditions opposing it never arise during the period observed. The termination of the agent's life or rule can conceal the failure that would have appeared under a later change of conditions.

Resistance to fortuna therefore requires two distinct capacities: structures prepared in advance to absorb unpredictable disturbance, and sufficient behavioral flexibility to alter conduct when the character of the disturbance changes. Preparation without adaptation protects only against anticipated classes of variation; adaptation without preparation begins only after the disturbance has already propagated.

Weaker still:

Fortuna governs variations an organization cannot determine; virtù governs the capacities retained for continuing through them. Success depends upon the fit between conduct and present conditions, while resilience depends upon preserving the ability to alter that fit when conditions change.

CHAPTER XXVI

AN EXHORTATION TO TAKE ITALY IN HAND AND FREE HER FROM THE BARBARIANS

Having considered everything discussed above, I have asked myself whether the present circumstances in Italy might bring honor to a new prince, and whether there is material here that could give a prudent man of *virtù* the opportunity to give it a form—one that would bring honor to him and benefit to all the people of Italy. It seems to me that so many things now favor a new prince that I cannot imagine a time better suited to the purpose.

As I have said, the people of Israel had to be enslaved in Egypt for the *virtù* of Moses to become visible; the Persians had to be oppressed by the Medes for the greatness of Cyrus's spirit to be recognized; and the Athenians had to be scattered for the excellence of Theseus to be revealed. In the same way, for the *virtù* of an Italian spirit to be recognized today, Italy had to be brought to her present condition: more enslaved than the Hebrews, more subjugated than the Persians, and more scattered than the Athenians; without a head and without order; beaten, stripped, torn, overrun, and made to endure every kind of ruin.

Until now, a glimmer may have appeared in someone—enough to suggest that he had been ordained by God for Italy's redemption. Yet it was later seen that, at the highest point of his career, fortune rejected him. Italy, left almost lifeless, therefore waits for someone who can heal her wounds, put an end to the sackings of Lombardy and the exactions imposed upon the Kingdom of Naples and Tuscany, and cure those sores that have long been festering.

One sees her praying to God to send someone who will redeem her from these barbarian cruelties and outrages. One also sees her ready and willing to follow a banner, if only someone will raise it.

At present, she can place greater hope in no one than in your illustrious house. Through its fortune and *virtù*, favored by God and by the Church—whose present head is a member of your house—it can place itself at the head of this redemption.

This will not be very difficult if you keep before your eyes the deeds and lives of the men named above. Although they were rare and extraordinary, they were still men, and each of them had a smaller opportunity than the present one. Their enterprises were neither more just nor easier than this, nor was God more their friend than yours.

Here the justice is great:

"For war is just to those for whom it is necessary, and arms are sacred where hope rests in arms alone."

Here the readiness is very great, and where readiness is great, the difficulty cannot be great—provided that you adopt the methods of those whom I have set before you as models.

Beyond this, extraordinary signs without precedent have been brought about here by God: the sea has opened; a cloud has shown you the way; the rock has poured out water; manna has rained down. Everything has converged upon your greatness. You must do the rest.

God does not wish to do everything, so as not to take free will from us, along with that part of the glory that belongs to us.

It is no wonder that none of the Italians mentioned before has been able to accomplish what we may hope your illustrious house will accomplish. Nor is it surprising that, through so many upheavals in Italy and so many operations of war, Italy's military *virtù* has always appeared extinguished.

This is because her old *ordini* were not good, and no one has known how to devise new ones. Nothing brings greater honor to a man newly risen than the new laws and new *ordini* he devises. When these are well founded and possess greatness, they make him revered and remarkable.

Italy does not lack the material upon which any form might be imposed. There is great *virtù* in the limbs, if only it were not absent from the heads.

Look at duels and small encounters, and see how superior Italians are in strength, agility, and ingenuity. But when it comes to armies, these qualities do not appear. Everything proceeds from the weakness of the leaders: those who know what to do are not obeyed, while everyone believes that he knows. Until now, no one has managed to rise so far above the others through both *virtù* and fortune that the rest will yield to him.

For this reason, throughout so long a period and through so many wars fought during the past twenty years, whenever an entirely Italian army has taken the field, it has always performed badly. Taro bears witness to this first, followed by Alessandria, Capua, Genoa, Vailà, Bologna, and Mestre.

Therefore, if your illustrious house wishes to follow those excellent men who redeemed their countries, it must, before everything else and as the true foundation of every undertaking, provide itself with arms of its own. No soldiers can be more faithful, more loyal, or better.

Although each of these soldiers may be good individually, together they will become better when they see themselves commanded by their own prince, honored by him, and maintained in his service.

You must therefore prepare such forces, so that through Italian *virtù* you can defend yourselves against foreign powers.

Although Swiss and Spanish infantry are considered formidable, each has a defect. A third kind of military organization could therefore not only withstand them but confidently expect to defeat them. The Spaniards cannot stand against cavalry. The Swiss must fear infantry whenever they meet foot soldiers as stubborn in combat as themselves.

Experience has shown, and will continue to show, that the Spaniards cannot withstand French cavalry and that the Swiss can be destroyed by Spanish infantry.

Although this second point has not yet been demonstrated completely, an example of it was seen at the Battle of Ravenna. There the Spanish infantry encountered German battalions organized in the same way as the Swiss. Through bodily agility and the protection of their bucklers, the Spaniards worked their way beneath the German pikes. They could attack in safety, while the Germans had no remedy against them. Had cavalry not struck the Spaniards, they would have destroyed all the Germans.

Having recognized the defects in both kinds of infantry, it is therefore possible to organize a new one that can resist cavalry without fearing other infantry. This can be accomplished through the kind of weapons used and through variations in formations.

Innovations of this kind bring reputation and greatness to a new prince.

This opportunity must therefore not be allowed to pass, so that after so long a time Italy may see a redeemer of her own.

I cannot express with what love he would be received in all those provinces that have suffered beneath these foreign floods—with what thirst for revenge, what unwavering loyalty, what devotion, and what tears.

What gates would be closed to him?

What peoples would deny him obedience?

What envy would oppose him?

What Italian would deny him homage?

Everyone finds this barbarian domination repulsive.

Let your illustrious house therefore take up this undertaking with the spirit and hope with which just enterprises are undertaken, so that under its banner this homeland may be ennobled, and under its auspices these words of Petrarch may be fulfilled:

Virtù will take up arms against fury,
and the fighting will be brief;
for the ancient valor
in Italian hearts is not yet dead.

An AC Weakening

When the named dynasty, biblical exemplars, military particulars, and nationalist rhetoric are removed while the organizational dependencies are preserved:

Severe organizational failure can create an opportunity for a new continuation. Distributed injury weakens attachment to the existing order, makes previously unacceptable transformation admissible, and leaves participants increasingly prepared to recognize a common alternative. Crisis supplies material and readiness, but it does not supply the form through which they can continue together.

Opportunity becomes effective only when an agent possessing sufficient virtù recognizes the available relations and organizes them into laws, institutions, command, and internally retained force. External conditions may make transformation possible, but they cannot complete it without human selection and action. Invoking providence can represent the opportunity as legitimate; retaining a role for free action makes the proposed leader answerable for whether it is realized.

Individually distributed capacities do not automatically compose a collective capacity. Participants may possess courage, skill, and intelligence locally while failing whenever their contributions require common command. Defective institutions, contested authority, and unavailable coordination prevent the capacities of the members from becoming capacities of the containing organization. New ordini must make those contributions mutually available through recognized leadership, common discipline, and a force formed within the continuation it is intended to defend.

Organizational innovation can proceed through comparative analysis. Existing forms are examined for the conditions under which each succeeds and the relations through which each fails. A new form can then be constructed that preserves their useful capacities while altering the dependencies that expose them to defeat. The innovation contributes to the founder's reputation because it makes previously dispersed capacities effective as one organized continuation.

The proposed transformation also requires a common subject. Shared suffering, an identified external oppressor, religious authorization, inherited cultural memory, and the promise of liberation are articulated so that separate populations may recognize themselves as participants in one injured and recoverable organization. These representations can mobilize contribution, although their universal claims of unity and readiness remain exhortative rather than demonstrated.

The addressee's private objective is joined to the containing organization's proposed continuation. Personal honor, dynastic greatness, and political authority are made obtainable through an undertaking represented as benefiting the wider population. The exhortation thereby attempts to make the leader's local continuation dependent upon preserving—and becoming a contributor to—the common continuation.

Weaker still:

Dispersed capacities become a common organizational continuation only when shared conditions, a recognized objective, coordinating authority, and retained institutions make their contributions mutually available. Crisis supplies the occasione; organizational form converts it into collective capacity.

APPENDIX A – CHAPTER-BY-CHAPTER TEXTUAL, ARGUMENTATIVE, AND ORGANIZATIONAL NOTES

DEDICATION AND CHAPTERS I–XXVI

Accuracy, terminology, argumentative structure, and organizational interpretation

Scope and method

This appendix consolidates the notes accompanying the Lucid conversion of Machiavelli's *The Prince* from the Dedication through Chapter XXVI. Repetition has been removed and terminology has been normalized, but distinctions that governed the individual chapter notes have been retained.

Each entry separates three layers: the wording and translation of Machiavelli's Italian; the argument Machiavelli explicitly makes; and an organizational interpretation developed for Why Machiavelli Works using Admissibility Calculus and Cohaerentia (AC&C). The third layer is a later reconstruction, not a claim that Machiavelli possessed or intended Admissibility Calculus or Cohaerentia.

Machiavelli ordinarily indexes success to the continuation of the prince or prince-state. A measure that is organizationally effective for that selected continuation is not thereby ethically admissible to the population, a republic, participating agents, rival organizations, or the containing social order. This scale distinction remains essential throughout the work.

Recurring translation terms

Stato. Depending on context, this may mean a political holding, governed territory, ruling position, or organized regime. It should not automatically be read as the modern nation-state.

Principato. A political order under a prince and, often, the territory or ruling position belonging to that order. 'Principality' preserves this double institutional and territorial sense better than 'monarchy' in many passages.

Virtù. Effective political capacity: judgment, courage, initiative, force, adaptability, and the ability to form or preserve an order. It does not mean moral virtue, although Machiavelli can still distinguish capacity from glory or goodness.

Fortuna. Contingency outside the actor's present control: circumstance, timing, opportunity, inheritance, accident, and adverse variation. 'Luck' is usually too narrow.

Ordini. Orders, arrangements, institutions, and established ways by which a political organization continues. The correct English rendering changes with context, but the institutional force should be retained.

Armi. Not merely weapons. In the military chapters it means organized coercive and defensive capacity: personnel, command, discipline, allegiance, and the institutions that make force available.

Necessità. A requirement imposed by the conditions of the selected political continuation. Machiavelli's statement that an act is necessary does not, by itself, claim that the act is morally justified.

Essere tenuto. To be held, regarded, or reputed as possessing a quality. Chapters XV–XVIII repeatedly distinguish conduct, public attribution, and political consequence.

Liberalità and *parsimonia.* The first is generosity or largeness in spending and giving, not modern political liberalism. The second is measured economy or frugality, not necessarily avarice. Chapter XVI turns on the difference between the visible quality and the financial system required to sustain it.

Pietà. Mercy or merciful restraint in Chapter XVII, not simply an emotion of pity and not religious piety. Machiavelli tests the quality by the injuries its use or misuse permits across the political organization.

Timore and *odio.* Fear and hatred are distinct political relations. Machiavelli treats fear as compatible with continued obedience but hatred as a boundary that makes coercive rule dangerous.

Licenzia. Excessive freedom from discipline: permission or latitude that has become organizational disorder. In the Scipio example it is the direct consequence of mercy insufficiently constrained by military discipline.

Dedication - Niccolò Machiavelli to the Magnificent Lorenzo de' Medici

Text and translation notes

The critical reading is *varietà della materia* ('the variety of the material'), not *verità della materia* ('the truth of the matter'), which appears in some later editions. The Lucid conversion follows *varietà*. This matters because Machiavelli is praising the range and weight of his subject, not asserting that his account needs no demonstration because it is simply true.

Uomini grandi means men of great consequence or historical action, not morally good men. *Populare* means a private or ordinary citizen - one of the people - rather than

someone who is popular. *Fortuna* remains untranslated because the closing complaint concerns a sustained adverse condition, not a single stroke of bad luck.

The dedication's plain style is itself part of its claim. Machiavelli contrasts compressed knowledge with ornamental language and presents the work as the product of both modern experience and continuous reading of antiquity.

Argumentative structure

Machiavelli offers Lorenzo the knowledge of political action that he has acquired over many years and now compressed into a small volume. He argues that the gift is valuable because it allows the recipient to understand quickly what cost the author extensive experience, danger, and study.

He then answers the anticipated objection that a man of low position should not instruct princes. A landscape painter must stand below to understand mountains and above to understand plains; likewise, a prince is positioned to know peoples, while one of the people is positioned to know princes. Political knowledge is therefore observer-relative without being merely subjective.

Organizational interpretation

The dedication establishes a method before it offers advice. Organizational knowledge can arise from a position outside the governing apex because different positions expose different relations. Rank does not monopolize evaluability.

The book is also presented as a transfer of retained experience: extended encounters with modern events and ancient cases are compressed into a representation meant to preserve their actionable distinctions. That makes the dedication an implicit account of why a Lucid conversion is possible, while also warning that simplification must not erase the variety from which the knowledge was formed.

The critical reading in Inglese is varietà della materia ("the variety of the material"), not verità della materia ("the truth of the matter"), which appears in some later editions (p. 40). The Lucid conversion follows varietà. This matters because Machiavelli is praising the range and weight of his material, not claiming "truth" as an ornamental quality of the work.

CHAPTER I - KINDS OF PRINCIPALITIES AND THEIR MODES OF ACQUISITION

Text and translation notes

Stati and *dominii* should not be collapsed. *Stati* names political states or organized holdings; *dominii* emphasizes territories or populations under rule. *Imperio* here means rule or command, not necessarily an empire.

The closing pair, *fortuna* and *virtù*, supplies distinct causal sources of acquisition. *Virtù* is effective political capacity - skill, judgment, resolution, and force - rather than moral virtue. *Fortuna* is the contingent structure through which a state becomes available.

Argumentative structure

The chapter is a compact taxonomy. Political orders are first divided into republics and principalities. Principalities are hereditary or new; new principalities are wholly new or annexed to a hereditary state. Acquired territories may previously have lived under a prince or in freedom. Acquisition may occur through one's own forces or those of others, and through *fortuna* or *virtù*.

These are not decorative categories. They identify different initial conditions that will govern the difficulties of acquisition and retention in the following chapters.

Organizational interpretation

Chapter I specifies the variables of Machiavelli's political experiment. A regime's present label does not by itself determine what will preserve it; its prior organization, acquisition path, military basis, and relation between contingency and internal capacity remain active conditions.

The organizing insight is therefore historical and relational: the same apparent endpoint - possession of a principality - can embody different dependencies and require different continuations. Classification precedes advice because political action is admissible only relative to the kind of organization being continued.

CHAPTER II - HEREDITARY PRINCIPALITIES

Text and translation notes

Ordine de' suoi antenati means the inherited governing arrangement or accustomed pattern of the ruler's predecessors, not merely a list of ancestral commands. *Industria* combines practical ability, diligence, initiative, and competent attention. *Temporeggiare con gli accidenti* means to accommodate or adapt to contingencies as they arise.

The final image, *addentellato*, is architectural. It is the toothed or projecting masonry left so that another wall can be attached. A political alteration likewise leaves an attachment point from which a further alteration can be built.

Argumentative structure

A hereditary state accustomed to the same ruling family is easier to retain than a new state. A prince of ordinary practical capacity normally needs only to preserve the ancestral order and adapt to events. Even after being displaced, he can often return when the usurper encounters trouble.

The hereditary prince has fewer causes and fewer necessities to injure his subjects. Unless extraordinary vices make him hated, continuity therefore makes him more readily accepted. Time extinguishes memories and causes of innovation, whereas every fresh alteration leaves the structural beginning of another.

Organizational interpretation

Hereditary stability is not explained by the superior character of hereditary rulers. It is produced by retained organization. Roles, expectations, and allegiance have already been coordinated, so ordinary competence can preserve what novelty would force a ruler to construct.

Continuity also weakens the availability of alternatives: memories of other arrangements and the coalitions associated with them fade. Change has the opposite effect. It reveals that change is possible and leaves unresolved interfaces through which another reorganization can attach. Machiavelli's masonry image is an early statement of path-dependent instability.

CHAPTER III - MIXED PRINCIPALITIES

Text and translation notes

A *principato misto* is not a constitution mixing monarchy, aristocracy, and democracy. It is a newly acquired territory joined as a member to an older state. *Provinciali* refers to the inhabitants of the acquired province. The 'strong medicines' available to a conqueror are coercive remedies, not conciliatory policy.

Colonie means strategically placed settlements tied to the conqueror; it should not automatically evoke the later global colonial system. *Spegnere il sangue del principe* is blunt: extinguish the former ruling line. Likewise, Machiavelli's assertion that men must be treated generously or destroyed should not be softened into ordinary administrative advice.

Argumentative structure

New subjects often assist an invader because they expect improvement, then discover that conquest brings troops, burdens, and injuries. The conqueror thus acquires enemies among those harmed while remaining unable to satisfy all who helped him. Entry depends upon local support, but acquisition itself destabilizes that support.

Territories sharing language and customs can usually be retained by eliminating the former dynasty while preserving laws and taxes. Territories with different language, customs, and institutions require closer control: the prince should reside there or establish colonies. Residence allows early detection; colonies impose control at lower cost and injure fewer people than a permanent occupying army.

Machiavelli's Roman examples yield a broader strategy: protect weaker neighbors without increasing their power, weaken the strong, exclude rival foreign powers, and address disorders before they become obvious. Louis XII failed in Italy because his actions repeatedly violated this structure. The chapter closes with the rule that whoever causes another power to become great is ruined by it.

Organizational interpretation

Annexation creates a coordination problem before it creates a stable possession. Supporters act from projected benefit; the new ruler acts from the necessities of control. Their continuations diverge as soon as the acquisition is made, producing an unstable coalition.

Residence, colonies, and occupation forces are different coupling structures. Residence shortens detection and response distance. Colonies distribute small but durable control points. A standing occupying force burdens the entire acquired population and continually regenerates opposition.

The disease analogy makes time a structural variable: an emerging disorder is difficult to detect but comparatively easy to correct; once fully visible, it is easy to diagnose but difficult to remove. Early action preserves more alternatives at lower cost. Empowering another actor, by contrast, changes the field itself by creating a new source of capacity that may later constrain its creator.

CHAPTER IV - WHY ALEXANDER'S SUCCESSORS RETAINED THE KINGDOM OF DARIUS

Text and translation notes

Machiavelli contrasts two ideal types: a prince ruling through servants or ministers who hold authority by his grant, and a prince ruling amid hereditary barons who possess their own territories, subjects, and inherited legitimacy. 'The Turk' names the Ottoman sultan and his centralized monarchy in Machiavelli's contemporary vocabulary, not the Turkish population.

The examples are analytic compressions rather than complete histories of Persia, the Ottoman Empire, or France. Their purpose is to isolate the distribution of political authority and show how that distribution changes conquest and retention.

Argumentative structure

A centralized monarchy is difficult to conquer because subordinate officials lack independent followings and cannot easily invite an outsider in. Once the ruler's army is defeated and the ruling family eliminated, however, the conqueror encounters few remaining centers capable of organizing resistance.

A baronial monarchy is easier to penetrate because discontented nobles can provide entry and local support. It is harder to retain because hereditary lords and their constituencies survive the conquest as alternative sources of authority. Alexander's successors retained Darius's kingdom, Machiavelli argues, because its centralized organization left no autonomous baronial order to reactivate after the royal line was removed.

Organizational interpretation

The distribution of authority determines a regime's invasion and failure topology. Centralization reduces the number of independent entry points but concentrates systemic dependence in the apex. Polycentric authority increases openings for external intervention while preserving multiple nodes from which resistance can continue.

The same organizational feature can therefore reverse its effect across phases. Centralization protects acquisition by an outsider until the center is defeated; after defeat, it facilitates consolidation. Distributed authority makes initial conquest easier but complete replacement harder. Political strength cannot be assessed without specifying both the disturbance and the phase of continuation.

CHAPTER V - GOVERNING STATES ACCUSTOMED TO THEIR OWN LAWS AND LIBERTY

Text and translation notes

Libertà here means collective political self-government under a city's own laws and institutions, not simply the private liberty of individuals. *Ordini antichi* denotes the city's old constitutional and institutional arrangements. *Rovinare* and *disfare* mean ruin, dismantle, or destroy; Machiavelli's severity should remain visible.

The dependent government of 'a few' is an oligarchic local order created by the conqueror. Its dependence is the reason Machiavelli expects it to remain loyal: it cannot preserve itself without the external prince who created it.

Argumentative structure

A conquered city formerly living under its own laws can be held in three ways: destroy it; reside there personally; or leave its laws in place while exacting tribute and creating a dependent local government. Sparta's dependent oligarchies failed, while Rome retained certain cities by destroying them.

The name and memory of liberty remain available as a rallying point for rebellion. Time and benefits do not necessarily erase that memory. A population accustomed to princely rule, once its dynasty is extinguished, has greater difficulty organizing an alternative; a formerly free city retains both the concept and the institutions of self-rule.

Organizational interpretation

Institutional memory is an organizational resource. Even while suppressed, a former republic retains a distinction between its present subjection and its earlier self-government. A later disturbance can reactivate that distinction and the practices organized around it.

Machiavelli's three methods correspond to eliminating the prior continuation, coupling the conqueror directly to it, or preserving it through a dependent intermediary. His conclusion is indexed entirely to the conqueror's possession. What is effective for princely continuation is plainly destructive of the conquered city's continuation; the chapter therefore demonstrates why organizational admissibility must always identify its subject and ethical scale.

CHAPTER VI - NEW PRINCIPALITIES ACQUIRED BY ONE'S OWN ARMS AND VIRTÙ

Text and translation notes

The archer's *virtù* is the effective reach or power of the bow, reinforcing that *virtù* means operative capacity rather than moral goodness. *Occasione* is the enabling situation that makes action possible; it is more structured than a casual 'opportunity.' *Materia* and *forma* retain their formative sense: circumstances supply material that the founder's capacity gives political form.

Ordini nuovi are new institutions and arrangements. The 'armed prophets' are founders who possess means of enforcing the order they announce; Machiavelli is not reducing prophecy to private religious belief.

Argumentative structure

Because people imitate paths already taken yet cannot reproduce another person's capacities exactly, the prudent founder aims above an attainable target, like an archer compensating for distance. Moses, Cyrus, Romulus, and Theseus serve as models of founders whose *virtù* met an enabling *occasione*.

Nothing is harder or more dangerous than introducing new institutions. Those who benefited from the old order become active enemies, while those who might benefit from the new one remain lukewarm until experience makes its advantages credible. Persuasion alone therefore fails when belief changes; armed founders can preserve the new order through its unstable beginning, whereas unarmed founders such as Savonarola collapse.

Principalities acquired through one's own capacity are difficult to establish but comparatively easy to maintain after the new institutions have taken root and acquired authority.

Organizational interpretation

Founding converts contingent availability into retained organization. *Occasione* supplies a break in the existing field, but *virtù* must articulate, enforce, and stabilize a new set of relations. Neither opportunity nor capacity is sufficient alone.

The opposition is asymmetric. Defenders of the old order possess actual benefits and an existing coordination structure; prospective beneficiaries possess only an uncertain future. Coercive capacity bridges the interval before the new order can reproduce itself through expectation and practice. 'One's own arms' therefore means control over the implementation layer by which institutional transformation becomes durable.

Critical-text verification (§§4–6). Inglese reads si truova a mantenergli più o meno difficultà, secondo che più o meno è virtuoso colui che gli acquista and per non avere altri stati, venire personalmente ad abitarvi (p. 72). These readings support the MetaLibri witness and the Lucid conversion. Wikisource instead reads per avere altri Stati, omitting non and thereby reversing the causal relation. The prince is compelled to reside personally in the new principality because he has no other state, not because he has others. The Wikisource reading is therefore not followed.

CHAPTER VII - NEW PRINCIPALITIES ACQUIRED BY OTHERS' ARMS AND FORTUNA

Text and translation notes

Radici e corrispondenzie means roots and supporting connections: the alliances, dependencies, loyalties, and institutions through which a new state can withstand its first adversity. *Crudeltà* remains 'cruelty'; the violence of Cesare Borgia's methods should not be disguised as generic decisiveness.

Machiavelli presents Borgia as a model of prudent preparation, not as a man who simply succeeded. Borgia ultimately lost. Machiavelli attributes the collapse principally to extraordinary adverse *fortuna* - the death of Alexander VI while Borgia himself was gravely ill - but also identifies Borgia's support for Julius II's election as a final error.

Argumentative structure

Those raised suddenly by another's favor or military power arrive with little effort but face their real difficulties afterward. They depend on the unstable will and *fortuna* of the patron who made them great and initially lack loyal forces, roots, and governing knowledge.

Cesare Borgia attempts to convert a borrowed position into an independent principality. He weakens rival families, wins over their adherents, destroys unreliable commanders, pacifies the Romagna, begins forming forces of his own, cultivates the people, and prepares to influence the next papal succession.

In the Romagna he delegates severe pacification to Remirro de Orco, then has Remirro publicly cut in two once order is restored. The act removes a now-dangerous agent,

places responsibility for cruelty upon that agent, and presents the duke as the source of justice. It is both coercive reorganization and deliberate management of attribution.

Organizational interpretation

Rapid elevation installs a ruling position before it installs the dependencies that can preserve that position. Borgia's campaign is a systematic attempt to internalize what had been externally supplied: military force, elite allegiance, public acceptance, territorial order, and succession control.

The Remirro episode shows that political continuation depends not only on actions but on how responsibility for actions is organized and perceived. Borgia localizes coercive blame in an agent, then destroys the agent and recenters favorable judgment on himself. That strategy may be effective for the prince while remaining radically inadmissible to the affected population.

Borgia's final vulnerability is structural. Too many critical continuations remain correlated with a single external node, his father's papacy. *Fortuna* does not merely strike at random; it reveals the insufficiency of an order that has not yet made itself resilient to the loss of its enabling condition.

CHAPTER VIII - THOSE WHO BECOME PRINCES THROUGH CRIMES

Text and translation notes

Scelleratezza and *via scellerata e nefaria* mean crime, wickedness, and an atrocious course of action. The category cannot be absorbed into either *virtù* or *fortuna*. Machiavelli can acknowledge Agathocles' bodily and mental capacity while denying that murdering citizens, betraying friends, and living without faith, pity, or religion deserve the name of *virtù* in a glory-conferring sense.

Crudeltà bene usate must remain 'cruelties well used.' 'Well' is instrumental and temporal, not moral: cruelty is so classified when concentrated at the beginning for security, not repeated, and subsequently converted into measures useful to subjects. The phrase is intentionally shocking, and paraphrasing it as 'firm measures' would erase the argument.

Argumentative structure

Agathocles and Oliverotto seize rule through planned massacres of the people whose authority or hospitality made their rise possible. Their examples show that possession, survival, glory, and moral worth are distinct results. Agathocles can acquire and defend an empire without being honored among excellent men.

Machiavelli distinguishes cruelties used once from cruelties that begin modestly and multiply. Injuries should be inflicted together so that they are experienced over a shorter interval; benefits should be distributed gradually so that they remain perceptible. A ruler

who must renew injuries whenever circumstances change cannot establish trust or stability.

Organizational interpretation

The chapter treats the temporal distribution of coercion as part of organizational structure. A bounded violent transition can terminate and allow expectations to stabilize. Recurrent coercion keeps the threat relation continuously available, prevents trust from forming, and enlarges the coalition with reason to resist.

It also separates continuation from evaluation. Crime may preserve the ruler's possession while destroying glory and the admissible continuations of others. Machiavelli's analysis is diagnostic rather than exculpatory: identifying why a method works for one selected objective does not convert that objective into a moral standard.

CHAPTER IX - THE CIVIL PRINCIPALITY

Text and translation notes

Umori does not mean temporary moods. It names durable and opposed social dispositions or drives. The people wish not to be commanded and oppressed by the *grandi*; the *grandi* wish to command and oppress the people. *Grandi* means the powerful or elite, not morally great persons. *Licenza* is disorder or license, not liberty.

Astuzia fortunata is fortunate shrewdness or strategically successful cunning. A civil prince requires neither complete *virtù* nor complete *fortuna*, because his elevation is mediated by one of the city's existing social forces.

Argumentative structure

A civil principality arises through the favor of either the people or the great. A prince made by the great is surrounded by men who regard themselves as his equals and whose positive objective is to dominate others. A prince made by the people stands more nearly alone, while the people's fundamental demand - not to be oppressed - is easier to satisfy without injuring others.

The people are too numerous to eliminate or secure against if hostile; hostile nobles are fewer and can be managed, replaced, or suppressed. Nobles who bind their fortunes to the prince can be honored; those who remain independent through ambition must be watched as prospective enemies.

The prince must maintain popular goodwill and prepare for the dangerous transition from ordinary government through magistrates to direct dependence in a crisis. Citizens must come to need both the state and the prince under ordinary and exceptional conditions.

Organizational interpretation

Political authority is coalition-mediated. The popular objective is negative and comparatively minimal: freedom from elite oppression. The elite objective is positive and relational: the capacity to impose upon others. The latter therefore produces more direct conflict with the rest of the organization.

Machiavelli also identifies a continuity hazard in intermediary institutions. A ruler whose authority is available only through magistrates may discover in crisis that the intermediaries control the actual paths of action. Resilient princely rule requires dependencies that remain available when the operating regime changes. This explains the recommendation organizationally; it does not endorse making a population personally dependent on an autocrat.

CHAPTER X - HOW THE STRENGTH OF PRINCIPALITIES SHOULD BE MEASURED

Text and translation notes

Per sé medesimo reggersi means being able to sustain or defend oneself under attack, not complete economic autarky. *Esercito giusto* is an adequate or properly sufficient army, not a morally just army. *Terra* in the fortification discussion is the prince's town or fortified city, not simply the surrounding countryside.

The German cities' *ordini* include fortifications, artillery, public stores, employment provisions, and maintained military practices. Machiavelli is describing an integrated defensive organization rather than walls alone.

Argumentative structure

A principality's strength should be measured by whether it can meet an attacker in the field through its own manpower and money or must retreat behind fortified walls and depend upon outside defense. A ruler in the second condition should fortify his town and manage his subjects so that he is not hated.

The German cities can withstand prolonged siege because they combine physical defenses with a year's supplies, public capacity to employ and feed the population, and respected military exercises. An attacker normally cannot sustain a siege long enough to overcome this system. The destruction of surrounding property may initially enrage subjects, but shared danger and the prince's protective role can bind them more closely to him if confidence is preserved.

Organizational interpretation

Strength is not an inventory; it is the capacity to preserve a specified continuation through a specified disturbance. Fortifications, supplies, employment, training, popular attachment, and deterrent reputation form a coupled resilience structure.

Material and social defenses cannot be separated. Walls do not secure a hated ruler, and goodwill does not replace provisions. A functioning defense preserves the population's continuation while making the prince's continuation part of the same dependency. External attack may then consolidate rather than dissolve allegiance because the population experiences ruler and city as a shared defensive organization.

CHAPTER XI - ECCLESIASTICAL PRINCIPALITIES

Text and translation notes

Ordini antiquati nella religione means ancient, deeply established institutions grounded in religion. *Temporale* refers to the Church's temporal or political power. Machiavelli's initial appeal to causes beyond human understanding may be reverent, strategically cautious, ironic, or some combination; the translation should preserve the rhetorical movement without deciding his private belief.

The chapter immediately follows its deferential opening with a secular account of how papal power increased through Italian balance-of-power politics, factional conflict, money, arms, Alexander VI's use of Cesare Borgia, and Julius II's consolidation.

Argumentative structure

Ecclesiastical principalities are difficult to acquire but uniquely easy to retain. They may be obtained through *virtù* or *fortuna*, yet they persist without either because long-established religious institutions support the ruler regardless of his personal conduct. Machiavelli provocatively says that these rulers possess states without defending them and subjects without governing them, yet are neither dispossessed nor abandoned.

He then explains the recent growth of the papacy's temporal power. Earlier, Roman baronial factions and the Italian balance kept the pope weak. Alexander VI demonstrated what papal money and force could achieve; Julius II inherited the result, expanded it, weakened the Venetians and barons, and increased Church power for Leo X to inherit.

Organizational interpretation

The chapter isolates transpersonal organizational capacity. An office supported by deeply retained institutions can remain stable despite variations in the competence or conduct of its occupant. Authority is reproduced by the organization rather than recreated by each prince.

Religious legitimacy is not the only mechanism in Machiavelli's account. Institutional inheritance combines with faction management, finance, military force, and succession. The result is an organization whose continuation exceeds the *virtù* of any one officeholder while accumulating the consequences of earlier officeholders' actions.

CHAPTER XII - MILITARY FORCES AND MERCENARY SOLDIERS

Text and translation notes

Milizia means the military establishment or mode of organizing forces. *Armi proprie* means forces internally connected to the prince or republic through subjects, citizens, command, and allegiance; it does not mean merely weapons legally owned by the state. The distinction among one's own, mercenary, auxiliary, and mixed forces must remain exact.

The critical reading *col gesso* means 'with chalk,' not the variant *col gesto*. The image is commonly understood as the chalk used to mark quarters for troops: Charles VIII could traverse or take Italy with scarcely more resistance than billeting required. It condenses Machiavelli's claim that Italian military weakness made conquest administrative rather than genuinely contested.

Machiavelli's 'good laws' and 'good arms' are mutually implicated foundations, but he chooses to discuss arms because laws cannot remain effective where the organization lacks a reliable capacity to defend and enforce them.

Argumentative structure

Mercenary forces are divided, ambitious, undisciplined, unfaithful, brave among friends, and cowardly before enemies. Pay is enough to keep them during peace but not enough to make them die for their employer in war. If their commander lacks *virtù*, he ruins the employer through incompetence; if he possesses it, his independent ambition makes him dangerous.

A prince should command his own troops personally. A republic should send its own citizens and constrain successful commanders through law. Rome, Sparta, and the Swiss illustrate armed polities; Carthage, Thebes, Milan, Florence, and Venice illustrate varying forms of mercenary dependence.

Italian mercenary commanders gradually optimized warfare for their own safety and status: they marginalized infantry, avoided killing, night assaults, fortification of camps, and winter campaigning. Their system could display competence within its own conventions yet left Italy unable to withstand a foreign army organized for actual conquest.

Organizational interpretation

Mercenary dependence is a principal-agent failure at the coercive foundation of the state. The prince needs a force willing and able to preserve the prince-state; the mercenary organization seeks pay, safety, and its commander's independent advancement. The implementation layer therefore has an objective that diverges from the organization it is supposed to preserve.

The danger has two forms. Incompetent mercenaries fail under external pressure; competent mercenaries can become an internal rival. Outsourcing a core continuation-capacity thus makes the state dependent upon an organization that either cannot or will not reliably share its defining objective. Machiavelli's linkage between laws and arms follows from this: formal order cannot remain available when decisive enforcement is controlled elsewhere.

CHAPTER XIII - AUXILIARY, MIXED, AND ONE'S OWN FORCES

Text and translation notes

Auxiliary forces are not generic allies. They are another sovereign's already unified military organization, brought in under that sovereign's ultimate command. *Armi* therefore means organized military capacity. *Rovina fatta* is ruin already made or already assembled: the dangerous unity exists before the force enters the prince's service.

Ignavia is cowardly ineffectiveness or lack of spirit. The contrast is exact: the greatest danger in mercenaries is their *ignavia*; the greatest danger in auxiliaries is their *virtù*, because their effectiveness remains controlled by someone else. *Infedeli*, translated as 'infidels,' preserves Machiavelli's period-specific Christian vocabulary rather than adopting it as the translator's description.

Creati tuoi means men raised, formed, or made dependent under one's own authority. *Intero possessore delle sue armi* means complete or undivided master of one's own military power. The Latin maxim concerns the *reputation* or appearance of power not founded on one's own force, not merely the amount of force displayed.

Argumentative structure

Auxiliaries create a double trap: if they lose, the prince is ruined; if they win, he becomes their prisoner. They are more dangerous than mercenaries because they arrive as one disciplined body obedient to another ruler. Mercenaries require time and opportunity to unite against their employer; auxiliaries already possess that unity.

Cesare Borgia's reputation rises as he moves from French auxiliaries to Orsini and Vitelli mercenaries and finally to his own forces. Hiero destroys commanders he can neither keep nor dismiss. David refuses Saul's armor because another man's arms fall off, weigh down, or constrain their user.

Charles VII gives France its own organized men-at-arms and infantry; Louis XI abolishes the infantry formation and hires Swiss troops. Native French forces become psychologically and operationally dependent upon the Swiss. Mixed forces are better than purely external forces, but inferior to forces wholly one's own. Rome's hiring of the Goths similarly transfers *virtù* from the Roman organization to the external force on which it depends.

Organizational interpretation

Chapter XII argues that an external force may fail to preserve you. Chapter XIII identifies the more severe possibility: an external force may preserve the immediate objective so effectively that it acquires control of the continuation. Failure produces defeat; success produces subordination.

Borrowed capacity can solve an immediate problem while transferring long-term agency to its provider. It can also cause internal capacity to atrophy, as French troops cease to regard themselves as able to act without the Swiss. A mixed system moderates the exposure but does not remove the foreign dependency.

Machiavelli's 'own forces' are therefore not an argument for ownership in a narrow legal sense. They are an argument for organizational integration: the decisive capacity, its command, its allegiance, and its development must remain within the organization whose continuation it serves.

CHAPTER XIV - WHAT BELONGS TO A PRINCE CONCERNING THE MILITARY

Text and translation notes

Milizia names the military domain as an organized practice: forces, command, discipline, preparation, and the knowledge required to employ them. *Arte* is a craft or governing occupation, not merely a theoretical 'art.' The opening claim is therefore stronger than advice to take an interest in weapons: military organization is the prince's defining professional responsibility.

Critical-text verification (§§1–3). Inglese's critical text reads negligere questa arte (p. 131), confirming the MetaLibri witness and the Lucid conversion's "neglecting this profession." Italian Wikisource instead reads disprezzare questa arte, "to despise this profession." Although both readings preserve the causal contrast, negligere, "to neglect," more precisely anticipates the chapter's demand for continual study and exercise. The Wikisource reading is therefore not followed. The chapter's armed/unarmed distinction likewise concerns available governing capacity, not the physical possession of a weapon.

Ordini in the military context denotes organized arrangements and disciplined formations. *Virtù* remains effective capacity. *Industria* combines diligent attention, practical ability, and sustained application. Machiavelli's statement that there is 'no proportion' between an armed and an unarmed ruler describes a structural disparity in capacity and dependence.

Military study has two modes: action and mind. Hunting trains the body and teaches the form of terrain. The terms *giornate* and *campeggiare* refer respectively to battles and to encamping or conducting operations in the field; terrain knowledge governs pursuit, retreat, encampment, movement, and advantage.

Philopoemen supplies the model of continuous counterfactual rehearsal: while traveling, he asks how forces could be deployed, withdrawn, pursued, or rescued on the terrain before him. Xenophon's *Cyropaedia* supplies the principal historical model. To *farne capitale* is to make those examples a principal resource or stock of usable knowledge, not merely to admire them.

Argumentative structure

A prince must treat war, its organization, and its discipline as his principal study. Machiavelli makes this discipline causally sufficient for men of private condition to rise and its neglect causally sufficient for princes to lose their states.

Military incapacity changes the ruler's relation to armed subordinates. An unarmed prince cannot command their respect and cannot prudently rely upon them. The deficiency is therefore simultaneously operational, hierarchical, and relational.

Peace does not suspend the military requirement. It changes the form of preparation. Bodily exercise, hunting, and terrain study preserve physical readiness and generate transferable knowledge of movement, supply, positioning, and local advantage.

Counterfactual questioning turns ordinary travel into repeated simulation. Historical reading adds retained cases of action, victory, defeat, conduct, and causality. The prince studies exemplary figures as a craftsperson studies models, selecting features that can inform present judgment without assuming that circumstances repeat exactly.

The chapter closes the argument by redefining peace as an interval in which capacity must be accumulated for adversity. Fortune is least able to surprise a ruler whose practical and intellectual preparations remain continuously available.

Organizational interpretation

Chapter XIV treats capacity as something an organization must keep accessible before disturbance occurs. A title or formal right to command cannot substitute for the trained relations through which defense is actually performed. If decisive capacity lies elsewhere, nominal authority becomes dependent upon its operators.

The chapter couples physical practice with representational practice. Terrain is read as an operational model; Philopoemen's questions rehearse branching possibilities; historical examples preserve prior solutions and failures. Resilience arises from repeated movement between embodied action, environmental structure, and counterfactual judgment.

This is a theory of prepared optionality. Training does not predict the exact future event; it enlarges the range of events through which the prince-state can continue without improvising its basic capacities from nothing.

The selected continuation remains important. A militarily capable prince may preserve his rule while imposing militarization, coercion, or war upon other continuations. Chapter

XIV explains why military capacity works for princely survival; it does not make that survival the complete ethical measure of the organization.

CHAPTER XV - THINGS FOR WHICH MEN, AND ESPECIALLY PRINCES, ARE PRAISED OR BLAMED

Text and translation notes

Modi e governi joins ways of acting with modes of governing. Machiavelli is moving from the acquisition and military support of principalities to the conduct by which rulers deal with subjects and friends. *Essere tenuto* means to be regarded or reputed as possessing a quality; the catalogue is a map of public classifications as well as of conduct.

The paired qualities vary slightly across witnesses and punctuation traditions, including whether some items are joined by 'and' or opposed by 'or.' The argument does not depend upon treating the catalogue as a perfectly symmetrical moral taxonomy. It depends upon the fact that rulers are publicly named through conventional terms of praise and blame.

Verità effettuale della cosa is the effective truth of the matter: the reality disclosed by what actions and arrangements actually do. It is contrasted with the *immaginazione* of a thing - ideal constructions of republics and principalities that have never been known to exist in fact. 'Effective' retains both actuality and consequence.

The claim that someone who makes a *professione di buono* in everything must come to ruin among so many who are not good concerns a fixed commitment to acting only in conventionally good ways. Machiavelli's answer is modal: a prince must learn *a potere essere non buono* - to be able not to be good - and to use or not use that capacity according to necessity. He does not say that the prince must always act badly.

Necessità identifies a conditional requirement, not an unrestricted license. *Misero* here means miserly or withholding, not miserable; *effeminato* is a period pejorative in Machiavelli's catalogue and should be recognized as such rather than silently normalized. Ordinary praised 'virtue' must also be distinguished from Machiavelli's more technical *virtù*, or effective political capacity.

The closing *sicurtà e bene essere* joins security with a condition of doing or being well. Inglese reads *e seguendola ne nasce la sicurtà et il bene essere suo* (p. 138), supporting the Lucid conversion's explicitly causal "produces his security and well-being." The reversal is deliberately uncomfortable: a quality that appears virtuous may produce ruin, while a quality that appears vicious may produce security and continued functioning.

Argumentative structure

Machiavelli first identifies the conventional vocabulary through which princes are evaluated: generous or miserly, merciful or cruel, faithful or faithless, forceful or weak,

and so on. No human being, and especially no ruler operating under political constraints, can possess and observe every quality held to be good.

He then distinguishes imagined regimes from the effective truth of political conduct. Anyone who abandons what people actually do for what they ought to do learns a route to ruin rather than preservation. Universal goodness is not safely available in an environment populated by actors who do not share that commitment.

The required competence is therefore conditional flexibility. A prince should know how not to be good and should use or withhold that capacity as necessity requires. He must especially avoid vices that would cost him the state; he should avoid other vices where possible, but need not fear their reputation when preserving the state genuinely requires them.

The conclusion reverses surface evaluation. Some acts that appear virtuous destroy the prince, while some that appear vicious produce security and well-being. Machiavelli is not erasing the difference between virtue and vice; he is denying that the public name of a quality reliably predicts its political effect.

The chapter therefore establishes three objects that later chapters will keep separate: the action performed, the quality attributed to the actor, and the consequence for the selected political continuation.

Organizational interpretation

Chapter XV replaces label-based evaluation with outcome-sensitive analysis. A public description such as 'generous,' 'merciful,' or 'faithful' does not itself reveal the dependencies created by the conduct, the conditions under which it operates, or the continuations it preserves and forecloses.

The distinction among action, reputation, and consequence is organizationally decisive. An organization may reward a visible quality even when the processes needed to maintain that appearance deplete resources or transfer costs elsewhere. Conversely, a blamed practice may preserve capacity that is not immediately visible.

Necessity is indexed to an objective and a field of constraints. Machiavelli usually selects preservation of the prince-state. That indexing explains why his advice works, but it also exposes its ethical limit: an action necessary for the ruler's continuation may remain destructive of subjects, rivals, or the larger organization containing them.

The capacity *not* to be good is a form of behavioral optionality. A ruler unable to depart from one fixed mode may lose the ability to respond when conditions change. Yet possession of an alternative does not make every use admissible. Admissibility still requires identifying whose continuation is selected, what burdens propagate to others, and whether less destructive alternatives remain available.

Critical-text verification (§§5–6). Inglese reads gli è tanto discosto da come si vive a come si doverrebbe vivere and impara più presto la ruina che la perservazione sua (p.

136), confirming the distance between actual conduct and prescribed conduct upon which the argument depends. More decisively, *Inglese reads imparare a potere essere non buono et usarlo e non usarlo secondo la necessità.* The repeated object pronoun in usarlo e non usarlo confirms that Machiavelli identifies an acquired capacity and its conditional exercise or nonexercise. Wikisource preserves this reading, while MetaLibri has *et usarlo e non usare*, apparently omitting the second -lo. The Lucid conversion therefore follows the critical text: the prince must become capable of not being good and must use or refrain from using that capacity according to *necessità*. Machiavelli does not say that the prince must always act badly.

Chapter XV is the methodological pivot of The Prince. The verità effettuale is the demand that an analysis preserve the organization actually operating rather than silently substitute an imagined one. AC&C sharpens the boundary Machiavelli leaves implicit: effective relative to which continuation, and at whose cost?

CHAPTER XVI - GENEROSITY AND PARSIMONY

Text and translation notes

The MetaLibri heading reads *Della liberalità e della parsimonia*; Italian Wikisource reads *Della liberalità e miseria*. The Lucid conversion follows MetaLibri. *Liberalità* is generosity or largeness in giving and expenditure, not political liberalism. *Parsimonia* is measured economy or frugality; it is not identical with avarice.

The opening turns on reputation: MetaLibri reads *la liberalità, usata in modo che tu sia tenuto, ti offende* - generosity practiced so that you are regarded as generous harms you. Wikisource's *tu non sia temuto* ('you are not feared') breaks the immediate grammar and the chapter's reputational logic; it is treated as a material corruption rather than followed.

Machiavelli distinguishes quiet generosity practiced *virtuosamente* and as it should be from the conspicuous expenditure required to acquire the public name of generosity. Here *virtuosamente* carries its ordinary evaluative sense. *Suntuosità* is visible, costly magnificence, and *facultà* means both financial resources and the continuing means or capacity to spend.

To *essere fiscale* is to become aggressively extractive in raising revenue, not merely to administer ordinary public finance. The prince must burden the people extraordinarily and use every means to obtain money. *Misero* continues Chapter XV's language of miserliness or withholding; *contennendo* means contemptible or little esteemed.

The statement that the parsimonious prince is generous toward the 'countless' people from whom he takes nothing and miserly toward the 'few' to whom he gives nothing is a rhetorical distributional contrast, not a literal census. It shifts attention from the visible recipients of gifts to the much larger population bearing or avoiding their cost.

Critical-text verification (§§7–10). Inglese reads El re di Francia presente ha fatto tante guerre sanza porre uno dazio extraordinario a’ sua (p. 140), confirming the MetaLibri

witness and preserving the present King of France as a separate example following Julius II. Wikisource instead reads that Julius undertook war al Re di Francia; *e ha fatto tante guerre*, thereby attaching the ensuing campaigns and fiscal restraint to Julius and eliminating the separate French example. That reading is not followed. The critical commentary identifies the “present King of France” as Louis XII and notes that, because he died on December 31, 1514, the phrase is potentially significant evidence for dating this passage. The Lucid conversion retains Machiavelli’s historically situated wording rather than silently replacing it with the king’s name.

The objection concerning Caesar introduces a phase distinction: a person seeking a principality may need a reputation for generosity, whereas an established prince is harmed by continually financing it. The later objection introduces a source-of-funds distinction: a prince must be parsimonious with his own and his subjects' property but can appear lavish with booty, plunder, and *taglie* - imposed contributions or tribute - taken from others.

The final contrast is exact. A reputation for miserliness brings disgrace without hatred. Maintaining a reputation for generosity eventually forces rapacity, which brings disgrace together with hatred. Machiavelli minimizes the politically more dangerous configuration rather than claiming that either name is honorable.

Argumentative structure

A reputation for generosity requires repeated and visible expenditure. Because true generosity may pass unrecognized, the prince who wants the name must omit no display of magnificence. The signal therefore consumes the resource that makes further signaling possible.

Once ordinary revenues are exhausted, preserving the reputation forces extraordinary taxation and aggressive extraction. Benefits have been concentrated among the few who receive gifts, while the many who finance them are injured. Poverty then produces contempt, extraction produces hatred, and the first hardship exposes the depleted ruler.

Parsimony reverses the feedback loop. By keeping revenue sufficient, the prince can defend the state and undertake campaigns without imposing new burdens. Over time, the absence of extraction can itself be recognized as generosity toward the many, even though direct gifts remain limited to the few.

Machiavelli answers apparent counterexamples by distinguishing political phase. Generosity can help acquire a principality or office because it builds reputation and followers. Once rule is established, unchanged expenditure destroys the resource base unless it is moderated.

He then distinguishes the ownership of what is spent. Lavishness with the property of the prince and his subjects is self-depleting. Lavishness with booty, plunder, and imposed contributions taken from others can strengthen military allegiance because its costs are externalized beyond the prince's own resource base.

The conclusion states the chapter's general mechanism: generosity consumes itself. Its continued public performance reduces the capacity to continue performing it and drives the ruler toward one of two politically dangerous conditions - poverty and contempt, or rapacity and hatred. The lesser danger is the reputation for miserliness without hatred.

Organizational interpretation

Chapter XVI is a feedback-loop analysis of reputation and resource depletion. Public attribution is not produced once; it demands recurrent evidence. When that evidence takes the form of expenditure, maintaining the signal progressively removes the material capacity on which the signal depends.

The distribution of benefits and burdens is asymmetric. A relatively small number of visible recipients can sustain the prince's image while a much larger population finances it through taxes and extraction. The reputation is locally generated, but its costs propagate through the organization.

Parsimony preserves continuational reserve: resources remain available for defense, disturbance, and future undertakings. It may look locally ungenerous to potential recipients while preventing a more general reduction in the population's available resources. Machiavelli therefore evaluates not only who receives, but who is not made to pay.

The acquisition/maintenance distinction shows that admissibility is state-dependent. A costly signal may help form a coalition during ascent yet become destructive once the task changes to preserving an established order. The same practice cannot be evaluated without specifying the phase of the organization.

The source-of-funds distinction reveals a darker mechanism. Externalizing costs can make generosity sustainable for the prince and attractive to followers while transferring destruction to people outside the selected continuation. Plunder may work for the army precisely because the victims' continuations are omitted from the prince's accounting.

Machiavelli selects the continuation of the prince-state and treats hatred as system-level feedback from widely propagated burdens. An admissibility analysis must retain that explanation while widening the scale: stability for the prince does not ethically validate extraction, tribute, or plunder imposed upon those whose resources and alternatives are destroyed.

For *Why Machiavelli Works*, the chapter supplies a compact model of political reputation: concentrated benefits, diffuse or externalized costs, a self-consuming signal, and delayed feedback through hatred and contempt. Its analytical force comes from tracing the mechanism rather than accepting the praised name of the quality.

Critical-text verification (§§1–2). Inglese’s critical text reads *De liberalitate et parsimonia* and *usata in modo che tu sia tenuto, ti offende* (pp. 138–39). These readings support the MetaLibri witness and the Lucid conversion. Wikisource’s *miseria* in the

heading and *tu non sia temuto* in the opening sentence are not followed because they disrupt the chapter's lexical and reputational structure.

CHAPTER XVII - CRUELTY AND MERCY: WHETHER IT IS BETTER TO BE LOVED OR FEARED

Text and translation notes

Critical-text verification (heading). Inglese reads De *crudelitate et pietate; et an sit melius amari quam timeri, vel e contra* (p. 143), confirming the MetaLibri heading's pietà and its complete alternative: whether it is better to be loved than feared, or conversely. Wikisource substitutes clemenzia and shortens the final contrast. The Lucid conversion follows the critical text.

Cesare Borgia's cruelty is said to have *racconcia* the Romagna - restored or put it back into order - united it, and brought it to peace and *fede*, meaning political loyalty or fidelity. *Pochissimi esempli* are not neutral illustrations but a very small number of exemplary punishments. The contrast between an entire *universalità* and a *particulare* explicitly compares injury propagated through the whole community with injury concentrated upon a particular person.

Inglese introduces the quotation simply with *E Vergilio nella bocca di Didone dice* (p. 144), confirming MetaLibri. Wikisource inserts an explanation that Dido excuses the inhumanity of her rule because it is new. That interpretively plausible interpolation is not adopted as Machiavelli's sentence. The interpolation is interpretively plausible but is not adopted as Machiavelli's sentence. The Latin is rendered: 'Harsh circumstances and the newness of my reign compel me to undertake such measures and guard my borders far and wide.'

To be *grave al credere et al muoversi* is to be deliberate or slow in believing and acting, not merely solemn. *Né si fare paura da sé stesso* warns the prince not to frighten himself through his own suspicions. Machiavelli then specifies a bounded middle: prudence and humanity must prevent confidence from becoming incaution and distrust from becoming intolerable rule.

Critical-text verification (§§9–11). Inglese reads *simulatori e dissimulatori* (p. 144), confirming MetaLibri and the Lucid conversion's "pretenders and dissemblers." Wikisource omits dissimulatori, thereby removing the distinction between pretending to possess what one does not and concealing what one possesses or intends. Tristi means bad, wicked, or morally unreliable in this usage, not sad. The severity of Machiavelli's generalization is preserved without treating it as an independently demonstrated anthropology.

The sentence about purchased friendships deliberately sustains a financial metaphor: they are acquired *col prezzo*, may be *meritate* or gained, yet are not possessed, and cannot be

spese - spent or drawn upon - when needed. 'Purchased but not possessed' keeps the contrast clear while the note preserves the older semantic range of *meritare*.

Love is held by a *vinculo di obbligo*, a bond of obligation, while fear is held by anticipated punishment. The conclusion's *a posta loro* and *a posta del principe* identifies who controls each relation: people love at their own choosing, while the prince can more directly control the conditions of fear. This does not erase the limiting requirement to avoid hatred.

The instruction to abstain from subjects' property and 'their women' retains Machiavelli's patriarchal formulation rather than normalizing it. *Patrimonio* is the inherited estate or material holding; *rapina* is plunder or predatory seizure. Machiavelli's point is structural as well as psychological: once extraction begins, reasons for continuing it remain indefinitely available.

In the military discussion, *fazione* is an operation or action, not a political faction. Hannibal's army is drawn from innumerable peoples and campaigns abroad. His inhuman cruelty operates together with his many forms of *virtù* to make him revered and terrifying. Scipio's *licenzia* is latitude exceeding military discipline, and his *natura facile* is a lenient or indulgent nature, not an intellectually simple one.

Critical-text verification (§§19–22). Inglese reads gli erano molti uomini che sapevano meglio non errare che correggere gli errori (p. 148): “there were many men who knew better how not to err than how to correct errors.” Wikisource adds d’altri, “the errors of others,” while the critical text does not. The Lucid conversion preserves the more general contrast. The final Scipio sentence remains institutionally important: a personal quality that would have damaged him in independent command was concealed and converted into glory because he served under the Senate.

Argumentative structure

Machiavelli begins by distinguishing the desired reputation for mercy from the consequences of mercy badly used. Borgia's reputed cruelty restores order; Florence's desire to avoid the name of cruelty permits Pistoia's destruction. The public name of the quality and the distribution of injury therefore diverge.

A small number of exemplary punishments may, in Machiavelli's accounting, prevent disorders that otherwise generate killings and robberies across an entire community. New princes face this problem most sharply because new states contain unresolved dangers. Yet the prince must remain deliberate, humane, and measured rather than credulous, panicked, or intolerably suspicious.

Love and fear are both desirable, but they cannot always be joined. Love depends upon another person's continuing sense of obligation and can be broken when private advantage intervenes. Fear depends upon a credible expectation of punishment. If one relation must be absent, Machiavelli therefore regards fear as the safer dependency.

The preference is conditional rather than absolute. Fear must be produced without hatred. Machiavelli locates the principal boundary in seizure of property and women, and he requires evident cause and suitable justification before proceeding against a life. Predatory appropriation is especially dangerous because it continually generates new pretexts and grievances.

Military command changes the relevant conditions. A heterogeneous army campaigning abroad requires unity, discipline, and readiness under good and bad fortune. Hannibal's cruelty is presented as the principal cause that makes his other capacities sufficient to preserve that organization.

Scipio supplies the inverse case. Excessive mercy produces license, mutiny, uncorrected abuse, and injury to the Locrians. The Roman Senate, however, contains the consequences of Scipio's disposition, so a harmful quality under independent command becomes compatible with his public glory.

The conclusion returns to control: a wise prince should ground himself in a relation whose conditions he can maintain rather than in one controlled by others. The whole prescription remains bounded by the requirement to avoid hatred.

Organizational interpretation

Chapter XVII evaluates a praised quality by the injury pattern it permits. Mercy can be locally gentle yet systemically destructive if it allows recurrent disorder; severity can be locally violent yet systemically stabilizing if it stops wider killings and predation. Machiavelli's *universalità/particulare* distinction is therefore an explicit comparison of organizational scale.

That comparison does not settle ethical admissibility. The prince's executions remain destructive to the people selected for punishment, and Machiavelli largely assumes the prince's authority to identify necessity and cause. A wider evaluation must include error, abuse, due process, alternative actions, and the continuations of the individuals upon whom exemplary violence is concentrated.

Love and fear are different dependency structures. Love depends upon an internal state retained by other agents and can become unavailable when their perceived utility changes. Fear depends upon the prince's accessible capacity to impose a consequence. Machiavelli prefers the latter when forced to choose because its implementation path lies more nearly within the ruler's control.

Hatred is the constraint boundary on that control mechanism. Fear may preserve compliant coordination, but hatred creates motivation for counter-coordination. Property seizure is particularly destabilizing because it propagates injury, remains memorable, and supplies an open-ended process through which the ruler can continue generating victims. This extends Chapter XVI's link between rapacity and hatred.

The Hannibal example concerns the coordination of a large, heterogeneous organization operating far from its ordinary supports. Machiavelli treats coercive reputation as the

relation that keeps discipline available across diversity and changing fortune. The organizational explanation can be retained without accepting inhuman cruelty as ethically admissible at the scale of soldiers, conquered populations, or the containing political order.

Scipio shows that a personal disposition has no fixed organizational value outside its institutional context. Independent command would allow leniency to propagate into license and uncorrected abuse. Senate government supplies a containing organization that absorbs or corrects what Scipio does not, concealing the defect and permitting the admired qualities to remain visible.

For *Why Machiavelli Works*, the chapter adds four mechanisms to the emerging model: public labels can invert actual consequences; reliable power depends on the location of control; effective coercion has a hatred boundary; and institutional containment can reverse the consequences of an individual trait. Machiavelli's diagnosis becomes most useful when those mechanisms are separated from his selection of princely continuation as the governing objective.

CHAPTER XVIII - HOW PRINCES SHOULD KEEP FAITH

Text and translation notes

Fede is a pledged word, promise, or faithfulness; it is not limited to religious faith. *Integrità* is uprightness or integrity, while *astuzia* is cunning. The opening contrast is therefore between conduct worthy of praise and conduct that has repeatedly proved effective.

Critical-text verification (§§1, 8, 14–15). Inglese reads realtà in §1 (p. 148), here carrying the sense of loyalty or good faith rather than modern factual “reality”; the Lucid conversion’s “loyalty” is therefore retained. The critical text also preserves *quando tale observanzia gli torni contro, sono spente le cagioni, non partirsi dal bene, potendo, and sapere entrare nel male, necessitato* (pp. 150, 152). These readings support the conversion’s conditional structure: departure from faith or goodness is tied to harm, exhausted grounds, and necessity, not presented as an unrestricted rule.

Machiavelli divides conflict into two modes: the human mode of law and the animal mode of force. The education of Achilles by Chiron, half man and half beast, becomes a figure for a ruler who must know both. The image does not erase law; it says law sometimes lacks sufficient force.

The fox recognizes traps and the lion frightens wolves. Neither capacity is sufficient alone. *Colorire* means to color, cloak, or furnish a plausible appearance for breaking faith. Simulation and dissimulation are practices of displaying what is useful and concealing what would be costly.

The five publicly valuable qualities are being merciful, faithful, humane, upright, and religious. Machiavelli does not simply advise their opposites. He says a prince should

appear to possess them, should avoid departing from good when possible, and should know how to enter evil when necessity requires it.

The contrast between eyes and hands distinguishes visible reputation from direct experience: everyone can see what a prince seems to be, while few can test what he is. *Fine* here is the publicly judged outcome or end of an action, not a general theorem that every end justifies every means.

Critical-text verification (§18). Inglese reads *e' pochi non ci hanno luogo quando gli assai hanno dove appoggiarsi* (p. 152), confirming the negative preserved by Italian Wikisource and followed in the Lucid conversion. MetaLibri omits non, which reverses the relation between the few and the institutionally supported many; that reading is not followed.

The unnamed contemporary ruler who continually preaches peace and faith while acting otherwise is commonly identified with Ferdinand of Aragon, but Machiavelli leaves him unnamed. The Lucid text preserves that anonymity rather than turning an inference into the text.

Argumentative structure

The chapter begins by granting the moral premise: keeping faith and living by integrity rather than cunning are praiseworthy. It then introduces an empirical counterclaim: rulers who have used cunning and known how to circumvent others have often accomplished more.

Law and force form a paired repertoire. Because law can fail against agents who will not honor it, a ruler who knows only the human mode is exposed to those who use the animal mode.

The fox-and-lion distinction turns force into a problem of diagnosis as well as power. Traps defeat unperceptive strength; wolves defeat perceptive weakness. Effective rule requires recognition and enforcement together.

Promises become defeasible when keeping them would injure the prince and the causes that produced the promise have disappeared. Machiavelli reinforces the claim by assuming reciprocal bad faith among people. This is a conditional political argument, not a proof that promises are intrinsically worthless.

Because flexible conduct can damage reputation, the ruler must manage appearances. The governing sequence is: retain the capacity for contrary conduct, display conventionally valued qualities, depart from them only under necessity, and make the departure publicly intelligible or difficult to detect.

The conclusion ties public judgment to appearance and outcome because most observers lack direct access to intention and process. Political support can therefore stabilize an appearance even when a minority possesses contrary knowledge.

Organizational interpretation

Organizations require more than a single preferred mode. Legal process, negotiation, investigation, enforcement, and emergency action are distinct capacities. A system that can use only one of them becomes predictable and fragile when its environment changes.

Promises coordinate future expectations across agents. Breaching one can preserve a local ruler in a particular emergency, yet repeated or poorly bounded breach destroys the shared expectation on which later coordination depends. The prince-state's immediate continuation and the larger system's continuing reliability are not the same objective.

The fox and lion are complementary control functions: sensing hidden constraints and possessing credible capacity to respond. Either without the other creates a characteristic failure mode—perception without implementable force, or force without adequate perception.

Reputation is a distributed organizational representation. It is formed from visible signals, repeated narratives, institutional endorsement, and observed outcomes. This makes it governable to a degree, but also makes an organization vulnerable when appearance becomes detached from operational reality.

Minority knowledge matters only when it can propagate, coordinate, or obtain institutional support. An accurate private judgment that cannot reach decision channels has little organizational effect.

Machiavelli's strongest operational distinction is between possessing a capacity for harmful action and making harm the habitual mode. Retained optionality can widen response; habitual deception consumes trust and creates adversarial expectations. Ethical admissibility still requires evaluation at scales beyond the ruler's survival.

CHAPTER XIX - AVOIDING CONTEMPT AND HATRED

Text and translation notes

Odioso and *disprezzabile* name different dangers: being hated and being despised. Hatred follows above all from rapacity and violation of subjects' property and women. Contempt follows from appearing variable, frivolous, weak, cowardly, irresolute, or otherwise negligible. Some of Machiavelli's vocabulary is historically gendered; the Lucid conversion preserves the political claim without silently endorsing it.

The prince has two broad sources of danger: internal subjects and external powers. Against external powers he needs good forces and allies; internally he needs arrangements that reduce hatred, contempt, and conspiratorial confidence.

The French *Parlamento* is a high judicial institution, not a modern elected legislature. Machiavelli treats it as an institutional buffer that can restrain the powerful, protect the people, and absorb some of the resentment attached to adverse judgments.

The maxim that burdensome measures should be delegated while gracious measures should come directly from the prince concerns attribution. It explains how offices can redistribute blame and favor; it does not make the burdens ethically harmless.

The Roman emperors introduce a third constituency absent from the simpler prince–great–people model: the soldiers. The soldiers demand severity, license, and rewards, while the people seek security from those same exactions. The exempla test rulers under incompatible audience demands.

Machiavelli's historical judgments are compressed and selective. Marcus, Pertinax, Alexander, Severus, Caracalla, Commodus, and Maximinus function as analytic cases inside his argument, not as complete modern biographies.

Argumentative structure

The chapter narrows the earlier list of qualities to two terminal political hazards. Other reproaches are manageable if they do not mature into hatred or contempt; these two conditions directly increase the feasibility of overthrow.

Hatred is reduced by respecting possessions and honor. Contempt is reduced by appearing stable, serious, courageous, and decisive, so that judgments become difficult to reverse and attacks appear unlikely to succeed.

A conspiracy depends on expected support after the act, not merely hatred before it. Popular goodwill raises the conspirator's projected cost because success against the prince may be followed by punishment from the people. The argument therefore treats conspiracy as a coalition problem.

Institutions can separate necessary but resented judgments from the personal reputation of the ruler. France's parliamentary arrangement is praised because it mediates conflict between great men and ordinary people while preserving royal authority.

The Roman cases alter the constituency structure. A ruler may be unable to satisfy both army and people; the correct response depends on which group has the greater capacity to threaten continuation. Machiavelli therefore judges similar conduct differently under different power distributions.

Severus is the central case of combined fox and lion. Yet Machiavelli does not recommend copying him without qualification: a new prince may imitate Severus's founding capacity, while an established prince is better guided by Marcus's restrained preservation of inherited order.

The conclusion is phase-sensitive rather than formulaic. Reputation, inherited legitimacy, military expectations, and the organization of coercion jointly determine whether severity, restraint, generosity, or discipline will preserve the state.

Organizational interpretation

Hatred and contempt are different organizational signals. Hatred measures accumulated injury and motivates opposition; contempt measures perceived weakness and lowers the expected cost of acting on that opposition. Stability requires control of both motivation and opportunity.

Conspiracy is a networked action. A participant estimates not only the target's defenses but the likely behavior of collaborators, bystanders, institutions, and the population after the strike. Broad legitimacy can therefore operate as a distributed protective capacity.

Property and personal security establish expectation boundaries. Repeated arbitrary violation expands the number of agents who regard organizational continuation as contrary to their own continuation. Fear may still compel isolated compliance, but it no longer supplies durable alignment.

Mediating institutions can contain conflict and allocate responsibility, but they can also become instruments for concealing accountability. Their admissibility depends on whether they genuinely constrain power and preserve recourse, not merely whether they protect the executive's reputation.

The Roman cases show that an organization may contain constituencies with incompatible objective functions. No communication technique eliminates the structural conflict. Leadership must identify which demands can be bounded, which capacity must be controlled, and what continuation is being privileged.

Selective imitation is a form of condition matching. Copying a celebrated act without reproducing its phase, resource base, audiences, and enforcement structure converts precedent into superstition.

The chapter also sharpens the scale boundary. Delegating blame or satisfying soldiers may preserve the ruler while increasing injuries borne by subjects. Political efficacy and organization-wide admissibility remain separate questions.

CHAPTER XX - WHETHER FORTRESSES AND OTHER DAILY DEVICES ARE USEFUL

Text and translation notes

Machiavelli introduces the chapter by refusing a single determinate answer. The practices under review—arming or disarming subjects, keeping territories divided, fostering opposition, winning over former enemies, and building fortresses—have produced opposite effects under different conditions.

Arming subjects normally converts them into the prince's own forces and signals trust. Disarming them signals distrust and often forces reliance on mercenaries. The judgment changes when a new territory is annexed to an older state: the acquired population may be disarmed while the prince's original forces remain armed.

Keeping conquered towns divided may ease control during peace, but division disables coordinated resistance when a strong external enemy arrives. What lowers local opposition can also lower the state's defensive capacity.

The claim that a ruler may benefit from creating opposition is reported as what 'many judge,' not delivered as an unconditional command. Machiavelli's narrower point is that overcoming visible difficulties can enlarge reputation when the difficulty is actually controllable.

Former opponents may serve faithfully because they must overcome prior suspicion; initial supporters can become difficult when they joined from dissatisfaction and expect rewards the new ruler cannot supply. These are tendencies conditioned by interest, not moral essences.

A fortress is useful when the prince fears his people more than foreigners and dangerous when he fears foreigners more than his people. Machiavelli's final rule is stronger: the best fortress is not to be hated by the people, because masonry cannot save a hated ruler when the population can support an attacker.

Argumentative structure

The chapter is organized as a sequence of conditional reversals. Each technique is first shown producing a familiar benefit and then placed in a condition under which the same technique produces the opposite result.

Arming changes allegiance by participation. Those who receive arms and responsibility can become the ruler's own organized capacity. Disarming communicates exclusion and transfers the burden of defense to a force whose interests may not coincide with the state.

Internal division trades coordination risk for control. It may prevent local coalition against the ruler in ordinary times, but it prevents effective collective defense in extraordinary times. The correct judgment therefore depends on the dominant threat.

Opposition can enlarge a ruler's reputation only if it is bounded and surmountable. Uncontrolled opposition is not a training device; it is a competing continuation. The text reports the practice while leaving its usefulness dependent on circumstance.

The analysis of old enemies and early friends relocates loyalty from labels to incentives. Former enemies may need to demonstrate fidelity, while early allies may carry unsatisfied expectations that make them harder to govern.

Fortresses are a final case of misplaced confidence. They can delay physical attack, but they cannot replace legitimacy, alliances, field capacity, or a population unwilling to assist the attacker.

Organizational interpretation

The chapter is an explicit warning against context-free best practice. A control succeeds only relative to the threat model, phase, resource distribution, and dependencies in which it operates.

Participation can integrate capacity. Giving agents meaningful responsibility, authority, and training may bind their competence to the containing organization; excluding them can create dependence on an external provider and communicate distrust.

Divide-and-rule is a brittle control. It reduces the ability of local units to coordinate against the center, but it also removes the same coordination when the organization must respond to a shared external shock.

Engineered difficulty can reveal or develop competence only when exposure is limited and recovery remains available. Leaders who create adversaries merely to display mastery can convert a reputational experiment into an irreversible organizational failure.

Formal affiliation is a poor proxy for continuing alignment. The better questions concern present incentives, unresolved expectations, available alternatives, and the agent's need to establish trust through performance.

Fortresses generalize to hardened controls, reserves, and procedural barriers. Such protections are valuable, but none can substitute for relationships that deny an adversary internal support. A technical boundary is weakest when the containing population wants it breached.

CHAPTER XXI - HOW A PRINCE SHOULD ACT TO GAIN ESTEEM

Text and translation notes

Stimato means esteemed, respected, or held in reputation. The chapter concerns actions that produce a publicly legible identity: great undertakings, unusual internal decisions, declared alliances, protection of economic activity, and visible participation in civic life.

Ferdinand of Aragon is presented as a sequence of campaigns that occupied the nobles, built military capacity, drew on church and popular resources, and continually supplied subjects with something consequential to attend to. The example explains political reputation; it does not validate every act.

Critical-text verification (§5). Inglese reads miserabile (“wretched” or “deplorable”) in describing Ferdinand’s expulsion and dispossession of the Marrani (p. 180). This confirms the MetaLibri witness and the Lucid conversion. Italian Wikisource’s mirabile (“admirable”) is not followed because it reverses the ethical sign of the sentence, transforming Machiavelli’s condemnation—né può essere questo exemplo più miserabile né più raro—into praise.

The prince gains esteem through rare or exemplary acts in civil government as well: conspicuously rewarding an outstanding action or decisively punishing an extraordinary offense. 'Rare' here is unusual and memorable, not necessarily morally admirable.

In a war between neighboring powers, Machiavelli prefers an open friend or open enemy to neutrality. A victor does not want a doubtful ally, and the defeated do not protect one who refused to share their risk. An alliance with a much stronger power remains dangerous unless necessity compels it.

The closing civic vocabulary includes commerce, agriculture, trades, guilds, and neighborhood or tribal groupings. The prince should make productive activity secure, reward useful enterprise, attend festivals, and meet organized groups while retaining the dignity of office.

Argumentative structure

Great undertakings create an intelligible public pattern. Ferdinand's continuing campaigns combine resource extraction, military development, elite management, and narrative attention so that reputation is produced by a sequence rather than by a single gesture.

Extraordinary internal judgments make standards visible. A striking reward or penalty can show that actions have consequences and that the ruler can recognize unusual performance or danger.

Neutrality is rejected because conflict reallocates power regardless of whether the prince declares a side. Open commitment can create obligation in a victorious ally and shared memory in a defeated one; neutrality often produces distrust from both.

The stronger-ally warning limits the preceding rule. Joining a power capable of absorbing you can solve the present conflict while surrendering the future. Such an alliance is rational only when avoiding it is no longer available.

Machiavelli admits that political decisions are rarely free of danger. Prudence does not discover a perfectly safe option; it recognizes the characteristic evils of the available choices and takes the one with the lesser evil.

The final movement turns from war to ordinary production. Esteem also depends on stable expectations that allow people to invest, trade, cultivate, assemble, and celebrate without fearing arbitrary confiscation.

Organizational interpretation

Reputation becomes durable when actions form a coherent sequence. Isolated publicity cannot substitute for repeated decisions that make an organization's priorities predictable to participants and rivals.

Large undertakings can integrate resources and attention, but they can also manufacture permanent emergency. Ferdinand's case therefore supplies both a mechanism and a warning: mobilization can strengthen central capacity while imposing severe costs on targeted populations.

The *miserabile/mirabile* variant demonstrates why textual control is part of analysis. A single word reverses the ethical sign of the example. Source comparison is therefore not ornamental; it constrains the organizational interpretation.

Open alignment reduces ambiguity but creates dependency. Before committing, an organization must compare the immediate coalition benefit with the post-conflict power of the ally and preserve enough internal capacity to remain an agent afterward.

Prudence under constraint is comparative, not ideal. Decision quality depends on making the harms, dependencies, and reversibility of each available path explicit rather than waiting for a risk-free path that does not exist.

Secure property expectations and visible support for productive activity expand the future actions participants are willing to initiate. Festivals and organized associations also maintain reciprocal legibility between center and groups, provided participation is not reduced to spectacle.

CHAPTER XXII - A PRINCE'S MINISTERS

Text and translation notes

Secretarii are ministers, counselors, and officials close to the prince, not merely modern clerical secretaries. *Appresso* marks proximity: these are the people placed near the ruler and entrusted with important affairs.

Machiavelli distinguishes three kinds of mind: one understands by itself; another recognizes what someone else understands; the third understands neither by itself nor through another. The first is most excellent, the second excellent, and the third useless.

The second kind of mind matters because a ruler need not originate every good proposal, but must be able to recognize sound and unsound counsel. Delegation therefore does not eliminate the ruler's requirement for judgment.

A minister who thinks more about himself than the prince and seeks private advantage in every action is not reliable. Conversely, the prince must honor, enrich, obligate, and share offices and responsibilities with a good minister so that neither expects to continue securely without the other.

The vocabulary of honor and wealth describes Machiavelli's mechanism of reciprocal dependence. It is not a general ethical defense of patronage, unlimited enrichment, or the suppression of a minister's independent judgment.

Argumentative structure

The quality of a ruler is first inferred from the people he selects and keeps near him. Appointment decisions reveal both judgment and tolerance: competent, loyal ministers indicate discernment; corrupt or incapable ministers disclose the ruler's failure to recognize or control them.

The three-minds distinction establishes a minimum competence for leadership. Independent discovery is best, but the ability to evaluate another's discovery is sufficient for excellent rule. A ruler unable to do either becomes captive to advisers.

The first test of a minister is objective alignment. If private gain consistently dominates the entrusted objective, the minister will redirect information and resources toward a competing continuation.

The second test concerns the institutional response. The prince must make loyal service sustainable through honor, resources, and consequential responsibility. Fear alone does not produce a stable ministerial relationship.

The chapter ends with mutual dependency: the minister should possess enough honor and office to value the present arrangement, yet understand that his position is tied to the prince. Machiavelli treats designed interdependence as the stabilizing mechanism.

Organizational interpretation

Appointments are diagnostic outputs. An executive's close team reveals what kinds of evidence, behavior, and competence the executive can recognize and what deviations the executive permits.

Delegation requires retained evaluative capacity. A leader may rely on domain experts for discovery, but must still compare claims, detect conflicts of interest, test consequences, and know when the organization's objective has been displaced.

The minister problem is a principal–agent problem before that terminology existed: authority and information are delegated to an agent whose private continuation can diverge from the principal's selected continuation.

Alignment cannot be demanded without supporting conditions. Status, resources, clear responsibility, reciprocal obligation, and credible future participation make faithful service more available; poorly designed incentives make diversion rational.

Machiavelli's solution remains prince-centered. In a modern containing organization, safeguards must also protect institutional purpose, lawful dissent, and affected participants so that mutual dependence does not become collusion between ruler and minister.

CHAPTER XXIII - HOW FLATTERERS ARE TO BE AVOIDED

Text and translation notes

Flatterers are an epistemic danger: rulers easily take pleasure in their own affairs and are deceived by those who confirm them. The problem is not simply bad manners but systematic corruption of the information reaching command.

Machiavelli rejects two extremes. If everyone may speak every truth without structure, reverence and decisional authority can erode. If no one may speak freely, the ruler receives only pleasing distortions.

The proposed middle course is to select wise advisers and give them freedom to tell the truth about matters the prince asks them about. The prince should ask broadly, listen patiently, deliberate for himself, and then hold firmly to the decision.

Ostinato can mean obstinate, but here the governing contrast supports 'firm' or 'steadfast' after due deliberation. The error is not reconsideration in light of new evidence; it is vacillation produced by unmanaged and contradictory counsel.

Emperor Maximilian is depicted as secretive about plans, unwilling to invite early counsel, and then easily diverted by objections when plans become visible. The result is repeated reversal and an inability for others to rely on his intentions.

The closing claim reverses a common assumption: good counsel, from wherever it comes, arises from the prince's prudence; the prince's prudence does not arise from good counsel alone. The ruler must possess the capacity to judge what is heard.

Argumentative structure

The chapter begins with the universal vulnerability of self-regard and asks how truth can reach a position of power without dissolving the authority needed to decide.

Selected advisers create a bounded truth channel. Selection protects the decision process from indiscriminate contest, while permission to speak candidly protects it from praise-driven distortion.

Questioning is the ruler's active responsibility. Advisers answer; the ruler compares, probes, and decides. A passive ruler who merely receives conclusions cannot know whether interests and omissions have shaped them.

After inquiry, consistency becomes a public good. If every later opinion reopens the decision, agents cannot coordinate their actions around it and advisers learn to compete through persistence rather than evidence.

Maximilian illustrates a broken sequence: conceal intention, omit early criticism, encounter late opposition, reverse direction, and lose credibility. Secrecy and receptiveness, badly timed, combine into indecision.

Because advisers possess their own interests, counsel cannot manufacture judgment in a ruler who lacks it. A prudent decision architecture amplifies prudence; it cannot substitute for the capacity to recognize evidence and conflict.

Organizational interpretation

Flattery is an information-control failure. When rewards attach to agreement and penalties attach to adverse evidence, reported conditions converge toward the leader's preferences while operational reality continues to diverge.

A functioning truth channel needs both authorization and scope: named people who can challenge assumptions, access to relevant evidence, protection from retaliation, and a defined point at which accountable decision replaces debate.

Question quality constrains answer quality. Machiavelli's design still depends on the ruler knowing what to ask. Organizations therefore need additional mechanisms for weak signals and unknown unknowns to enter review without waiting for a perfectly framed executive question.

Decision firmness is valuable only after a credible inquiry process and only while governing assumptions remain true. A controlled revision rule distinguishes evidence-responsive adaptation from reputation-destroying vacillation.

Late consultation is structurally expensive. It turns advisers into blockers, makes sunk commitments defensive, and forces public reversals. Early dissent preserves more options and lowers the cost of correction.

Advice architecture and leadership competence are complements. Better channels raise the quality of available information; retained evaluative capacity determines whether that information changes action coherently.

CHAPTER XXIV - WHY THE PRINCES OF ITALY HAVE LOST THEIR STATES

Text and translation notes

A new prince can become secure enough to seem *antiquo*—old or long established—when his actions are competent and publicly recognized. Conversely, a hereditary ruler can lose the advantage of continuity through present failures.

Virtuose means capable, effective, or conducted with *virtù*; it does not automatically mean morally virtuous. Good laws, good forces, good friends, and good examples are presented as mutually reinforcing signs of sound foundations.

The Italian rulers who lost their states share defects already analyzed: inadequate forces, hostility from the people, failure to secure the people after relying on the great, or failure to control the great after relying on the people.

Nervo is the sinew or effective strength of defense—the organized capacity sufficient to field a force and survive an initial reverse—not a literal anatomical claim.

The Macedonian example is Philip V, the ruler defeated by Titus Quinctius Flamininus, not Philip II, father of Alexander. Machiavelli uses Philip V to show that a ruler with military capacity and knowledge of his constituencies can withstand a stronger coalition for a long time.

Ignavia is indolent, cowardly, or spiritless inaction. The calm-and-tempest image criticizes rulers who never prepare for changed times and then expect the conqueror's misconduct to make their subjects recall them.

The chapter closes by distinguishing dependent hopes from durable defenses: only those defenses that depend on oneself and one's own *virtù* are good, certain, and lasting.

Argumentative structure

The first claim converts novelty from a permanent disability into a performance question. Current competent action can generate the equivalent of inherited legitimacy, while current failure can consume an inherited advantage.

Machiavelli then rejects *fortuna* as a complete explanation for the losses of Italy's rulers. A common outcome across multiple rulers points to common defects in preparation, force, and constituency management.

Philip V demonstrates that numerical or coalition superiority does not decide the matter alone. Internal strength, knowledge of the governed groups, and the capacity to recover can keep continuation available after setbacks.

The lost rulers reason only from calm conditions. Because they exclude the possibility of a tempest, they do not build the forces, allies, or popular relations that would remain operative when ordinary assumptions fail.

Hoping that an invader's injuries will make the population recall the former prince is a weak defense because it depends on another actor's conduct and on subjects choosing to restore a ruler who failed to protect them.

The conclusion restates the own-forces principle at its broadest. Durable security arises from capacities whose command, allegiance, and renewal remain within the continuation they are meant to protect.

Organizational interpretation

Organizational age is partly an achieved expectation. Repeated competent action can make a new arrangement predictable and legitimate; inherited longevity cannot compensate indefinitely for present inability.

Common failure across nominally independent units is evidence of a shared structural dependency. Blaming circumstance unit by unit can hide a common architecture that removes local recovery capacity.

Resilience is not the absence of reverses. It is the retained ability to field capacity, preserve constituency support, learn, and continue after the first plan fails.

Calm-time optimization creates a preparedness trap. When all resources are justified by present conditions, capacities needed only under disruption appear wasteful until the moment they become unavailable to build.

A recovery plan that depends on an adversary behaving badly or on injured participants returning voluntarily is not controlled recovery. It outsources the decisive transition to agents with different objectives.

'Depending on oneself' should be read as controlled critical capacity, not isolation. Allies and outside resources can contribute, but the organization must retain enough internal judgment, command, and implementation to remain an agent rather than a client.

CHAPTER XXV - HOW MUCH FORTUNE GOVERNS HUMAN AFFAIRS, AND HOW IT MAY BE RESISTED

Text and translation notes

Fortuna is contingency and variation outside the actor's present control, not merely good or bad luck. Machiavelli acknowledges the widespread belief that human affairs are governed by fortune and God, then preserves a domain for human action.

The familiar 'half' is approximate rather than a quantitative model: fortune may govern half of our actions and leave the other half, or nearly so, to us. Italian witnesses vary slightly in the approximation; neither wording supports a precise percentage.

The flood analogy separates unavoidable shock from preventable exposure. Flooding water is violent when it rises, but people can build dikes and embankments in quiet times so that later water is channeled or causes less uncontrolled damage.

Ordinata virtù is organized or ordered capacity. Italy is exposed because it lacks the dikes and institutions found, in Machiavelli's comparison, in Germany, Spain, and France.

Success depends on fit between a person's mode of proceeding and the character of the times. The same method can yield opposite outcomes in different conditions, and different methods can reach similar success when each fits its moment.

People struggle to change their mode because natural inclination and the memory of prior success hold them to it. A cautious person cannot easily become impetuous when the times demand it, especially while the old method has not yet visibly failed.

Julius II succeeded through impetuosity because his times favored it; his short life prevented the contrary test. Machiavelli's final image of fortune as a woman to be beaten or mastered is violent and misogynistic rhetoric. It belongs to the historical text but is not analytic proof and should not be normalized as a modern principle.

Argumentative structure

The chapter positions itself between fatalism and complete control. External variation remains real and can dominate events, but preparation and adaptive conduct determine how much variation becomes destruction.

The river is not controlled at its peak. Agency is exercised before the peak by shaping channels, reserves, and barriers. Preparation therefore converts some future contingency into a bounded condition.

Italy's vulnerability is organizational rather than metaphysical. The same fortune strikes elsewhere, but arrangements built in advance distribute and contain its force.

Machiavelli then moves from institutional preparation to behavioral fit. No mode is universally successful; caution, patience, force, and impetuosity acquire value only in relation to changing times.

Adaptation is difficult because disposition is persistent and success reinforces the method that produced it. Failure often becomes legible only after the environment has changed enough to make the former strength a liability.

Julius supplies a favorable but incomplete case. His method and moment coincide, yet the absence of an opposite phase means his biography cannot prove the method universally superior.

The conclusion rhetorically favors impetuosity because fortune is variable and youth appears more able to command it. The underlying analysis, however, remains fit and adaptability, not the universal superiority of aggression.

Organizational interpretation

Resilience consists in changing the shape of exposure before disturbance peaks. Reserves, modularity, alternate routes, practiced recovery, and institutional boundaries are organizational dikes: they cannot eliminate variation, but they can keep continuation available.

Preparation must occur while its need is contestable. Once the flood is visible, implementation time, attention, and free capacity have already contracted.

The chapter describes a competence trap. A method that succeeds becomes embedded in incentives, identity, skill, and reputation; the very evidence that once justified it makes abandoning it harder after conditions change.

Adaptive capacity therefore cannot depend on a leader spontaneously becoming a different person. Organizations need alternate modes, dissenting perspectives, succession options, and rehearsed triggers while the dominant mode is still successful.

Environmental fit is relational. Identical conduct can be capable in one phase and destructive in another, so evaluation must record the conditions that made the observed result possible.

The gendered closing metaphor attempts to convert uncertainty into an object of domination. A responsible reconstruction should retain the insight about initiative under variation while rejecting violence and misogyny as explanatory necessities.

CHAPTER XXVI - AN EXHORTATION TO TAKE ITALY IN HAND AND FREE HER FROM THE BARBARIANS

Text and translation notes

The title phrase *pigliare la Italia* is stronger than merely 'help Italy' but need not imply conquering it for private possession. 'Take Italy in hand' retains the sense of assuming leadership of a collective undertaking.

The register changes abruptly from analysis to prophetic exhortation. Moses, Cyrus, and Theseus appear in a biblical and classical pattern: an oppressed people supplies the *materia*—the material or human condition—in which a redeemer can introduce *forma*, an organizing form.

The unnamed figure who seemed appointed to redeem Italy but failed at the decisive moment is often taken to be Cesare Borgia. Machiavelli does not identify him, so the note retains the inference as uncertain.

The appeal to the Medici joins dynastic opportunity to ecclesiastical power under Pope Leo X. Machiavelli frames the house as favored by God and fortune, but also insists that God will not do everything and thereby remove free will and the human share of glory.

The Latin maxim means: war is just for those to whom it is necessary, and arms are sacred when hope rests in arms alone. It expresses the chapter's emergency claim; it does not independently establish the ethical justice of every proposed war.

Barbari is Machiavelli's polemical name for the foreign powers occupying and fighting in Italy. The term mobilizes an inside–outside distinction and should not be treated as a neutral ethnographic description.

In the military diagnosis, *ordini* are formations, arrangements, and systems of organization.

Critical-text verification (§18). Inglese reads *quegli che sanno non sono ubbiditi* (“those who know are not obeyed,” p. 206), confirming MetaLibri and the Lucid conversion.

Italian Wikisource's non sono ubbidienti would instead mean that knowledgeable people are not obedient, reversing the direction of the organizational failure. That reading is not followed.

Critical-text verification (§25). Inglese reads *il che lo farà la generazione delle arme e la variazione delli ordini* ("this will be accomplished by the kind of arms and the variation of the formations," p. 208), confirming MetaLibri and the Lucid conversion. Italian Wikisource's reading—"not the kind of arms but the variation of the formations"—is not followed because it removes one of the two coordinated sources of the proposed military innovation.

The occupation is said literally to *puzza*—to stink. The bodily word intensifies the closing appeal. Petrarch's lines then promise that *virtù* will take arms against fury because ancient valor is not dead in Italian hearts.

Argumentative structure

The chapter recasts Italy's maximum distress as maximum opportunity. Oppression makes a population ready for a new form, while the earlier chapters supply the qualities, forces, and institutional foundations required to make that form durable.

Providence and agency are joined rather than opposed. Favorable conditions and divine signs open an opportunity; human *virtù*, preparation, and command must still realize it.

Machiavelli converts dynastic address into collective purpose. The Medici are invited to make their particular continuation coincide with the liberation of a broader Italian subject.

The appeal then returns to military mechanism. Italy possesses individual courage and skill but lacks effective leadership and common *ordini*. Excellence in isolated members therefore fails to become system-level capacity.

Foreign military systems have complementary weaknesses: one formation is vulnerable to cavalry, another to infantry. Machiavelli calls for a third system able to synthesize what each does well and avoid what makes each fail.

The knowledge–command variant is central to the argument. Technical understanding exists, but it does not control coordinated action. The missing condition is not information alone; it is authority, obedience, and organization around that information.

The conclusion uses disgust, honor, providence, memory, and poetry to transform diagnosis into commitment. It seeks not merely to describe Italy but to produce the collective identity and willingness required for action.

Organizational interpretation

A collective subject can be partly constituted by address. Repeatedly naming 'Italy,' its injuries, its capacities, and its possible liberator gives dispersed participants a common object around which expectations may coordinate.

The matter–form distinction separates available potential from organized continuation. Skilled people, grievance, resources, and opportunity are material; command relationships, institutions, doctrine, and a shared objective supply form.

The chapter's diagnosis is high competence in the limbs and weak organization in the head. Distributed expertise produces little common effect when knowledgeable agents are not connected to authority, implementation, and reciprocal obedience.

'Own arms' here generalizes into internally governed critical capacity. An organization cannot free itself through a decisive capability whose allegiance, renewal, or command remains controlled by the powers from which it seeks independence.

The proposed third military order is a design response rather than simple imitation. It compares rival systems by failure mode, preserves complementary strengths, and creates an arrangement fitted to the organization's own conditions.

Mobilizing rhetoric has ethical hazards. It can simplify internal differences, convert outsiders into undifferentiated 'barbarians,' and use necessity to suspend scrutiny. Collective activation should therefore be evaluated for whose continuation it serves, what injuries it authorizes, and whether affected participants retain standing.

The exhortation completes the book by joining analysis to enactment. The preceding mechanisms become components of a proposed intervention: recognize opportunity, select an objective, create internal capacity, place knowledge in command, organize a constituency, and act before the opening closes.

COMPLETE SYNTHESIS: DEDICATION THROUGH CHAPTER XXVI

Across the complete work, Machiavelli repeatedly replaces moral labels and inherited titles with relations among conditions, capacities, constituencies, time, and the continuation selected for analysis.

Classification establishes initial conditions. Hereditary, mixed, wholly new, civil, criminal, ecclesiastical, free, centralized, and baronial orders do not present one generic problem. Their prior organization determines what persists after acquisition and what kind of intervention is possible.

Acquisition and retention are different phases. The opportunity, borrowed force, coalition, spending, or disruption that wins a position may become dangerous after the objective changes to continuing possession. Successful transition requires capacities fitted to the next phase, not only the last victory.

Prior organization persists. Laws, liberty, elites, memories, military habits, religious authority, and expectations survive nominal transfer. New command is never written onto empty material.

Controlled implementation is decisive. Laws, counsel, reputation, and plans remain fragile when the forces required to realize them are foreign, mercenary, divided, disloyal, or governed by another objective. 'Own arms' names internally integrated critical capacity more than literal ownership of weapons.

Constituencies create structural constraints. People, great men, soldiers, ministers, allies, conquered populations, and foreign powers possess different capacities and expectations. Some demands cannot be simultaneously satisfied; prudence begins by identifying the actual distribution of threat, support, and dependency.

Time changes detectability, cost, and available action. Disorders are easiest to treat before they are obvious; injuries and benefits behave differently when concentrated or repeated; calm is the time to build dikes; and prior success can keep an obsolete mode in place after its conditions disappear.

Reputation is a distributed political object. Observers infer capacity and character from visible conduct, chosen associates, institutional attribution, and outcomes. Reputation can protect against conspiracy and attract support, but an appearance detached from operation eventually consumes the trust needed for coordination.

Coercion works within a boundary. Fear may support obedience when force is credible and bounded; hatred enlarges motivation for opposition, while contempt lowers the expected cost of acting. Property, honor, discipline, and predictability shape where that boundary lies.

Information requires architecture and judgment. Good ministers, selected truth channels, early dissent, broad questioning, and firm decisions after inquiry connect knowledge to command. Advice cannot rescue a ruler who lacks the capacity to recognize evidence, conflict, and displacement of objective.

No method is best outside its conditions. Fortresses, division, generosity, mercy, caution, impetuosity, alliances, and even admired historical examples reverse their effects as phase and environment change. Machiavelli's most durable method is conditional comparison, not a list of universal tricks.

The final chapter turns diagnosis into organization. The exhortation attempts to constitute Italy as a collective subject, attach Medici interest to a wider objective, place existing competence under effective command, and design a third order from the failure modes of rival systems.

Political necessity remains objective-relative. An action can be instrumentally required for the continuation of the prince-state while remaining inadmissible to subjects, a republic, another polity, or the containing social organization. Explanation of efficacy is not endorsement of injury.

This is why Machiavelli continues to work as an analytic source. He identifies mechanisms rather than relying only on qualities: retained institutions, controlled capacity, coalition structure, attribution, information flow, temporal sequence, phase fit, and resilience to contingency. The organizational reconstruction is strongest when it derives those relations explicitly, preserves their scope, and refuses to convert descriptive effectiveness into automatic ethical permission.

Source note

Source documentation for the Italian witnesses, critical-text verification, and lexical resources appears in “Sources and Bibliography” at the end of Appendix B.

APPENDIX B — HJC AND AC&C IN THE PRESENT EDITION

B.1 PURPOSE AND SCOPE

This appendix identifies the limited portions of the Hoffman–Joyce Continuum, Admissibility Calculus, and Cohaerentia used in preparing and organizing the present edition.

It is not a summary of any of these frameworks. It does not reproduce their formal derivations, extend their claims, or attempt to establish them through Machiavelli's work. Its purpose is to make the present editorial and analytical procedures inspectable.

The three frameworks perform different functions.

The Hoffman–Joyce Continuum governs the desired communicative condition of the Lucid conversion.

Admissibility Calculus supplies the structural vocabulary and weakening procedure used in the organizational reconstruction.

Cohaerentia supplies distinctions concerning evaluability, constraint propagation, local and containing continuations, shared evaluability, and ethical admissibility.

Admissibility Calculus and Cohaerentia are collectively designated AC&C in this edition.

These frameworks are not inserted into the converted text and are not attributed to Machiavelli. They are later analytical structures used to clarify how the conversion was produced and what organizational relations may be recovered from Machiavelli's reasoning.

B.2 THE HOFFMAN–JOYCE CONTINUUM

The Hoffman–Joyce Continuum describes controlled movement among three principal communicative conditions: the Lucid Pole, the Hybrid Current, and the Dream Pole.

The present conversion remains principally at the Lucid Pole.

At the Lucid Pole, represented persons, actions, conditions, distinctions, and consequences remain externally traceable. Syntax makes their relations available without requiring the reader to reconstruct them through avoidable ambiguity, grammatical instability, or unexplained shifts of reference.

Three dimensions of the Continuum are used here: Fit, Phase, and Dissolution.

Fit

Fit concerns the correspondence between represented relations and the articulation through which they become available.

The target condition is high Fit between Machiavelli's Italian argument and its English realization. High Fit does not require mechanical similarity of words, clauses, or sentence boundaries. An Italian sentence may be divided, a referent may be made explicit, or clauses may be locally reordered when doing so allows the English reader to recover more faithfully the distinctions and dependencies available in the source.

Fit is therefore assessed relative to the represented relation, not merely to surface resemblance.

Phase

Phase concerns the movement of an articulation through changes of pace, density, emphasis, and relational development.

The conversion does not impose an independent literary rhythm upon Machiavelli. Its Phase follows the movement of his reasoning: classification, example, qualification, comparison, consequence, exhortation, or rhetorical intensification.

When Machiavelli becomes compressed, repetitive, severe, ironic, ceremonious, or affectively elevated, the conversion preserves the function of that movement while maintaining Lucid accessibility.

Dissolution

Dissolution concerns the degree to which stable access to represented relations becomes weakened, destabilized, or unavailable.

Dissolution is not introduced for stylistic effect. Ambiguity, instability, or incomplete determination is preserved when it belongs to the Italian source, but avoidable dissolution produced by obsolete syntax or unclear English reference is removed.

The conversion therefore does not make Machiavelli more definite than the source permits. It seeks to prevent the English articulation from becoming less evaluable than the Italian merely because the two languages organize their relations differently.

Qualitative Application

Fit, Phase, and Dissolution are applied qualitatively. Sentences are not assigned numerical scores, and the Continuum is not used as an automated conversion formula.

Its function is diagnostic and compositional. It establishes the target communicative condition and supplies a vocabulary for identifying where an English formulation has obscured a relation, altered the movement of an argument, or introduced instability not present in the source.

The Continuum does not determine Machiavelli's meaning, supply missing premises, settle deliberate ambiguity, or generate the organizational reconstruction.

B.3 Admissibility Calculus

Admissibility Calculus examines the weakest organizational and representational structures sufficient to preserve specified continuations and their required relations.

Only a limited set of AC concepts is used explicitly in this edition.

Selected Continuation

Every organizational investigation is conducted relative to some continuation being examined or preserved.

In *The Prince*, the selected continuation is often the acquisition, preservation, expansion, or recovery of a ruler's state. It may also be the continuation of a population, military force, institution, faction, alliance, governing office, or shared political order.

A measure may contribute to one continuation while injuring another. The selected continuation must therefore remain explicit. Calling an action effective without identifying what it effectively preserves can conceal the organization upon which its cost is imposed.

Organizational Distinction

An Organizational Distinction preserves a difference required for the investigation.

Machiavelli repeatedly distinguishes hereditary from new rule, internal from external force, popular from elite support, love from fear, concentrated from distributed authority, and present appearance from directly accessible conduct.

These are not merely descriptive categories. They preserve differences upon which later consequences depend. If the distinction is removed prematurely, the resulting political outcomes can no longer be adequately compared or explained.

Organizational Consequence and Dependency

An Organizational Consequence identifies what becomes available, unavailable, preserved, or terminated through a specified organizational relation.

An Organizational Dependency identifies a relation without which a selected continuation cannot proceed in the same way.

A ruler may depend upon internal support for entry, externally supplied arms for defense, public belief for legitimacy, magistrates for command, or a patron for succession. The continuation remains vulnerable while the required capacity is controlled by another organization or remains available only under conditions the ruler cannot preserve.

Continued Availability

A previously established distinction, relation, capacity, or result may remain available for later reuse.

The memory and institutions of former liberty, for example, can preserve the availability of a suppressed political continuation. Prepared defenses remain available when adversity arrives. Historical examples can make the results of earlier experience available to later agents.

Continued availability explains why an organization may resume a prior continuation even after its present expression has been interrupted.

Alternative Continuation

An Alternative Continuation is a distinct continuation that remains organizationally available relative to the conditions under investigation.

A displaced dynasty, retained republican institutions, a powerful faction, a foreign protector, or an independently commanded military force may remain available as an alternative to the ruler’s continuation.

Political security therefore depends not only upon the continuation presently governing, but also upon the alternative continuations that remain recoverable, supportable, or capable of attracting contribution.

Organizational Promotion

Organizational Promotion occurs when a result developed within one investigation, scale, office, or continuation becomes available within another.

The Church's inheritance of the territorial, financial, and coercive capacities developed under Alexander VI provides a clear political example. Achievements pursued for a personal or dynastic continuation became retained capacities of the larger institution and were available to successors who had not produced them.

Developmental Recursion

Developmental Recursion occurs when a promoted result becomes an available starting condition for further development.

Julius II did not have to reconstruct the Church's power from the condition preceding Alexander VI. He received previously promoted results and developed them further. What required exceptional action in one continuation became ordinary organizational availability in the next.

Admissible Weakening

An AC Weakening progressively removes articulation that is not required to preserve a selected organizational distinction, dependency, or consequence.

In the present edition, the procedure generally follows these stages:

1. A principal organizational result is selected from the chapter.
2. The named persons, places, events, institutions, and historically local circumstances through which Machiavelli articulates that result are identified.
3. Those particulars are progressively replaced by their functional organizational relations.
4. The conditions, qualifications, dependencies, and consequences are checked after each removal.
5. The operation stops when further removal would alter the result or leave it too indeterminate to perform the same analytical work.

Weakening does not mean softening Machiavelli's language, reducing the force of his claims, or removing morally disturbing consequences. It means removing articulation that is unnecessary for the selected organizational result.

Each postchapter section is therefore titled **An AC Weakening**, not **The AC Weakening**.

The postchapter sections present useful weakened articulations. They do not claim to prove that the resulting wording is uniquely minimal, irreducible, or the only admissible reconstruction of the chapter. The concluding formulation labeled “Weaker still” carries the operation further, but it likewise does not claim formally demonstrated minimality.

B.4 COHAERENTIA

Cohaerentia is used here to examine how political continuations remain evaluable within finite relational organizations and how the constraints imposed by one continuation propagate into others.

Only the following distinctions are required for the present edition.

Evaluability

Evaluability requires retained access to the distinctions, relations, conditions, and consequences necessary to determine what is occurring within an organization.

A population cannot adequately evaluate a ruler’s promise when the operative conditions under which he will abandon it remain available only to him. A prince cannot evaluate emerging disorder when reports become available only after the disorder has grown beyond remedy. A governing agent cannot evaluate counsel when advisers suppress disagreement or when he lacks the capacity to compare their recommendations.

Evaluability does not require complete knowledge. It requires sufficient access to the relations relevant to the continuation under examination.

Local and Containing Continuations

A Local Continuation preserves the objective of a participant or limited organization within a larger relational structure.

A Containing Continuation includes that local organization together with other participants and the relations through which their continuations interact.

A measure may be functionally successful relative to a ruler’s local continuation while damaging the containing political organization. Mercenary institutions may preserve the continuation of military providers while degrading the defense of the states employing them. Extractive generosity may preserve the ruler’s reputation among selected recipients while distributing its cost across the wider population.

Identifying the containing continuation prevents local success from being mistaken for organizational success without qualification.

Constraint Propagation

Actions taken within one relation can alter the conditions available to other participants and continuations.

A ruler's dependence upon foreign arms changes the capacities of his own soldiers. Property seizure changes the population's relation to future government. Factional division may simplify control during peace while propagating weakness into the organization's capacity for common defense. Political deception changes what other participants can evaluate and therefore which continuations they can knowingly support.

Cohaerential analysis follows these propagated constraints beyond the action's immediate objective.

Shared Evaluability

Shared Evaluability exists when participants in a retained common continuation possess sufficient access to the relevant relations and constraints governing their participation.

It is degraded when one participant controls information necessary for the others to evaluate the continuation, when public representation systematically conceals operative conduct, or when imposed conditions make alternative participation inaccessible without making that loss available for common evaluation.

Machiavelli's analysis of appearances, promises, institutional authority, and popular judgment repeatedly exposes political techniques that preserve a ruler's continuation by controlling what becomes publicly evaluable.

Functional and Ethical Admissibility

Functional Admissibility concerns whether an action contributes to a selected continuation.

Cohaerential Ethical Admissibility concerns whether that continuation preserves the necessary conditions of other continuations participating in a retained shared continuation.

An action can therefore be functionally admissible relative to the ruler and ethically inadmissible relative to the containing organization.

Agathocles may acquire and preserve political power through murder and betrayal. That functional success does not make his continuation ethically admissible. A prince may stabilize public belief through deception, but do so by depriving other participants of the information required to evaluate their own participation. A ruler may acquire glory

through an undertaking whose costs are imposed upon a population excluded from the continuation being celebrated.

Cohaerential ethics may be stated here in its limited applicable form:

Ethics concerns the regime in which the admissibility of one continuation becomes constrained by the necessary conditions of other continuations participating in a retained shared continuation.

This does not introduce a conventional moral code into Machiavelli's text. It identifies the structural boundary between preserving a local objective and preserving the evaluability and continuability of the larger organization within which that objective is pursued.

B.5 Separation of Editorial Layers

Four editorial and analytical layers are kept separate throughout this edition.

Layer	Function	Standard of answerability
Lucid conversion	Presents Machiavelli's argument in current, structurally traceable English	The established Italian source
Textual and argumentative notes	Explain significant terms, variants, references, conversion decisions, and Machiavelli's explicit reasoning	Textual, linguistic, and historical evidence
Organizational notes	Reconstruct relations involving continuation, dependency, force, institutions, representation, and evaluability	The stated AC&C analysis
AC Weakening postchapter sections	Remove unnecessary particular articulation while preserving selected organizational results	The chapter's recoverable distinctions, dependencies, qualifications, and consequences

The Lucid conversion remains answerable to what Machiavelli says.

The organizational reconstruction remains answerable to what can be derived from the relations he presents.

No conclusion generated by AC&C is permitted to enter the conversion as though it belonged to the Italian source.

B.6 Representative Conversion and Weakening Audits

The following examples make two editorial judgments inspectable. The first shows how the Hoffman–Joyce Continuum guides an Italian-to-English conversion. The second shows how an AC Weakening is stopped when further removal would destroy a relation required to explain the original result.

HJC Conversion Audit

Chapter XV contains the following Italian formulation:

Onde è necessario ad un Principe, volendosi mantenere, imparare a potere essere non buono, ed usarlo e non usarlo secondo la necessità.

A close relational gloss is:

The gloss is an expository device used only in this audit to expose the relations being preserved. It is not a separate conversion, an additional editorial layer, or part of the published Lucid text.

Therefore it is necessary for a prince, wishing to maintain himself, to learn to be able not to be good, and to use it and not use it according to necessity.

The Lucid conversion reads:

Therefore, a prince who wishes to preserve himself must learn how to be capable of not being good, and must use or refrain from using that capacity according to *necessità*.

Several conversion decisions are present.

First, *volendosi mantenere* is rendered as “who wishes to preserve himself.” “Maintain himself” would be verbally closer, but “preserve himself” makes the selected continuation more immediately available in English and remains consistent with Machiavelli’s contrast between *rovina* and *preservazione*.

Second, *imparare a potere essere non buono* is rendered as “learn how to be capable of not being good.” The formulation preserves the modal structure of the Italian. Machiavelli does not say that the prince must learn to be bad, or that he must act badly continually. He says that the prince must acquire the capacity to depart from conventionally good conduct when the conditions of preservation require it.

Third, *usarlo e non usarlo* is not rendered mechanically as "use it and not use it." In English, the pronoun "it" could appear to refer to badness itself or to a particular act. "Use or refrain from using that capacity" makes explicit that the object being conditionally exercised is the capacity just identified. The referent is clarified without adding a new relation to the argument.

Finally, *necessità* is retained rather than reduced to "need" or "circumstances." The retained term marks a conditional requirement imposed by the selected continuation and its operative constraints. It does not independently confer moral permission.

In HJC terms, these decisions may be described as follows.

Fit is increased because the English articulation preserves the relations among preservation, acquired behavioral capacity, conditional exercise, and *necessità*. Mechanical resemblance would leave those relations less accessible.

Phase is preserved because the sentence retains Machiavelli's movement from objective, to required capacity, to conditional use: the prince wishes to preserve himself; preservation requires an alternative capacity; the capacity is exercised or withheld according to *necessità*.

Avoidable Dissolution is reduced by replacing the unstable English pronoun "it" with its recoverable referent, "that capacity." No ambiguity belonging to the Italian argument is removed. The conversion removes only an ambiguity that a mechanically similar English articulation would introduce.

The audit does not establish the meaning of the passage through HJC. The Italian context and argumentative sequence establish the available meaning. HJC identifies where an English realization would preserve or weaken access to that meaning.

AC Weakening Audit

Chapter III describes Louis XII's rapid acquisition and loss of Milan:

For these reasons Louis XII, King of France, took Milan immediately and lost it just as quickly. The first time, Ludovico Sforza's forces alone were enough to take it from him. The people who had opened the gates to Louis discovered that they had been deceived in their expectations and in the future benefits they had anticipated. They could not endure the burdens imposed by the new prince.

The passage contains a historically particular realization:

- Louis XII is the acquiring ruler.
- Milan is the acquired territory.
- Ludovico Sforza represents the displaced continuation.
- Milanese support makes the acquisition locally available.

- Anticipated benefits motivate that contribution.
- New burdens make the resulting continuation unacceptable.
- Withdrawal of support makes restoration of the displaced continuation practicable.

The first weakening removes the named actors and place while preserving the political mechanism:

An acquisition that remains dependent upon internal support becomes unstable when the expected benefits of its contributors are frustrated and the burdens imposed upon them exceed what they will tolerate.

The formulation retains:

- acquisition;
- dependence upon contributing support;
- expected benefit;
- imposed burden;
- a threshold of tolerability;
- resulting instability.

The "Weaker still" formulation removes the specifically political articulation while preserving the underlying dependency:

Acquisition through contribution does not secure preservation after the conditions sustaining that contribution fail.

The second formulation applies beyond territorial conquest, but it remains strong enough to explain the result developed in the passage. Initial acquisition was made available through contribution; preservation remained dependent upon conditions sustaining that contribution; and failure of those conditions removed the support upon which the acquired continuation depended.

A proposed further weakening might read:

> Continuation is not secured when its sustaining conditions fail.

This further formulation is rejected.

It removes the distinction between acquisition and preservation. It also removes the contributor whose participation made acquisition available and the continuing dependency that survived the initial success. The resulting statement may apply generally to many failures, but it no longer explains the reversal developed in Machiavelli's example: the same contributed support that enabled acquisition became unavailable when its sustaining expectations were defeated.

The rejected formulation is therefore weaker in content but not an admissible weakening of this result. It has removed relations required to preserve the organizational consequence.

These examples also demonstrate the separation of editorial layers.

The Lucid conversion remains answerable to the Italian articulation and Machiavelli's argument.

HJC diagnoses whether the English realization preserves accessible relations and argumentative movement without introducing avoidable instability.

The AC Weakening does not replace Machiavelli's argument. It removes particulars while preserving an organizational relation recoverable from that argument.

The stopping condition is reached when further removal would leave the formulation unable to explain the consequence from which the weakening was derived.

B.7 Limits of the Reconstruction

The methods described in this appendix establish several limits upon the claims made in the present edition.

First, the organizational reconstruction is not part of the translation. It cannot be used as evidence for choosing an Italian reading merely because one variant fits AC&C more readily.

Second, the reconstruction does not claim that Machiavelli possessed the formal concepts or terminology of HJC, Admissibility Calculus, or Cohaerentia.

Third, the AC Weakening postchapter sections are selective rather than exhaustive. A chapter may preserve several organizational results, and a different investigation may select and weaken a different one.

Fourth, a weakened formulation is not treated as a substitute for its historical realization. Removing particulars makes relations more general, but the particulars remain necessary for understanding how those relations operated in Machiavelli's circumstances.

Fifth, functional explanation is not moral endorsement. Showing why cruelty, deception, coercion, factional division, or dispossession may preserve a ruler's continuation does not establish that the continuation is ethically admissible.

Finally, the proposed relation between Machiavelli's method and AC&C remains limited. His classifications, conditional comparisons, historical variations, analyses of dependency, and repeated separation of acquisition from preservation exhibit a proto-organizational analytical technique. The present edition makes that technique more explicit; it does not claim identity between Machiavelli's reasoning and the later formal apparatus.

B.8 Framework Sources

The Hoffman–Joyce Continuum
DOI: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17517550

Foundations of Admissibility Calculus
DOI: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21982239

Cohaerentia
DOI: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.18717795

The full definitions and derivations governing these frameworks remain in their respective works. The present appendix identifies only the concepts and operations used in producing and organizing this edition.

Sources and Bibliography

Editorial Use of Sources

The Lucid conversion and the accompanying notes were checked against the Italian text. The MetaLibri edition edited by Sálvio M. Soares served as the primary working edition. The Italian Wikisource transcription, based upon an 1814 Italian edition, served as a comparison witness. Material differences between these witnesses are identified in the chapter notes when they affect wording, argumentative structure, or interpretation.

The Vocabolario Treccani was consulted selectively to examine the historical and contextual range of Italian terms. Lexical consultation informed conversion decisions but did not independently determine the meaning of a passage; each decision remained answerable to syntax, context, and the movement of Machiavelli's argument.

These digital sources provide practical access to the Italian text but do not constitute a new critical edition. The present edition does not attempt to reconstruct the manuscript tradition or adjudicate every orthographic, punctuational, or textual variation among scholarly witnesses.

Historical examples are treated primarily as components of Machiavelli's argument. Dates, persons, and events were checked where their identification materially affects that

argument, but the organizational notes do not attempt an independent modern adjudication of every compressed historical claim.

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